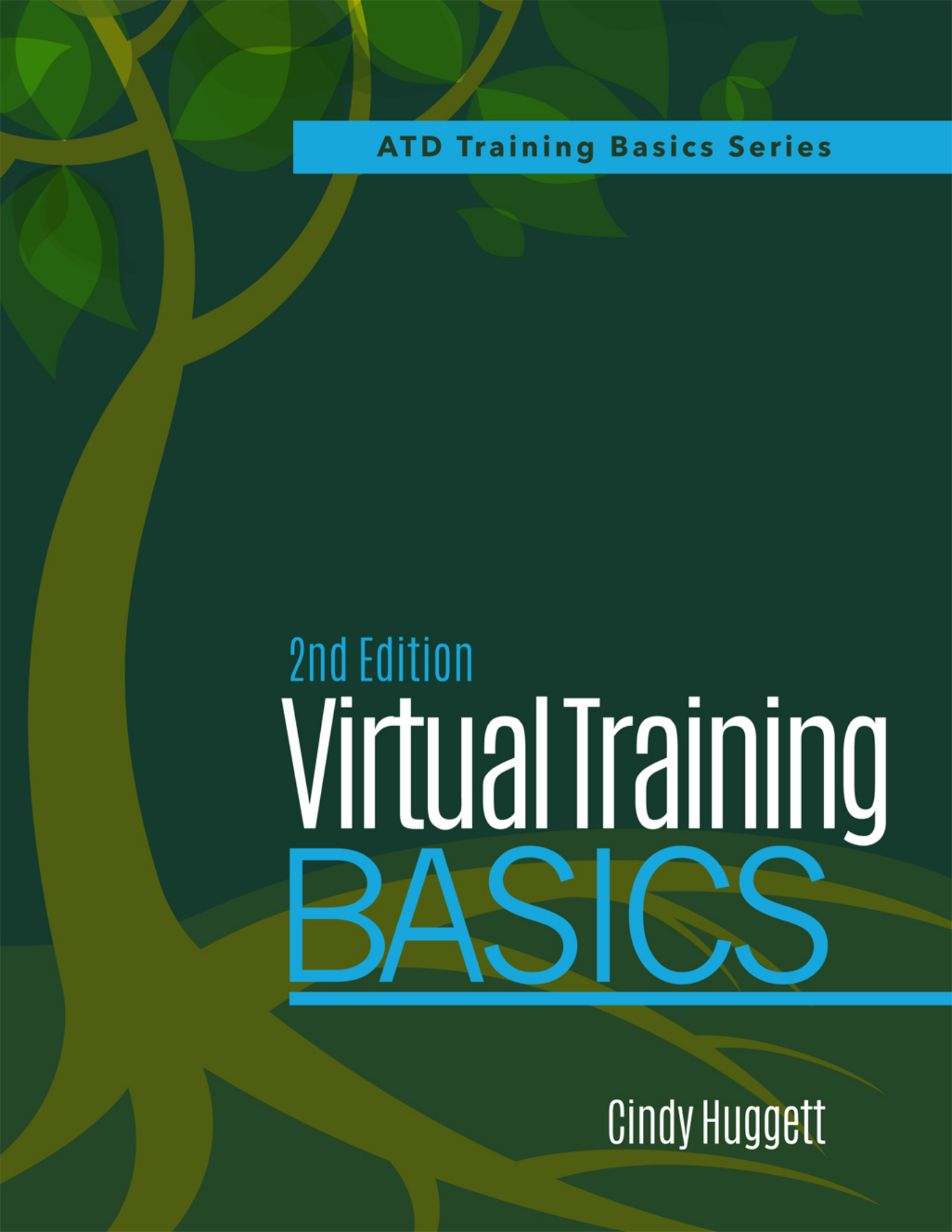


A stylized graphic of a tree with a thick, brown trunk and branches. The leaves are represented by various shades of green, some solid and some outlined, creating a layered effect. The tree is positioned on the left side of the cover, with its branches extending towards the top and right.

ATD Training Basics Series

2nd Edition

Virtual Training **BASICS**

Cindy Huggett

2nd Edition

Virtual Training

BASICS

Cindy Huggett



© 2018 ASTD DBA the Association for Talent Development (ATD)

All rights reserved. Printed in the United States of America.

21 20 19 18

1 2 3 4 5

No part of this publication may be reproduced, distributed, or transmitted in any form or by any means, including photocopying, recording, or other electronic or mechanical methods, without the prior written permission of the publisher, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical reviews and certain other noncommercial uses permitted by copyright law. For permission requests, please go to www.copyright.com, or contact Copyright Clearance Center (CCC), 222 Rosewood Drive, Danvers, MA 01923 (telephone: 978.750.8400; fax: 978.646.8600).

All trademark attributions are listed at the end of the book. Adobe Connect screenshots are reprinted with permission from Adobe Systems Incorporated.

ATD Press is an internationally renowned source of insightful and practical information on talent development, workplace learning, and professional development.

ATD Press

1640 King Street

Alexandria, VA 22314 USA

Ordering information: Books published by ATD Press can be purchased by visiting ATD's website at www.td.org/books or by calling 800.628.2783 or 703.683.8100.

Library of Congress Control Number: 2017962657

ISBN-10: 1-947308-64-5

ISBN-13: 978-1-947308-64-0

e-ISBN: 978-1-947308-65-7

ATD Press Editorial Staff

Director: Kristine Luecker

Manager: Melissa Jones

Community of Practice Manager, Learning Technologies: Justin Brusino

Senior Associate Editor: Caroline Coppel

Cover Design: Kay Hankins and Francelyn Fernandez

Text Design: Jason Mann and Francelyn Fernandez

Printed by Versa Press, East Peoria, IL

Contents

About the Training Basics Series

Foreword

Foreword to the First Edition

Preface

1. What Is Virtual Training?

Starting With the Basics

Moving From Traditional to Virtual Training

What Virtual Training Looks Like

Is Going Virtual the Right Solution?

Getting It Done

2. Virtual Training Is Still Training

Comparison Between Virtual and Face-to-Face Training

Training Skills Virtual Trainers Use

Getting It Done

3. Learn About Technology

The Basics of Hardware and Software

Files and Folders

The Internet

Telephony

Learn More About Technology

Getting It Done

4. Master Virtual Classroom Software Programs

Selecting a Virtual Solution

Comparing Virtual Classroom Software Programs
Tips for Learning a Virtual Classroom Software Program
Virtual Class Logistics
Common Features of a Virtual Classroom Software Program
Getting It Done

5. Prepare Your Workspace

Preparing Your Virtual Classroom
Computer, Internet, and Telephone Considerations
Setting Up for Success
Getting It Done

6. Get Really Good at Multitasking

The Connection Between Speed and Multitasking
How to Multitask
Getting It Done

7. Harness Your Voice

Overcoming Voice Challenges
Getting It Done

8. Engage Participants

Effectively Engaging Participants
Getting It Done

9. Practice, Practice, Practice

Practice Makes Perfect
General Practice
Getting Feedback
Dress Rehearsals
Activities That Require Extra or Special Practice
Getting It Done

10. Know What to Do When Everything Goes Wrong

Prepare to Prevent Problems
Stay Calm
Manage the Situation

Getting It Done

11. Design Interactive Programs

Define the Session Type

Review the Learning Objectives

Set the Stage for Interaction

Select Activities for Maximum Involvement

Close With a Call to Action

Create Materials for Facilitators, Producers, and Participants

Getting It Done

12. Present With Polish

Set the Stage

Start on Time

Sound Confident

Script Parts of the Delivery

Seamlessly Transition

Share Your Webcam

Show Your Style

Getting It Done

Glossary of Virtual Training Terms

References

Additional Resources

Trademark Attributions

About the Author

About the Training Basics Series

ATD's Training Basics series recognizes and, in some ways, celebrates the fast-paced, ever-changing reality of organizations today. Jobs, roles, and expectations change quickly. One day you might be a network administrator or a process line manager, and the next day you might be asked to train 50 employees in basic computer skills or to instruct line workers in quality processes.

Where do you turn for help? The ATD Training Basics series is designed to be your one-stop solution. The series takes a minimalist approach to your learning curve dilemma and presents only the information you need to be successful. Each book in the series guides you through key aspects of training: giving presentations, making the transition to the role of trainer, designing and delivering training, and evaluating training. The books in the series also include some advanced skills, such as performance and basic business proficiencies.

The ATD Training Basics series is the perfect tool for training and performance professionals looking for easy-to-understand materials that will prepare nontrainers to take on a training role. In addition, this series is the consummate reference tool for any trainer's bookshelf and a quick way to hone your existing skills.

Foreword

I once worked with a client who had a “Basic Tactics for...” class that he knew—from both experience and research—his trainees needed. Very few people signed up for it. After scratching our heads and doing more research, we figured out that while trainees needed it and—even better—they knew they needed it, they didn’t want their boss to know that they needed it, because they were already supposed to know that material. It was *assumed* that they knew it.

Before I share what we did to transform results, let me tell you why I think you’re smarter than the trainees in this story. One, unlike the employees in the story I just shared, I’ve never met a trainer who wasn’t hungry to be a learner themselves. Two, unlike the 100-year-old industry in the story, virtual classroom technology is relatively young historically speaking. It’s OK to be learning the basics right here and now. For *real* trainers, learning the basics is not a sign of weakness; it’s a sign of wisdom and strength.

I’ve known Cindy Huggett a long time because we’re both old pros when it comes to the conferencing technology that powers virtual classrooms. You’re in good hands. *Virtual Training Basics* is brilliantly put together. You’ll learn more stuff than you even knew to ask about; plus, the book’s organization itself reveals a lot about how virtual training works, and how to navigate the choices in front of you. Best of all, for a seriously scant amount of money, you’ll grow your mastery and add a new modality to your repertoire.

Oh, and the magic fix for the low response rate of the course in my story? Changing the title—and only the title—of the class to “Advanced Tactics

for....” The content didn’t change, but both attendance and smile-sheet ratings for the course increased.

You can add that one to your bag of tricks, too. Because if you’re smart enough to buy this book, you’re smart enough to beg, borrow, or steal a good idea anywhere on your own journey to mastery.

Enjoy!

Roger Courville
Chief Content Officer, EventBuilder
April 2018

Foreword to the First Edition

Only Perfect Practice Makes Perfect

The concept of e-learning in many formats has been around since 1997, as Cindy aptly describes in her first chapter. Age, however, isn't a precursor for maturity, and repetition isn't a synonym for expertise.

So while the training profession is moving into its second decade of "practicing" the concept of e-learning, and more specifically virtual learning, few of us have been "perfecting" our design and delivery. As Vince Lombardi said, "Practice does not make perfect. Only perfect practice makes perfect." Cindy gives us the tools in this book to begin to perfect our virtual training skills.

Why is this important? Most organizations are seeing an increase in the use of virtual training. Travel restrictions, budget cuts, and an increasingly technology-savvy workforce have led most organizations to rethink how they continue to meet the learning needs of their employees. Organizations are asking their trainers to deliver more content online. Trainers are expected to have the skills to design and deliver virtual training.

Unfortunately, the concept of virtual learning is still not very well understood by either organizations or practitioners. Virtual training often falls short of the quality standards expected in traditional settings. Most of these instances are due to a lack of appropriate design and limited knowledge of the skill variations required. It seems that many are still under the misperception that virtual training is simply classroom training set to a different tune. Although almost anything can be taught virtually, those who design and deliver training have not always attended to the translation

considerations for both the material and the delivery skills required. Cindy addresses these differences in a way that every reader will understand.

Too often I pick up a book about technology that is way over my head. I may be lost while reading the first chapter! The most unique aspect of this book is that it doesn't assume the reader knows anything about virtual training. It starts with the basics, including definitions and explanations of the necessary hardware and software. It walks us through every aspect of virtual training, from how to set up for a class, to what the trainer needs to know about technology, to what to do when everything goes wrong.

Cindy convinces us that virtual training is "still training" and requires us to tap into all the good things we do in the classroom. And she takes it one step further. She addresses the differences between classroom and virtual training, providing techniques to address the differences. Not only is this practical, but it gives us a calming sense of "I can do that!"

I remember the first virtual training that I conducted. It took me quite some time after it was over to realize that I had treated the session differently. I had thrown out many of the basics of good training, such as facilitating discussion and engaging participants, just because the participants were not in the same room with me. One of the greatest concerns for trainers is that they cannot "see" the participants. One of the most valuable aspects of this book is that Cindy describes other methods of "observing" participants that are available to the virtual trainer. There are ways to "see" your participants. I sure wish I had read this book before my first virtual training session!

Throughout the book, Cindy combines her experience with the experience of other training colleagues. She uses other virtual trainers' quotes to share tips and lessons learned. What I loved about these quotes is that they often present varying views. So even if her colleagues have a different approach from Cindy's, she presents both sides and allows readers to select what will work best for them. The 10 steps in this guide will prepare you better than any other book I've read for your role as a virtual trainer.

If you are searching for professional development that is practical, enabling you to put it to use immediately, you have found the right book. Spend the weekend reading and you'll be a more knowledgeable virtual trainer by Monday. The book is chock full of worksheets, activities, basic

rules, assessments, and checklists that ensure ease of understanding and implementing the concepts.

Here's a sample of the topics I found most helpful to perfect my virtual training skills:

- managing your virtual classroom time
- engaging participants in the virtual classroom
- juggling all the elements of virtual training and advice for multitasking
- asking well-thought-out questions
- giving instructions for group activities
- using your voice and speaking skills to enhance the participants' learning.

Cindy personalizes each of the topics through stories that illustrate her advice, making your learning come alive. You will feel as if she is writing directly to you when she asks a question you've been thinking about or when she highlights one of her slipups that matches one of your fears. This is Cindy's way of telling us that she has been there, too. She illuminates our learning by taking us by the hand and walking us through each of the concepts in her reassuring way.

The best reason for any product is to fill a need and Cindy has done that with this book. I don't think there is anything on the market that hits the mark quite like *Virtual Training Basics*. Cindy is an early adopter of technology, starting her training career as a software instructor. She has delivered hundreds of virtual training classes for more than a decade. She is passionate about developing trainers and helping them be the best that they can be. Who better to coach all of us to be better virtual trainers? You are in good hands with this book by your side and Cindy as your guide to *perfect* your virtual training skills.

—Elaine Biech

Author of *ASTD's Ultimate Train the Trainer*

Preface

So you've been asked to deliver training in a virtual classroom, and you don't know where to begin. Or you've delivered a few online classes, and are not quite comfortable with the technology. Or maybe you keep hearing that virtual training is the wave of the future and you want to stay current. If any of these scenarios describe you—congratulations! You've come to the right place. *Virtual Training Basics*, second edition, will help you deliver successful virtual classes. It is designed for classroom trainers who are migrating to virtual delivery. This book will also help first-time virtual trainers, and anyone who is asked to present or facilitate online.



Noted

We'll look at our definition of virtual training in more depth throughout the chapters; however, this book defines virtual training as a synchronous online event, with participants and a trainer meeting together at the same time, using a software program designed as a virtual classroom.

The Move to Virtual Training

Over the past decade, industry studies have shown a trend toward increased virtual training. ATD's 2017 *State of the Industry* report indicated that instructor-led online learning made up approximately 10 percent of all formal learning hours last year. While that may not seem to be a significant number, it has more than doubled in the last 12 years, when only 4.24 percent was reported in 2006.

Another interesting ATD research report, *Virtual Classrooms Now* (2016), found that 64 percent of all organizations were using some form of virtual training; of those who don't use it, 22 percent said they will do so soon. Most organizations expected their use of virtual training to increase in the future, with survey respondents citing reasons such as reaching geographically dispersed employees, building workers' agility, and saving on training-related travel costs.

While virtual instructor-led training is not the only online option available, it still represents a significant portion of training delivered to learners. More and more trainers are being asked to use technology in training implementations. Traditional classroom training is not going away; however, training professionals must diversify their skill set to stay relevant in the new economy.

Just because a trainer is effective in a traditional classroom does not mean they will be effective in the virtual classroom. It is a new delivery environment. Many trainers—especially those who are not technology savvy—need to learn the nuances of the online classroom. Virtual training delivery requires an updated skill set for trainers. This book helps both new and experienced classroom trainers get started in the virtual classroom.

So why a second edition? It's been more than eight years since the original *Virtual Training Basics* book went to press, and a lot has changed during that time. Technology platforms have changed, mobile devices are more common, and the Internet has evolved into a more social experience. When I first wrote *Virtual Training Basics*, virtual training was maturing as a delivery method. It wasn't new, yet it also wasn't commonplace. It was still a novelty to many organizations and trainers. Some organizations were early adopters and thriving in their virtual training success. Yet many organizations were fumbling their way through it, or avoiding it altogether.

Fast forward to today. As a whole, virtual training is a mature delivery method, but it is still evolving. Some organizations and industries are just getting started. Several of my clients have said to me, "You would think an organization like ours would be more experienced with virtual training." Another common sentiment that I hear is, "We tried it before but weren't very successful. So now we want to focus on it again."

The basics of virtual training have not changed much since I designed and delivered my first live online programs in the early 2000s. Much of what I wrote in the first edition still applies to today's virtual training

classes. The overall content remains quite relevant to training professionals, and even more so as virtual training adoption continues to spread.

Why This Book?

When I talked with fellow trainers about virtual training, the question was always the same—“How did you learn?”—which really meant, “How can *I* learn?” After having this same conversation over and over, it became apparent to me that a basic “how-to” book was necessary for those brand-new to virtual training. They needed a resource to tell them:

- Where should you start when learning how to deliver in the virtual classroom?
- How do you learn to deliver in the virtual classroom?
- What’s different about virtual training as compared with classroom training?

This book seeks to answer those questions. It represents my experience in delivering thousands of virtual classes over the years. It also contains advice and stories from my training colleagues. We hope you can learn from our consolidated experiences, and that they lead you toward becoming an effective virtual trainer.

Although this book is primarily written for classroom trainers who are new to virtual training, anyone needing to facilitate virtual events will benefit from the tips found here. In addition, trainers with limited experience in the online classroom may also discover new tips and techniques that will benefit them.

How This Book Is Organized

Virtual Training Basics is divided into 12 chapters. They can be seen as the 12 steps you should follow to become a great virtual trainer. Each chapter outlines a necessary skill or preparation step for effective online delivery.

This book's chapters are loosely organized in the order you should follow them. I say "loosely" because many of them occur simultaneously when you are delivering a virtual class. For example, "Harness Your Voice" ([chapter 7](#)) and "Engage Participants" ([chapter 8](#)) both happen during delivery. Some of the steps need to be done prior to the class, such as "Prepare Your Workspace" ([chapter 5](#)) and "Practice, Practice, Practice" ([chapter 9](#)).

While I recommend that you read and apply all the steps outlined in this book, if you are short on time, just look at the beginning and ending of each chapter for the basics. It's also OK to jump to the chapter you need, especially if you have done this for a while or just need help with a specific topic. You will find this book is full of checklists and worksheets to get you up to speed quickly.

Here is a brief overview of the chapters:

Chapter 1: What Is Virtual Training? There are varying definitions of virtual training, and it's important to know the options available to you as a training professional. In this chapter, we'll define what "virtual training" is, and what it isn't.

Chapter 2: Virtual Training Is Still Training. What's similar between face-to-face classroom training and virtual training? It's still about training! Improving productivity and getting better business results are still the goals. Technology is just a tool to get us there. You can rest assured that you still need training skills in the virtual classroom. In this chapter, we'll review the training skills needed to be a successful virtual facilitator.

Chapter 3: Learn About Technology. To be an effective virtual trainer, you need to be 100 percent comfortable with your computer, both its hardware and software. You'll also need basic technical troubleshooting skills. In this chapter, we'll focus on the necessary technology background when training in the online classroom.

Chapter 4: Master Virtual Classroom Software Programs. Just like a craftsman masters the tools of his trade, a virtual trainer must expertly know

the software programs used in online delivery. In this chapter, we'll cover the typical capabilities of virtual classroom software and how to use its features in an online class.

Chapter 5: Prepare Your Workspace. What a trainer does prior to each class affects its success. A virtual trainer's preparation includes learning the content and learning about the participants, as well as setting up the classroom. In this chapter, we'll go through a recommended preparation process, starting with your initial look at the material through getting ready for a virtual class.

Chapter 6: Get Really Good at Multitasking. Virtual trainers need to talk, type, and click at the same time, juggling the course material, technology, and participants all at once. In this chapter, we'll review 10 tips to be a better multitasker.

Chapter 7: Harness Your Voice. In the virtual classroom, trainers connect with participants using their voice. In this chapter, we'll consider ways to use your voice—and how not to use it—so that it's an asset to your virtual delivery style.

Chapter 8: Engage Participants. Trainers must engage participants in any class, and even more so in the virtual classroom. In this chapter, we'll learn how to get participants' attention and keep them involved throughout a virtual class.

Chapter 9: Practice, Practice, Practice. When you learn a skill, practice makes perfect. While you may never be “perfect” in the classroom, you will gain confidence and experience when you practice. In this chapter, we'll review practice tips and ways to get quality feedback on your delivery.

Chapter 10: Know What to Do When Everything Goes Wrong. Virtual trainers can and should expect technical challenges. In this chapter, we'll cover what types of things typically go wrong in the online classroom, and what you should do when these problems happen.

Chapter 11: Design Interactive Programs. Whether you design your own virtual training classes, or partner with a design team who creates them for you, it's important to know the basic rules of interactive design. In this chapter, you'll learn a three-step design process for engaging virtual classes. You'll also learn creative ways to use virtual classroom tools.

Chapter 12: Present With Polish. The difference between good virtual trainers and great virtual trainers is often found in a few small but

significant details. This chapter pulls together a series of techniques used by expert virtual trainers, who demonstrate how to make these techniques your own.

Each chapter opens with a quick access guide—What’s Inside This Chapter—to introduce you to the contents of the chapter. Use this section to identify the information it contains and, if you wish, skip ahead to the material most useful to you.

The final section of each chapter—Getting It Done—offers you a chance to practice some of the concepts discussed in the chapter and provides closing tips and pointers to help you apply what you have learned.

Icons throughout the book help you identify key points that can mean the difference between a virtual training success or failure.

Basic Rules

These rules cut to the chase. They are unequivocal and important concepts that form the foundation of virtual training.

Noted

This icon is used to give you more detail or explanation about a concept or principle.

Think About This

These are helpful tips for how to use the tools and techniques presented in the chapter.

Acknowledgments

I dedicate this book to my best friend and husband, Bobby Huggett. Without his love and support, neither edition of this book would have been written.

I give special thanks to the training professionals who willingly shared their advice and stories about the virtual classroom: Mike Abrams, Jo Cook, Lynne Hobbs, Kella Price, Sardek Love, Shane Smith, Kathy Shurte, Tracy Stallard, Jeff Smith, Rebecca Ward, Jim Wilcox, Joe Willmore, and Sharon Wingron. I am grateful to each one of you for your willingness to offer your wisdom. Your contributions have enriched this book. Thank you.

More special thanks go to Wendy Gates Corbett, my *Infoline* co-author and friend, for sharing her thoughts, suggestions, and insights on the content, as well as her virtual training expertise. Also to Tracy Stanfield, who helped review the technology updates for this second edition.

Finally, thank you to Paige Smith, Keri DeDeo, and Sherri Stotler for their thoughts on various parts of the manuscript, and to Justin Brusino and Caroline Coppel at ATD Press for their patience, encouragement, and advice.

Cindy Huggett
Psalm 115:1
April 2018

1

What Is Virtual Training?



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- common terms associated with virtual training
- guidelines for moving from traditional to virtual training
- what virtual training looks like
- how to determine if virtual training is the right solution.

What Is Virtual Training?

If you ask 10 different trainers to define virtual training, you will probably get 10 different responses. To one person it might mean a self-paced e-learning course, and to another it might mean a video conference. *Virtual training* is a broad term with many different interpretations.

In some ways, it's like the word *health*. When you tell someone that you want to “get healthy,” they might think you will be changing your eating habits. To someone else, it might mean exercising, getting more sleep, or losing weight. In reality, the full scope of the word *health* encompasses all aspects of a person's well-being: physical, social, emotional, and spiritual. Yet when people talk about their health, they are usually referring to just one specific aspect of it.

It's the same with virtual training. Virtual training is multifaceted, and could mean many things depending upon the context and who is talking about it. Because this book's definition of virtual training might not be your definition of virtual training, let's spend some time clarifying various elements of it and defining some terms.

Starting With the Basics

Training classes help people learn new skills. Traditional training classes have predefined learning objectives, are held at a set time and place, and are taught by a trainer. Participants register for the class, show up at the preassigned time, and leave with new knowledge and skills they can apply back on the job.

These traditional training classes vary in style, length, and format. They may be highly participatory or lecture based. The class size may be small enough for intimate discussion around a table or large enough to fill an auditorium. The class may be two hours or two days in length. It may be contained in a single meeting or span several months.

Virtual training has the same types of options. It can vary in style, length, and format.

The most common terms associated with virtual training include:

- online learning
- e-learning
- synchronous virtual classroom
- asynchronous training
- webcast
- webinar
- blended learning
- web 2.0 and social learning
- informal learning
- virtual instructor-led training (vILT).

Let's review each one in context, so that we can establish the boundaries for our definition of virtual training.

Online Learning Versus E-Learning

When computers were introduced into the workplace and our daily lives, we used them to automate processes and simplify routines. It was natural for training to follow suit. Trainers began looking for ways to automate learning, and traditional training adopted the computer.

At first it was called electronic learning, or e-learning for short, because it was learning using a computer. The term *e-learning* has since evolved to refer to any type of training that requires a computer. Some people use the hyphenated spelling—e-learning—while others run it together—eLearning. Both versions are still widely accepted.

After the introduction of the Internet and web browsers, trainers took advantage of this new technology. When you accessed training through the Internet, it was called online learning.

Many people consider online learning and e-learning to be the same thing. Online learning naturally requires a computer and therefore uses electronic tools. However, you can distinguish between online learning and e-learning by looking at learner interaction. It's a subtle yet important distinction.

Some online learning is self-paced, completed individually without any interaction with others. However, most types of online learning occur in

conjunction with other learners. Learners collaborate with one another and with a trainer. *Online learning* is an umbrella term that refers to all types of interactive training that use an Internet-connected computer.

On the other hand, e-learning more commonly refers *only* to self-paced or self-directed individual training. Participants taking an e-learning course would log in to a website and complete an assignment on their own. There is usually no interaction with other learners, or with a trainer. While the e-learning course uses a website, it is distinguished by its individual, self-directed nature.

Virtual training requires a computer with Internet access and has interactivity between the learners and a trainer. Because it's so similar to an in-person classroom event, it's often called live, online learning. Therefore, throughout this book, I will use the terms *virtual training* and *online training* interchangeably.

Synchronous Versus Asynchronous

Synchronous and asynchronous refer to the meeting time of the training session. In a synchronous training event, the participants and trainer meet at a set day and time. Synchronous training events normally use an Internet-based software program specifically created to host online meetings, events, and training. A participant in a synchronous training class would receive a welcome announcement such as, "Class begins at 9 a.m. Eastern Time on Thursday, August 20. See below for location information and directions for accessing the online classroom."

In asynchronous training, the participants and trainer do not meet at the same time. *Asynchronous* refers to self-paced learning that occurs over time as the participants' schedules allow. Common tools used in an online asynchronous training event include threaded discussion boards, email messages, on-demand videos, podcasts, and wikis. A participant in an asynchronous training class would receive a welcome announcement that might say something like, "Sometime before Friday, August 14, log on to our class website discussion board and post an introduction. Your first class assignment will be due by Thursday, August 20. Send an email to your trainer with any questions or concerns."

Both synchronous and asynchronous training events usually include opportunities for collaboration and interaction between participants. In a synchronous event, the collaboration happens together in real time; in

asynchronous training, the collaboration occurs intermittently over time. The two main differences between them are the software tools used to conduct the training and the timing of the events.

This book's definition of virtual training applies to synchronous online events only.

Face-to-Face Training Versus Virtual Training

When the participants are together with the trainer in the same room, it's called in-person or face-to-face training (sometimes abbreviated as F2F). When participants are separated by distance and meet online, it's called virtual training.

Virtual training can be audio-only by conference call. A training colleague recently told me that one of his clients wanted to do "virtual training." He assumed they meant an online synchronous delivery, only to find out they simply meant training using a conference call. However, most virtual training also includes a visual connection through a shared website or collaboration software program.

Some might consider videoconferencing to be a type of virtual training. Participants are separated by distance yet are able to see one another on a video screen. Sophisticated videoconferencing systems may be used in a corporate boardroom. Or a simple video connection on a mobile device could be used. One distinguishing factor between videoconferencing and virtual training is the audiovisual platform required to make a videoconference happen. In addition, videoconferencing usually has a group of people gathered around a shared screen, while virtual training has only one person per online connection.

The type of virtual training covered in this book does not include videoconferencing. Virtual training may or may not include video, and instead uses a computer's Internet connection and web browser to connect to a virtual classroom software platform.

In addition to the distinction between face-to-face and virtual training, "hybrid" classes are becoming more common. A hybrid class mixes in-person and virtual participants; some participants are in person and others are remote. The remote participants may be connected individually or they may be together, sharing a computer connection. Hybrid classes combine two types of programs—instructor-led training and virtual training.

Hybrid classes create a challenge for virtual trainers because some participants are hands-on with their computer, while others are not. That means the participants will have different learning experiences, and therefore may have different learning results. Some participants may be neglected because the trainer—consciously or not—focuses on one group over the other.

While hybrid training may be efficient in some cases, it's not a recommended solution because of its challenges. If you have to do it, take extra time and consideration when putting together the program design so that both audiences will be accommodated and the expected learning outcomes achieved.

A Successful Example of Hybrid Training

I recently facilitated an in-person virtual training design workshop at a client location. One of the key participants, a manager on the instructional design team, was on a work-from-home medical restriction. She wanted to participate in the program but couldn't come into the office to join us. So, we invited her participation using a virtual classroom.

To make this situation work successfully, we turned on the webcams so that we could see her and she could see us. I asked the in-person participants to connect to the virtual classroom so that everyone had a similar hands-on experience. For small group and partner activities, the remote manager was always included on a team. And as the trainer, I made extra effort to include her in all large group discussions.

Online Presentations, Meetings, and Webcasts

An online presentation, sometimes called a webcast, could be compared to an in-person seminar, where a presenter speaks to the attendees. There is little interaction between the presenter and participants, except for possible Q&A opportunities during the program.

I once attended a webcast sponsored by a well-known financial institution. At the designated start time, I logged on to a website and saw the speakers and their presentation slides. I estimate there were at least a thousand other participants logged in as well. There was limited interaction between the speakers and attendees, except for the ability for attendees to submit questions electronically. The speakers addressed a few of the questions during the program, but the rest went unanswered.

It was an expertly produced, informative webcast, but I would not consider it to be virtual training. If we had met face-to-face instead of

online, this webcast would probably have been called a meeting. It would have been held in a large auditorium, with the speakers on stage behind a podium and screens hanging overhead to display the visual aids.

While it is possible to create limited interactivity in this type of event, it's mostly just a talking head who is sharing information. This is not considered training in a face-to-face environment, and therefore would not be considered training in the virtual environment. A webcast is not the same as a virtual training class.

While many of the tips contained in this book will help you be more effective at leading webcasts and online meetings, our focus is specifically on virtual training.

Webinars and Virtual Training

Most people use *webinars* and *virtual training* interchangeably. The word *webinar* sounds like *seminar*, and it has become the word du jour for synchronous online training.

While most people do not distinguish between webinars and virtual instructor-led training, in my experience they have different intended outcomes and therefore are not the same thing. The goal of a webinar is to impart knowledge, while the goal of virtual training is to improve performance. This difference may seem slight, but it is significant enough to warrant discussion.



Think About This

A webinar differs from a webcast in two ways:

1. A webcast usually has a very large audience. The attendees stay anonymous and usually cannot see one another online because the attendee list is hidden from view. Alternatively, webinars could have any size audience.
2. A webcast has little, if any, interactivity. It's designed for one-way communication from the presenter to the attendees. Conversely, a webinar may have some interactivity built into its design. Webinars are always more engaging than webcasts.

Webinars raise participant awareness of a topic. They are used to impart information to the attendees. For example, if a corporate human resources department needed to share information with employees about an upcoming annual benefit enrollment period, it may choose to share that information in

a webinar. This webinar could include interactivity, with polling questions and chat, but it would not be considered a training class. While webinars may have two-way communication between presenter and participants, they may or may not ultimately result in the participants' behavior changing or have an impact on participants' performance after the event. Webinars are simply an online opportunity to interactively share information.

Webinars are helpful and useful in the right context. They have their place and purpose. There are times when participants simply need to gain awareness of new information, and interactivity will help communicate it. Most of the tips covered in this book will be as useful to a webinar facilitator as to a trainer leading a virtual class.

A virtual training class is different from a webinar because it has predefined learning objectives. These objectives are tied to performance outcomes. And ideally, these performance outcomes will have a positive impact on business results. During a virtual training class, the trainer will check for knowledge transfer. In addition, participants will have an opportunity to practice and apply their new skills.

Even though *webinar* is a popular term and many people use it to describe virtual training, this book will distinguish between them and focus on virtual training.

Refer to [Table 1-1](#) to help you distinguish between a webcast, a webinar, and virtual training.

Table 1-1. Differences Between a Webcast, a Webinar, and Virtual Training

	Webcast	Webinar	Virtual Training
Relative size of audience	Large	Any size	Small
Interactivity?	No	Yes	Yes
Predefined, performance-based learning objectives?	No	Usually not	Yes
Face-to-face equivalent	Presentation or meeting	Seminar	Training class



Think About This

Webinar and *webcast* are popular terms, and many people use them to describe virtual training interchangeably. Ask about the intended outcome of the event so that you share a mutual understanding.

Blended Learning

When a training class combines multiple delivery methods, it's considered blended learning. A blended learning solution might include a mix of traditional face-to-face classes, coaching, and participation in a discussion board. Or, it could be a series of synchronous online training events with self-paced assignments in between. Even assigning a reading before coming to class could be considered blended learning. It is a “blend” of various activities to achieve a learning outcome.

Blended learning usually takes place over time—several weeks or even several months. For instance, if a new employee orientation program took place in a blended format, it might look like this: Employees receive a packet in the mail containing materials to read prior to class. They are directed to log on to a website and post an introduction message on the company's new hire discussion board. On their first day of work, they attend a face-to-face, instructor-led class. Afterward, they are given two homework assignments to complete. These activities make up the overall blended new hire orientation.

Many years ago, I facilitated a leadership class for a group of managers who were dispersed in many locations. I used a blended format for the program. It spanned six months and included a series of self-paced e-learning courses with assignments in between. In addition, we met every three weeks in a synchronous virtual classroom so the managers could collaborate to practice new skills and compare their notes. By the end of the program, the managers had completed approximately 26 hours of training through the various activities.

Virtual training is frequently one component of a larger blended learning curriculum.

Web 2.0 and Social Learning

The Internet was originally called the World Wide Web because it allowed computers to connect to one another in patterns reminiscent of a spider web (notice the *www* at the beginning of many Internet addresses). It was commonly referred to in its abbreviated form, the web.

Even though the underlying technology of the Internet has not changed much since its inception, the way we use the Internet has evolved. In the early 2000s, as functionality increased and Internet usage spread, people started sharing content and interacting with one another. Websites and programs that allowed this type of user-generated content became known as the second generation of Internet, or web 2.0.

Internet sites like Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube allow users to share content and comment on one another's posts. Internal corporate sites like Yammer and Chatter allow for similar sharing, but behind greater security protections. These types of sites have changed the way we use the Internet. It has shifted from viewing static information pages to collaborating and sharing among users.

Because of their collaboration and information-sharing properties, web programs that can be used for social learning are a fertile source of learning possibilities. For example, a class could have a sharing site set up, and ask participants to introduce themselves to one another before attending a virtual training class. Or, during a virtual class series, participants could ask questions and collaborate in between sessions. One of my colleagues regularly uses a social collaboration site to post discussion and reflection questions after her virtual training classes to help participants apply what they've learned. The possibilities for shared social learning using these Internet collaboration tools is endless.

Informal Learning

Much of what someone learns takes place outside the formal classroom. This is called informal learning, which can be on-the-job training, where someone learns by doing; reading a book; or asking a colleague for assistance. Most informal learning is not captured or recorded as training. It simply happens out of necessity. In fact, it's estimated that more than 80 percent of the way people learn their jobs is informal (Cross 2015).

Informal learning is in our virtual training vocabulary because of its relationship to the Internet. Much of it takes place online as learners visit websites and collaborate with one another.

For example, I once needed to learn more about digital audio recording devices. I searched the web for information and learned a little about them in the process. I also found a tweet about a recording device, and contacted the person who wrote it. He recommended one of his colleagues with expertise in these types of devices, so I followed up with that person. We connected first on Twitter and then by telephone. Through these connections, I learned enough about the devices to complete the task I needed to do without ever participating in a formal training event.

Informal learning should be on the minds of trainers who are paying attention to trends in workplace talent development. Informal learning significantly influences organizational knowledge and employee performance. However, it is beyond the scope of what we'll focus on in this book. Our definition of virtual training will stay in the synchronous online classroom.

Virtual Instructor-Led Training

So, what is virtual training? As I've mentioned, virtual training occurs as a synchronous online event, with participants and a trainer meeting together at the same time. Because a training professional facilitates the event, it is sometimes called virtual instructor-led training, or vILT.

Virtual training uses a software program specifically designed for real-time collaboration on the web. This software application is called a virtual classroom. We'll cover the intricacies of virtual classroom programs in [chapter 4](#). Some common virtual classroom programs are:

- Adobe Connect
- AirClass by Lenovo
- Blackboard Collaborate
- Cisco WebEx Training Center
- GoToTraining
- Jigsaw
- Saba Virtual Classroom
- Zoom.

Virtual training can be a one-time event or part of a blended learning solution. It has learning objectives and performance-driven outcomes. The participants attend to acquire new knowledge, close a performance gap, and practice new skills.

Remember, virtual training is not a meeting held over videoconference. Nor is it a webcast or a self-paced web course. Virtual training is also not traditional classroom training transferred to the web. It has more nuances than a face-to-face class and a different set of interaction dynamics.



Basic Rule 1

The term *virtual training* has many meanings. When discussing virtual training with someone, ensure that you're using the same definition. Ask questions to understand what they mean when they say virtual training.

Moving From Traditional to Virtual Training

If you are asked to take the material from a physical classroom training course and deliver it in the online classroom, make sure to do it properly. It's not a matter of just moving slides from the classroom projector to the virtual platform, nor is it a one-to-one translation of activities or of time. Some face-to-face activities simply don't make sense online. And one minute of classroom time does not equal one minute of virtual classroom time.

For more information about designing virtual classes, see [chapter 11](#). See [Table 1-2](#) for a comparison between a traditional face-to-face class and a synchronous virtual training class.

Table 1-2. Differences Between Face-to-Face and Virtual Training

	Traditional Face-to-Face	Synchronous Virtual
Based on learning objectives and performance outcomes	✓	✓
Participants and the trainer meet at the same time	✓	✓
Participants are dispersed in various geographic locations during the event		✓
Participants connect to the class using a computer with an Internet connection		✓
Can be part of a blended learning solution	✓	✓

What Virtual Training Looks Like

When I describe virtual training to people not familiar with it, it's hard for them to visualize the experience. Here's a quick snapshot:

Michelle is a trainer for a large telecommunications company. She's located in Cincinnati, Ohio. She schedules a 60-minute virtual class for Thursday at 11 a.m. ET. About a week prior to the training date, she sends a welcome email message with instructions and confirmation of logistics to her participants. About an hour prior to the start time, she sits at her office desk, logs in to the virtual classroom software, and gets ready for the event. She uploads her slides (if they were not set up already), opens the first polling question, and prepares the virtual whiteboard. She completes all her preclass preparation and waits for everyone to arrive.

Around 10:50 a.m., the participants start entering the classroom. They do this from the comfort of their respective offices: sitting at their desks,

opening up Internet browsers, and clicking on the link from Michelle's email message.

One participant, Moira, is in her office in Dallas, Texas. She clicks on the link and goes straight to the login page. She types in her name and email address, and waits for the classroom software to load on her screen. Once connected to the virtual classroom, she dials the telephone number seen in the onscreen dialog box, and enters the conference call passcode and her unique ID when prompted. Moira hears Michelle's voice on the line, and says hello to greet her. The other participants follow the same steps to join the class.

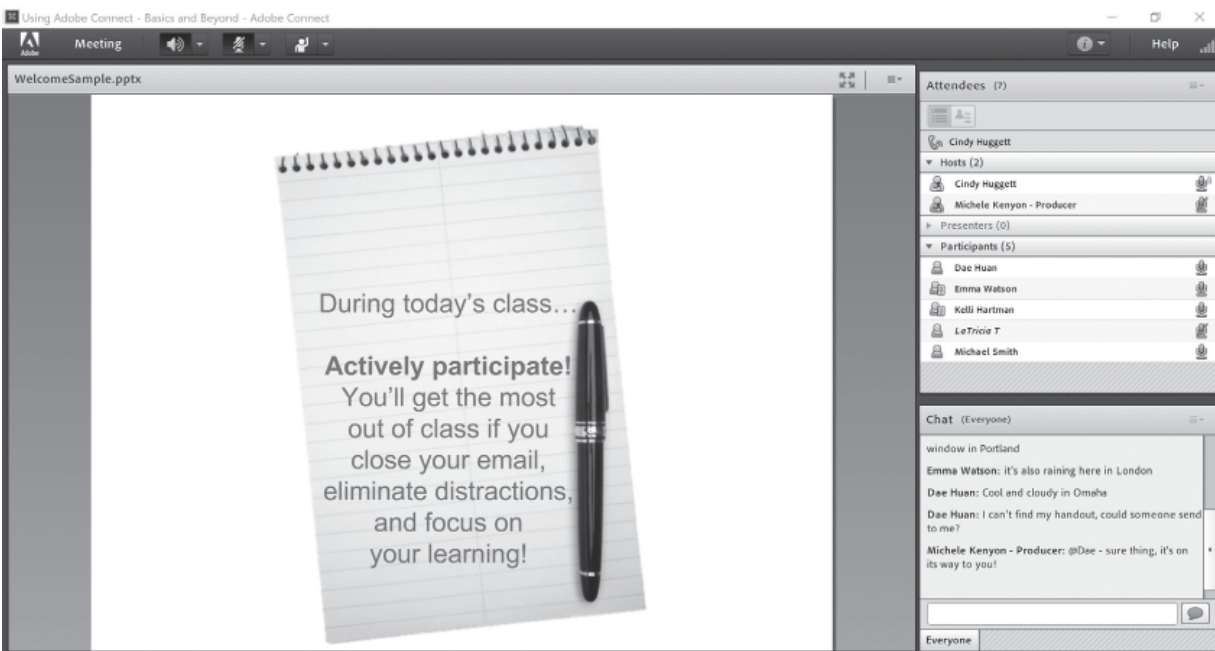
The participants are able to see what Michelle has prepared for them on the screen (see [Figure 1-1](#) for an example). They see the names of the other attendees, slides, and a chat area. They are also likely to see an introductory activity, inviting them to engage right away.

The participants speak with one another over the audio connection; they can also type in the chat area or use the drawing tools. Throughout the class, Michelle asks them to respond to poll questions, type onscreen for input, and participate in activities. At one point, Michelle assigns the participants into virtual breakout groups, and Moira is able to talk privately with her partner, Julie. They practice one of the new skills before returning to the large group for a brief discussion.

By 12 p.m., class finishes, and Michelle asks everyone to complete a follow-up assignment to apply what they've just learned.

As you can see, there seem to be many similarities between a virtual class and a face-to-face one. Each class is scheduled for a specific time, and participants are engaged through activities and exercises. However, participants in a virtual session typically don't leave their workspace to attend, and they usually cannot see one another during class. Also, virtual classes tend to be shorter in length than their face-to-face counterparts.

Figure 1-1. Sample Virtual Training Classroom Using Adobe Connect



Keep in mind that not every virtual training class is exactly like the one just described. This story simply illustrates a typical experience for the trainer and participants.

Is Going Virtual the Right Solution?

As mentioned earlier, many organizations see virtual training as an opportunity to save time and money. There's no need for participants to travel or even leave their workspace to attend training. Virtual training is convenient and can be cost effective.

But is it really the right solution for your training need? This is a question that every training professional should ask before implementing a virtual training solution. To determine if virtual training is the correct delivery method, consider these questions:

- 1. Are the participants centrally located or dispersed?** If your organization is not going to save on travel expenses because everyone is in the same location, then stick with face-to-face training. It may be just as fast for them to walk down the hallway to

your training room as it would be for them to log in to a virtual classroom.

2. **Do all participants speak the same language?** Virtual training is a great way to provide training to an international population, as long as language barriers don't get in the way.
3. **Will every participant have an appropriate learning environment?** Participants need to have their own computer, Internet connection, and telephone line to attend the virtual event. They should be in a quiet area conducive to learning. If they are in an open space or cubicle environment, they will need headphones or another way to tune out external noise.
4. **What technology barriers will affect success?** Participants need to have the appropriate technology available to them. The exact technology needed will vary depending upon the virtual software program used; however, a typical technology setup requires a high-speed Internet connection, a sound card and speakers to hear streaming media, and administrative privileges to install software.

When virtual training is done well, it can strengthen an organization because participants from various departments and multiple locations build relationships in the classroom. They might realize that other participants are dealing with the same types of problems they are, and therefore they might be able to more easily relate to one another. Virtual training can break down regional and departmental silos when participants from various locations collaborate. When virtual training is done well, it can lead to increased communication and, in turn, more effective business results.

Unfortunately, some trainers implement virtual training in situations that do not make sense. For instance, one organization wanted to save on conference-call costs by having everyone bring their laptop to a conference meeting room so they could share a speakerphone. This setup reduces participation because it prevents appropriate breakout groups and makes it difficult to hear anyone speak. Another organization had participants attend using a computer on an open table in the frequently used employee break room. Participants reported so many external distractions that they could not stay focused on the training session.

When such potentially disastrous implementations occur, it's not always the trainer's fault—sometimes it's the organization that forces the decision,

and sometimes it's simply a lack of understanding about virtual training. Regardless, you should take steps to avoid these unfortunate situations.

Of course, in the face-to-face classroom, trainers frequently face implementation conditions that are not ideal. You might not have enough resources to properly execute a training plan. Or you might deal with participants who are not supported in their quest for training. In these situations, especially when things are beyond your control, manage them to the best of your ability. And it's the same in the virtual classroom. Despite our best efforts, sometimes a virtual training solution is not well supported or well designed, but the trainer needs to make the best of it and manage the situation.

See [Table 1-3](#) for a few ideas about conducting virtual training in scenarios that are not ideal.

 Basic Rule 2
Virtual training can be an effective learning solution. However, it is not the right learning solution for every learning initiative in every organization.

Table 1-3. Virtual Training in Tricky Situations

Situation	Suggested Solutions
Participants are in a cubicle or other less than ideal learning environment	• Supply stereo telephone headsets for participants to use. • Create “Do Not Disturb” signs for cubicle walls. • See if participants can borrow an office or room with a closed door.
Two or more participants have to share the same computer	• Plan ahead and request loaner laptops for participants. • Schedule more than one virtual training session and have participants attend different classes.

Getting It Done

In your transition to delivering in the online classroom, you should be aware of the multiple definitions of virtual training. What one person considers to be virtual training may not be what someone else considers to be virtual training. Therefore, always take time to discuss training needs and intended outcomes so that everyone has a common understanding of the goal and the chosen method to get there. Once you are certain that the synchronous online classroom is part of the training solution, your next step is to learn how to transfer your training skills to this new platform.

Now that you have learned some of the basics about virtual training, use Worksheet 1-1 to help guide your journey. Then, use Worksheet 1-2 to assess your readiness.

In [chapter 2](#), we'll review the training skills needed to be a successful virtual facilitator.



Noted

Joe Willmore's Story: Discovering Virtual Training

Many years ago, I attended a conference presentation with four speakers. Two were expert organization development professionals, and two used technology for decision making. What I took away from that presentation was that interaction in a virtual environment is not the same as it is in the face-to-face environment. Around the same time, I read some research on the dynamics of virtual teams, specifically that virtual teams build trust differently than face-to-face teams. This helped me realize that virtual training is not just face-to-face training with computers. It's a whole different dynamic.

—Joe Willmore, President and Founder, Willmore Consulting Group

Worksheet 1-1. Goal Setting

Use the following questions to guide your journey to virtual training success.

How will learning to be an effective virtual trainer benefit you personally?

How will learning to be an effective virtual trainer benefit your organization?

Why is learning to be an effective virtual trainer important to you right now? What are the short-term benefits?

How might learning to be an effective virtual trainer help you in the future? What are the long-term benefits?

Use SMART (specific, measurable, achievable, realistic, timely) goal-setting guidelines to create a learning plan for yourself.

Goal 1:

Goal 2:

Goal 3:

Revisit these goals frequently throughout your journey, adjusting them as necessary.

Bonus

What might get in the way of accomplishing your goals?

How can you overcome these obstacles?

Worksheet 1-2. Preparedness Checklist

Use this worksheet to assess your readiness for virtual training. The higher your overall score, the more prepared you will be for virtual training.

Organizational Readiness	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Usually	Always
The organization currently uses technology for learning initiatives (i.e., self-paced e-learning for compliance training).	1	2	3	4	5
The organization is open to trying new methods and techniques for organizational learning (i.e., early adopter of new training techniques).	1	2	3	4	5
The organization supports learning initiatives (i.e., visible executive or key leadership support).	1	2	3	4	5

Technology Readiness	No	Yes
Each learner has access to a personal computer with an Internet connection and all necessary software.	1	2
There are no connectivity issues for virtual classroom access (or if there are issues, they can be resolved).	1	2

People Readiness	No	Yes
Each learner has a private location—free of disruptions and distractions—to participate fully in virtual training.	1	2
Learners have basic computer skills (i.e., keyboard typing and basic navigation skills) and are comfortable using technology.	1	2

2

Virtual Training Is Still Training



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- the differences between face-to-face and virtual training
- what training skills are needed for virtual delivery.

Virtual Training Is Still Training

By now you may be thinking, “Oh no, I have to start all over again! Virtual training will be a career change for me because of all the new skills I need to learn!” Rest assured that if you’re a classroom trainer, then you *do* already know a lot about facilitating in the online classroom.

Think of it as adding a new layer to your training skill set. It’s similar to learning to drive a motorcycle or bus after you already know how to drive a car. It’s all transportation, so you apply your experienced driving knowledge to the new vehicle. You may need to take a class or study for an exam; however, you already know the basic skills. Likewise, many of the same face-to-face training skills are used in the virtual classroom. Yes, the environment is online and there are some significant differences, but you will not be starting from scratch.

Comparison Between Virtual and Face-to-Face Training

Many of the same training skills are used in both the face-to-face and virtual classroom, and we will explore the nuances of these similarities later in this chapter. But first, let’s focus on the differences.

There are two primary differences when facilitating classes virtually:

- You do not see the participants.
- You use technology to communicate with and engage the learners.

These differences might not seem like much on paper, but they are significant. While training skills are still used in the virtual classroom, the environment in which they are used is a whole new world.

Difference 1: No Visual Contact

You can't see the participants! For many trainers, not having visual contact is the most intimidating feature of delivering in the virtual classroom. They are disturbed by the thought of not seeing the participants. Classroom trainers are usually very good at reading participants' body language:

- They observe participants' faces to see if they are "getting it."
- They watch to see if energy levels in the room are getting low.
- They notice cues that tell them to speed up or slow down their delivery.
- They look for signals that participants are paying attention and maintaining interest in the content.

Because virtual trainers do not see participants, they have to rely on other methods of observing participants. Virtual trainers still determine if participants are getting it, and whether they are paying attention. They stay aware of the group's overall energy level during class.

Due to the inability to see participants in the virtual classroom, a common thought is to use webcams for video streaming. If every participant and the trainer has a webcam, and the virtual classroom software program has the capability to display video, then problem solved, right? No, unfortunately not. In most cases, I don't recommend using video streaming in a synchronous virtual classroom to "see" the participants. Yes, technically you could have webcams and use the streaming video feature, but there are two drawbacks to this.

First, multiple video streams significantly increase the amount of Internet bandwidth needed for the class. The connection speed will slow down, which could negatively affect the other learning activities. If everyone's connection speed is slow, when you switch from one slide to the next, there will be lag time for the participants' screens to catch up with yours, which can be extremely distracting to the learning environment. This lag time means you may be talking about a screen that they cannot see. In addition, if there is lag time, then the audio connection will not match the video connection. In other words, the facilitator's mouth will move onscreen, but there will be a delay in participants hearing the words. This delay becomes distracting. Despite many technical advances over the past 10 years, Internet bandwidth remains a huge challenge for many participants. Therefore, weigh the potential benefits of live video streaming against this significant drawback.

Second, video streaming does not usually add instructional value to the class. Instead, it can actually do more harm than help. Imagine you have 15 participants in your online class, and you asked each to turn on a webcam. On the side of the screen, you would have 16 small windows (15 plus yourself), each with a moving participant headshot. (It might remind you of *The Brady Bunch*; in the opening scene of the show, each family member appeared in a box and traded glances with one another throughout the theme song.) At first, this visual aid would be a fun novelty addition to the screen. You could watch them, and they could watch you and one another. As class continues, however, these windows could become a distraction amid other learning activities. They simply do not add value to the training content.



Think About This

If you want the participants to see you, then show your photograph on a slide at the beginning of the session, or briefly turn on your webcam at the beginning so participants can see you, and then turn it off for the remainder of the session. Once again, the ability of the participants to see you onscreen will not add much value to the training content. You can engage participants and effectively facilitate without them watching you talk.

Although I am not a fan of using a webcam during virtual training, some trainers believe it is worth the effort. Here is another viewpoint from Lynne Hobbs, a leadership consultant at Strategy Design Inc.:

I've tried to experience as many different virtual sessions as possible, on a variety of subjects, with a wide variety of presenters. Since keeping people engaged is as important a goal as transferring learning, I have found that a live camera of the facilitator is critical to increasing engagement. Good facilitators can maintain eye contact and animated facial expressions that almost replicate being in the same room, from the participant's viewpoint. I found myself participating with a particularly excellent virtual facilitator, and I was nodding and smiling back as though she could see me.

The bottom line is that not seeing the participants is not as big of a problem as it initially seems to be. There are other ways you can “see” the participants and “watch” for the cues you need. We’ll explore techniques for encouraging participants in [chapter 8](#).

Difference 2: Using Technology to Communicate With and Engage Participants

In any training class, the instructor communicates with participants and leads them through a series of activities to achieve the course's stated learning objectives. The obvious difference between facilitating a face-to-face class and a virtual one is the technology used to communicate and engage. Virtual training uses special software programs specifically designed for online collaboration between multiple participants. The trainer uses these virtual tools to facilitate.

In a virtual class, the trainer can display slides and other documents, write on a virtual whiteboard, invite participants to chat, share software applications, and more. The content of a class may be the same face-to-face as it is in the virtual classroom, but the delivery mechanism differs.

At first, you might think that virtual training is limited to technology topics such as how to use a software application. You might also think that virtual training activities cannot match what can be done in a face-to-face class. The reality is that almost anything can be successfully taught in the virtual classroom. This includes learning new software programs, sales techniques, business acumen, interpersonal skills, or time management—anything!

Another surprising reality for some is that in the virtual classroom, you can do almost anything that you can in a face-to-face classroom. Using the virtual tools as they are intended and in creative ways, trainers lead the class through a series of activities to achieve the course's stated learning objectives. The class can discuss, brainstorm, take notes, work in small groups, play content-related games, watch video demonstrations, and so on.



Noted

“The biggest surprise to me was that it takes just as much energy to deliver a class virtually as it does when you have a group of people sitting in front of you. As a matter of fact, it may take even more energy for virtual delivery, because you don't have the synergy of the classroom from which to fuel yourself.”

—Kathy Shurte, CPLP, CPM, D4 Organizational Development Manager, Florida
Department of Transportation

We will explore virtual classroom technology in [chapter 4](#), and learn more about engaging participants in [chapter 8](#). For now, let's focus on the role of the trainer in the virtual classroom.

Training Skills Virtual Trainers Use

The two differences noted previously are significant, and they distinguish virtual training from face-to-face training. However, virtual training is still training. Many classroom training skills are still used, as you'll see in [Table 2-1](#).

Table 2-1. Skills Needed for Training Delivery

Training Skills	Face-to-Face Training	Virtual Training
Facilitate discussion	Yes	Yes
Ask questions	Yes	Yes
Give instructions for group activities	Yes	Yes
Teach new skills	Yes	Yes
Present content	Yes	Yes
Engage participants	Yes	Yes
Manage class time	Yes	Yes
Use technology	Sometimes	Yes
Multitask	Yes	Yes, using technology
Observe and monitor participant behavior	Yes	Yes; however, trainer does not see participants' faces or body language

Let's review the basic training skills used by virtual and classroom trainers alike, with a special focus on what's unique in the virtual classroom.

Facilitate Discussion

In both training environments—the face-to-face classroom and the virtual one—a key role of the trainer is to facilitate. Facilitation consists of:

- asking questions to provoke discussion
- drawing people into conversation
- praising learners for their participation
- enabling participants to apply what they've learned.

Trainers ask questions for a variety of reasons. They seek responses to a query and poll the audience for input. They probe to make people think. And they ask provocative discussion questions to draw out comments. Every question a trainer asks during class should have purpose and meaning, moving the class along to the learning outcome.

The virtual environment requires the questions asked to be even more specific and directed. When asking questions during a virtual delivery, the trainer needs to not only ask the question, but also indicate how the participants should respond.

For example, a trainer might ask, “Who thinks this topic is challenging?” However, in the virtual classroom, the trainer would first say, “If you think this topic is challenging, please click the ‘raise hand’ button,” and then ask a follow-up question to a participant whose hand is raised: “Sande, tell us what you find challenging about it.” Or, in a face-to-face class, the trainer might ask, “When would you use this skill in your job?” In the virtual classroom, that same question might sound like, “Let’s have everyone respond to this next question in the chat window: When would you use this skill in your job?” This specific method of questioning lets participants know exactly what you expect of them.



Basic Rule 3

Trainers should ask very specific questions during virtual delivery, with emphasis on how participants should respond.

In addition, the trainer should also use participants’ names when only one person should respond to a question (such as, “José, could you elaborate on your comment in the chat window?”). The specific, direct questioning approach eliminates any confusion for participants over how to respond.

A skilled facilitator also draws each person into the discussion while maintaining a comfortable classroom environment. (A comfortable environment means they don't embarrass people or put them on the spot in a painful way.) A successful trainer strives to create and maintain a comfortable environment because it helps participants more easily learn. So in the virtual classroom, to draw people into the discussion, the trainer might ask for a response "from someone we haven't heard from yet." Learners can also be drawn into the discussion when trainers use their names, or by referring to something a participant said earlier in the class.

One way to keep the facilitation evenly distributed is to keep track of who is contributing to the class discussion. I do this by printing out a roster prior to the session, and making tick marks next to participant names when they share examples. If participants stay quiet, then I'll find an opportunity to ask them direct questions and encourage their contributions.



Think About This

When asking a direct question to a participant, ensure it is a question that has no wrong answer. In other words, when you call on someone by name, make it a question that could have any response. For example, "Bryan, what is the square root of 362?" would not be appropriate because it has one right answer. However, "Bryan, what did you think about the video demonstration?" would be fine. This helps maintain a comfortable learning environment.

Great facilitation techniques also include providing positive feedback for participation. Thank your attendees for completing an exercise. Use positive reinforcement phrases, such as *good* or *excellent*, when someone answers a question. Use names to encourage specific individuals. Praise learners frequently for their engagement when they contribute to the discussion and use the virtual classroom tools. These reinforcement techniques should be used in any training environment, including the virtual one.

A word about virtual class size: It should be conducive to participation for the trainer to effectively facilitate discussion. Class size is as important in the virtual classroom as it is in the face-to-face one. While there is no standard rule for the number of people to have in a virtual class, it should be large enough to successfully complete the group learning activities and small enough so that everyone can contribute to the discussion. I prefer to have no more than 16 participants so that each person can receive my individual attention during class.

Finally, great facilitators create opportunities for participants to apply what they've learned. This fact is true regardless of the delivery method—face-to-face or virtual. Therefore, as a virtual trainer, encourage participants to share their stories. Allow time for them to hear their fellow participants' experiences. Help participants see how the training topic can be immediately applied and how it's relevant to them. Provide opportunities to experiment and practice. These methods will lead to a beneficial program for the participants that's geared toward the learning objectives.

Give Instructions for Group Activities

One of the trainer's primary responsibilities is to lead participants from one activity to the next during class. Give clear directions for each exercise and set expectations with the participants.

If activity directions are not clear, confusion and frustration result. Participants are more likely to disengage from the class if they do not have a complete grasp on what they are supposed to be doing at any given time.

When you give activity instructions, there are two guidelines that are true in both training environments but warrant special attention in the virtual classroom:

- 1. Be explicit on every detail of the exercise.** Participants need to know exactly what buttons to click, where to type their responses, what to watch for, or what is expected of them during the allotted time.
- 2. Give directions both verbally and visually.** Participants need to see and hear instructions for comprehension and retention. Providing directions verbally helps participants understand what to do. Providing them visually helps those who process information by sight. A visual aid with instructions also gives participants something to refer to during the exercise. This aid can be onscreen or in a handout that is printed prior to class.

Manage Class Time

As a trainer, have you ever had to rush to finish a class on time? Or realized too late that you have more information than time? Or wondered why some of your training classes finish early and others leave you gasping for air?

Even the most seasoned trainers sometimes struggle with classroom time management.

Time management concerns are amplified in the virtual classroom because many synchronous online classes are shorter. Every single minute counts. Think about it: If you have an eight-hour face-to-face class and you lose five minutes due to a discussion tangent, you can easily make it up at another point during the day. But in a 60-minute virtual session, if you spend an extra five minutes on a topic, then you've lost almost 10 percent of your available time!



Think About This

It's a best practice for virtual training classes to be 60-90 minutes, and no more than 120 minutes. If your sessions have to be longer, build in time for a break.

Maximize every minute of your classroom time. Good time management will help give you credibility with your audience, and help you make the most of your time together. For example, if you have a face-to-face class scheduled to begin at 9 a.m., and you start a few minutes late because you were sipping on water while walking to the front of the room, the participants would not think much of it because they can visually see you and know that it is time to start class. However, in the virtual environment, if you start a few minutes late for any reason, your participants may think, "Did I get the wrong time?" and they might disconnect from the session.

When you prepare for your virtual session, make sure you know how much time each activity should take and how much discussion time you have. It's up to you to manage the pace of class.

Review [Table 2-2](#), which will help you recognize and eliminate the most common time wasters in the virtual classroom.

Table 2-2. Dealing With Time Wasters

Time Waster	Suggested Solution
Taking too much time on introductions	Use a brief activity, such as a poll or chat, to learn about your audience instead of asking them to introduce themselves one by one.
Wasting time reviewing logistics	Share logistics prior to the class start time, either in an email or on an introductory screen.
Spending too much time showing participants how to use the virtual classroom software tools	• Require a prerequisite session on how to use the virtual classroom software. • Invite new users to join the session early for review. • Teach tools in the moment, as needed.
Requiring an answer (or response) from each participant	Use one of the software tools—poll, shared whiteboard, or chat—to allow for simultaneous responses.
Not seeking input from participants on the timing and pacing of activities	Ask participants to electronically “raise their hands” when they’re finished with an exercise so you know when it’s time to move on.

Establish Ground Rules

The ground rules of a training class let participants know what behaviors are expected and which ones are not allowed. Trainers should always establish ground rules in a training class, regardless of the delivery environment, although you will have less time to discuss them than in a face-to-face class.

Typical ground rules for any type of class might include:

- Follow common courtesies for communication.

- Keep sensitive information confidential.
- Be on time.
- Share experiences.
- Participate actively.

Ground rules unique to a virtual class may include:

- State your name before speaking.
- Never use your telephone “hold” button, to avoid hearing hold music.
- Use the mute/unmute buttons if in a noisy environment.
- Ask questions verbally or in the chat window at any time.

I believe it is important for participants to set their own ground rules. In my face-to-face classes, I may start the list with suggestions, but then ask the group to decide upon the rules. Once the rules are established, I’ll often joke with the group, using an analogy from flying: “When someone sits in an exit row, they have to verbally agree to follow the airline’s rules for emergency exit seating. Here in our class, we also need to verbally agree to follow these rules.” Giving participants input on the ground rules list increases the likelihood of them being kept. I also ask participants to decide the “penalty” for breaking a rule. My face-to-face classes have come up with some fun and creative ideas, such as asking the offender to wear a funny straw hat for five minutes. What works for one group may not work for another, which is why the participants have control.

In a virtual class, participants should still have ownership of the ground rules. They can decide their own penalties for the rule breakers, such as asking the offender to sing a short song.

Because virtual classes are often shorter than their face-to-face counterparts, you should limit the amount of time spent on logistics. Group virtual class “housekeeping” items and the ground rules into one short discussion. You could even cover them before class starts by having the information posted onscreen while you’re waiting for class to begin. If you use this technique, then gain the participants’ buy-in to the rules with a quick question at the beginning of class.



Noted

Kella Price, CEO and human resources and training consultant at Price Consulting Group, has advice for classroom trainers who are just getting started with virtual delivery: Think about all the things you like when you are participating in a training course, and incorporate those elements into your own delivery. Ask others to critique your course before using it with participants. Try to use some of the activities that you would do in a traditional classroom in the online environment; group activities and breakouts are possible in many virtual platforms.

If you have a group of participants who are new to virtual training, then you may need to take a more active role in establishing ground rules. You can give them a list and ask which ones they agree with and what else they would add.

Getting It Done

Virtual training is still training. Yes, the online dynamic is different. Yes, you will use technology to communicate. No, you cannot see the participants. However, despite these obstacles, you are not starting from square one when you transition from the face-to-face classroom to the virtual classroom. You will be able to transfer many of your classroom training skills to the virtual environment. It will take time and practice to get comfortable with the new delivery method, but you can successfully make the leap. Reading this book is a good step in the right direction. Use Worksheet 2-1 to assess your skills in delivering training to the virtual classroom.

Worksheet 2-1. Training Skills Assessment

Place a checkmark next to the training skills you would like to focus on learning to deliver in the virtual classroom.

Training Skill	I Want to Learn
Facilitate discussion	
Ask questions	
Give instructions for group activities	
Teach new skills	
Present content	
Engage participants	
Manage class time	
Use technology	
Multitask	
Monitor participant behavior	

What skill(s) are already your strengths?

What skill(s) will you focus on first in preparing to deliver in the virtual classroom?

3

Learn About Technology



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- the basics of hardware and software
- files and folder structure
- Internet features specific to virtual training
- types of telephony in virtual training
- the importance of learning more about technology.

3

Learn About Technology

To be a successful virtual trainer, you must learn about technology. You need to know more than the virtual classroom software—you also need to know what's underneath it.

It's similar to driving a car. You can be a good driver without knowing how to change a tire or check the oil. But when a problem arises, you are dependent on someone else to fix it. You may be waiting on the side of the road while everyone else passes you by.

Similarly, the best classroom trainers are ones who not only facilitate with ease, but also have mastered all aspects of the classroom, including its technology. They can connect a laptop to any projector, TV, or other display; use standard sound systems; and perform basic troubleshooting when things go wrong. They are not dependent on someone else for these essential classroom functions.

The more you know about technology, the more comfortable you'll be in the virtual classroom. You'll be able to troubleshoot when things go wrong, it will be easier for you to multitask, and your classes will flow more smoothly. You'll also have greater credibility with your participants.

The Basics of Hardware and Software

Let's start with the basics: hardware and software. If you are already well versed in basic technology, you can consider this section a brief refresher. Or, skip ahead to the Tech Check at the end of the chapter.

Hardware consists of the physical components you can touch. Your desktop computer, monitor, mouse, printer, cables, keyboard, hard drives, and removable drives are all considered hardware. Your laptop, tablet, or smartphone would also be considered hardware.

The computer's processor is its brain and central nervous system; it accepts commands and tells the various parts what to do and how to

respond. Some of these hardware items take input (mouse, keyboard, touch screen), while others give output (monitor or screen, printer).

To participate in virtual training, and to facilitate an online class, you'll need a basic computer setup: computer, monitor, mouse, and keyboard, plus a sound card and speakers if you plan to use any sound-enabled features in class. Most laptops have all these hardware components built in.



Basic Rule 4

It's possible to use Internet-enabled smartphones or tablets to participate in some virtual training classes. However, given their current screen size and the feature limitations of virtual classroom apps, it is not recommended that you use one to facilitate.

Software, on the other hand, is the intangible program that tells the computer processor how to function and what to do. Software falls into two categories: operating systems and applications. Examples of operating systems are Microsoft Windows, Linux, and macOS High Sierra. Examples of what I call traditional applications are Microsoft Office Excel, Word, and PowerPoint. Newer applications include cloud-based programs like Google Sheets, screen capture programs like TechSmith's Snagit, and presentation programs like Prezi.



Think About This

If you want to play your favorite song, you need both hardware and software. The hardware would be an MP3 player or smartphone. When you press the buttons to find the song you wish to hear, and adjust sound controls such as bass, treble, and volume, you're using software to do those tasks. The result? Hearing beautiful music.

Every software program has its specialty. If I visited your town and asked where the best steak restaurant was, you'd send me to the place known for great steak. And you'd expect me to order a steak when I got there. Would I go and order spaghetti? No. It's possible to order spaghetti, and some people probably do, but the point of going to the best steakhouse in town is to enjoy what it's known for: the steak. It's the same with software programs—they each have their specialties. They may have a menu full of choices, but each program has a sweet spot, or what it does best.

The virtual classroom uses a special type of software program that allows multiple computers to see the same screen at the same time and participants to collaborate. We'll explore the details of these types of classroom software programs in [chapter 4](#). Other software programs that virtual trainers commonly use include Microsoft PowerPoint, Adobe Acrobat Reader (to access PDFs), and Internet browsers such as Microsoft Internet Explorer, Google Chrome, or Apple Safari.

In fact, Internet software can be an entire category unto itself. We use software programs to access the Internet. Some Internet pages require additional use of special software programs, such as Adobe Flash Player or JavaScript to view certain content.

Traditional software is usually installed on your computer from a storage location such as a USB drive, your organization's network servers, or the "store" included in the operating system, such as the Windows Store or Apple App Store. Other software programs can be downloaded onto your computer from the supplier's website.

In the case of mobile devices such as tablets or smartphones, the software programs are called apps, which is short for applications. These apps are typically downloaded from the operating system's store, which is natively built into the device. For example, to install an app onto an Android mobile device, you would connect to the Google Play Store.

For hardware and software to talk to one another, they often need drivers. You may have experienced working with drivers if you've ever installed a printer. You need the correct driver on your computer to print to that printer. Some Internet software, including certain virtual classroom and collaboration programs, also need to have drivers installed. In my experience, drivers are not a frequent cause of problems during a virtual training class, but they are something to keep in the back of your mind when troubleshooting incorrect display or other settings. We'll explore troubleshooting in [chapter 10](#).

Software Plug-Ins and Administrator Rights

Some software programs make use of plug-ins (also called add-ins) to enhance their capabilities. Plug-ins are like little software programs that stay hidden in the background until they are needed. They have various functions, such as playing video or audio clips. For example, when you play

a video in a virtual classroom software program, it could use a plug-in like Adobe Flash Player.

Like traditional software programs, plug-ins are installed or downloaded onto a computer. Some virtual classroom software requires plug-ins to work properly. This is where problems may arise, because computers can be configured to allow only certain users the ability to install software or make changes to their computer settings. If participants do not have administrator rights to their computers, then they may not be able to install the required plug-ins for the virtual classroom software programs.

Trainers should check with the information technology (IT) or information services (IS) department of their organization to see if there will be any known challenges with installing necessary plug-ins or administrator rights assigned to participants' computers.

Settings

Most hardware and software programs have settings that can be changed by a user with administrator privileges. Some settings are based on the type of hardware you have, while other settings are changed because of user preference.

For example, your monitor has various display settings. Some monitors display a screen resolution that is 1920 pixels wide by 1080 pixels high. Other common resolutions are 1920 × 1440, 1440 × 900, and 1366 × 768. The screen resolution dictates the output quality and size display seen on a monitor.



Basic Rule 5

To check a computer to see if it will be able to use your virtual classroom software program, click on the “test” link provided by the software vendor. This link is usually included in the automated event registration email, or available on the vendor’s website.

When delivering virtual training, your computer’s screen resolution settings might be different from the settings on your participants’ computers. Therefore, what you see on your computer screen may not be the exact same image as what your participants see on their computer screens. Everyone’s screens will look similar, yet there may be distortions or other slight differences.

It may be helpful to think of it this way: When you play a music CD on different systems, you hear the same song, but with slightly different experiences. The sound quality depends on the speakers as well as the player's sound settings, such as bass, treble, and balance. The result is a slightly different listening experience based on the hardware and software used.

Therefore, as a virtual trainer you should have a general understanding of what settings can be changed on a computer, and know how to change the basic settings of your own computer.

By now you're probably thinking: Do I really need to know these technology details? Let's just get to the good stuff—how to deliver training in the virtual classroom. The answer is yes—you really do need to know this information.

Think about a classroom trainer who uses a projector to display a visual. If the projected display is crooked or slightly out of focus, then everyone in the class notices. They focus on the imperfections, and wonder why the trainer doesn't fix them. On the other hand, if a classroom trainer uses a projector and the visual display is perfect, then no one pays attention to the mechanics. Instead, they're focused on learning.

Classroom trainers who know how to adjust projectors, including their display settings, are able to keep participants' focus off the technology and on the class. It's the same in the virtual classroom. Once you've mastered the technology, you and your participants will simply use these tools and everyone can focus on learning.

Files and Folders

Other important technology components are files and the folder structure where you store them. There are two main reasons a virtual trainer needs to know about files and folders. First, you need to know what file types work (and don't work) with your virtual classroom software. Second, you need to know where your files are stored and how to get to them quickly when you need them.

File Types

Every software program saves its files with a unique signature called a file type. You can easily determine the file type by looking at the file extension

(if it's visible), or at the icon graphic next to the file name. These file extensions associate the file with a particular software program.

When you are delivering in the virtual classroom, you use files to communicate visually. For example, you could use a Microsoft PowerPoint file to show slides with text and graphics, or a media file to play a video that demonstrates a new skill. You might also have a poll question saved or a document you refer to during class. All these files are opened or “shared” in your virtual classroom.

When software programs are updated to newer versions, sometimes the file extensions change as well. For example, previous versions of PowerPoint files had a .ppt extension, yet the default setting for PowerPoint 2007 and newer files is .pptx.

It's important to know what file types are supported by your virtual classroom software. Some platforms allow .pptx files, while others still need .ppt ones. And some platforms can open media files (such as mp4 files), while others cannot. If a virtual classroom supports the file type, then the file should be loaded into it. If not, then you may need to share the application or share your desktop. The virtual classroom is faster and the participant experience is better when files are loaded into the platform, so that's always the preferred choice when possible. Every platform is different, so you should know what works for your chosen software.

File Storage

Trainers use files in both the face-to-face classroom and the virtual classroom. A face-to-face classroom trainer has instructor notes, participant handouts, whiteboards, and videos. In the virtual classroom, a trainer uses all of the above and more. Virtual training files could also include poll questions, saved chat notes, and other shared documents.

Your electronic files are stored in drives and folders, similar to how you store paper files in your office filing cabinet. Your file organization structure is not critically important: You may be an extremely organized “filer” and have every file in its place, with hanging folders and color-coded labels. Or, you may be a “piler,” with everything thrown into piles. Your computer filing cabinet is probably the same: files organized in subfolders or collected in one big folder. What *is* important is being able to find the training file you need at a moment's notice. Therefore, it really doesn't

matter what your style is, as long as you can find the file you need when you need it.

To share a document or open a saved poll question in the virtual classroom, you must know the name of the file, where you saved it, and how to navigate to that location. You need to be able to get to it quickly. You should also know how to make backup copies of your files, and how to email file attachments to participants. These things are essential skills for a virtual trainer. For example, I was a participant in a virtual class recently. It was a smooth experience until the trainer accidentally closed his slide presentation. Unfortunately, he did not know how to reopen it. It was an embarrassing moment for him, and the class could not continue as planned. He had to call for help to remedy the situation.

The Internet

Virtual classroom software, by its very nature, uses the Internet. Therefore, virtual trainers should know basic Internet features.

Connection Types

A fairly important consideration is the type of Internet connection that you and your participants have. The connection needs to be fast enough to handle the virtual classroom software and all the activities you have planned. If you plan to use any streaming video during the class, you'll want to ensure everyone's Internet speeds are fast enough to handle it.

While most corporate Internet connections are fast, consider the home office user or someone using a public wireless (Wi-Fi) hotspot. Those connections are more likely to be slower or not as robust. They may also lack security, leaving your computer vulnerable to outside intruders or other malicious activity.

Bandwidth

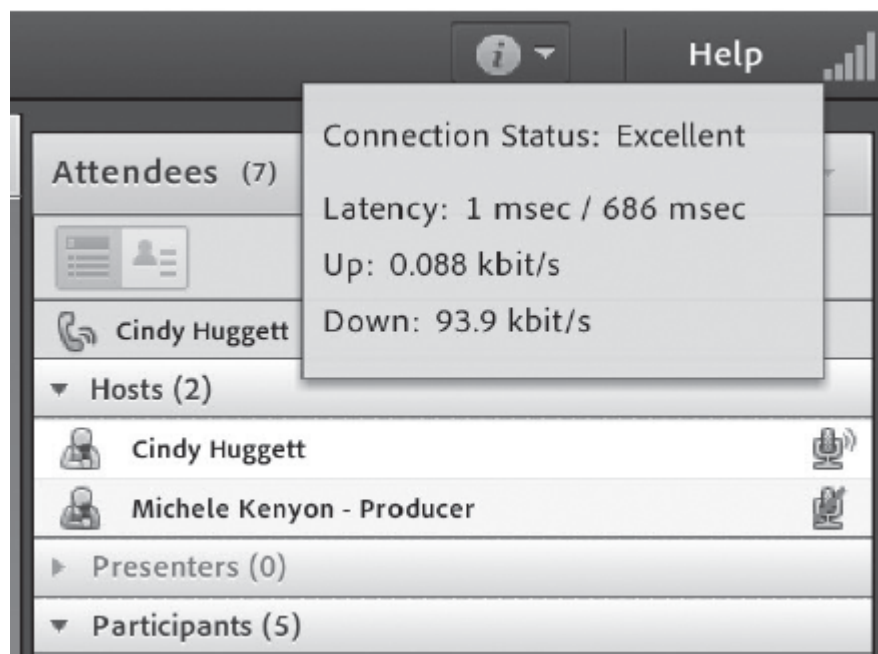
You are probably already familiar with bandwidth. In simplest terms, bandwidth refers to the speed that data transfer from one computer to another. So, if you have ever waited too long for a webpage to load, or watched an online video that played in slow motion, then you know what it's like to be dependent on Internet bandwidth.

Bandwidth is typically measured in bits per second (bps) or megabits per second (mbps). So a data transfer rate of 120 million bits per second (120 megabits) would be written as 120 mbps. The higher the bandwidth, the faster the data transfer (Figure 3-1).

Most virtual classroom software programs state the minimum data transfer rates required for use. However, the true amount needed depends upon what features will be used and what activities are planned. For example, if the audio connection will be through the computer (Voice over Internet Protocol, or VoIP), a higher bandwidth will be required than if regular telephone lines are used. Or, if the trainer turns on the webcam for live-streaming video, then the bandwidth requirement will be higher.

One of the frequent causes of problems during a virtual class is lack of sufficient bandwidth on the participant or trainer connections. When participants complain of slow-loading graphics, or if they say the audio is “choppy,” it’s typically a bandwidth problem.

Figure 3-1. Bandwidth Indicator in Adobe Connect



Firewalls and Pop-Up Blockers

Due to security concerns on the Internet, most computers have software to prevent unauthorized intrusions. While this is a good thing, it can get in the way of virtual classroom software programs.

A firewall is a virtual barrier that, for security reasons, separates a computer or network from others. It prevents unauthorized entry to the network, but it can also prevent outbound connections. Firewalls typically do not get in the way on personal home computers. But an organization's firewall for its corporate computers might interfere with a virtual software program. Therefore, it's important for a trainer to check with the organization's IT or IS department ahead of time to see if there will be any known challenges with firewalls or other security features.

Another security element found on most Internet-connected computers is a pop-up blocker. These blockers prevent pop-up windows from opening in a computer's Internet browser. Once again, this is usually a good thing, but it can also get in the way of some virtual classroom software programs that open in a new pop-up window.

Pop-up blockers can usually be disabled by the computer's user, although sometimes multiple pop-up blockers can be installed and in use at one time. My favorite trick is to press the CTRL key while clicking on a link, because that manually overrides any pop-up blockers.

Cookies and Caches

As you log in to some websites, a small file is deposited into your computer with identifying information such as your computer's IP address or which pages you view while on the site. These small files are referred to as cookies. Some virtual classroom software programs need to have an Internet browser's cookies enabled to capture login information. Find out if your computer has security settings that prevent cookies from being deposited.

These cookies are stored in a tucked-away location called a cache, along with other temporary Internet files. When an Internet browser is having display or login problems, a common troubleshooting technique is to clear out the browser's cache and its cookies.

Virtual trainers should know how to clear the Internet cache and delete unwanted cookies. In most Internet browser programs, including Internet Explorer, Firefox, and Chrome, this option can be found in dialog boxes under the Tools menu.

Telephony

During a virtual training class, you'll have three types of connections: visual, kinesthetic, and auditory. The visual connection is what's seen on the screen. Kinesthetic is the physical movement associated with the connection, such as typing on the keyboard. And the audio connection is hearing what everyone's saying.

Your computer handles the visual and kinesthetic connections to the virtual training class, and your telephone usually handles the audio. *Telephony* is a broad term referring to overall audio connection and telephone equipment used.

There are three types of audio connections you and the participants could use:

- stand-alone conference call
- integrated conference call
- Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP).

With a stand-alone conference call, everyone dials a pre-established telephone number. This conference call is not connected in any way to the virtual classroom software. Sometimes these numbers are referred to as a "conference bridge" and are often managed by a telephony supplier.

Integrated conference calling connects the virtual classroom software and the conference bridge. One supplier provides both the software and telephony, and the moderator of one is the moderator of the other. With integrated conference calling, everyone still uses a telephone to dial in to the audio portion of the call. One advantage of an integrated telephony connection is that some virtual classroom software programs display the participants' telephone connection status, and the trainer can view and change individual settings (such as placing a participant on mute).

Also, an integrated conference call often includes the ability for participants to dial in or to receive a phone call from the conference service (dial-out). My preference is for participants to let the system dial their number (the dial-out option), so that their audio is automatically synced in the virtual classroom platform.

The third type of telephony used for virtual classes is VoIP. (VoIP can either be pronounced as one syllable, *voyp*, or spelled out, *vee-oh-eye-pee*.) VoIP uses the Internet and the computer's microphone and speakers to transmit the audio portion of the call. Instead of using a telephone for the conference call, participants simply connect to the conference and speak

into their computer's microphone. They hear the trainer and other participants through their computer's speakers.

People often ask if they can use a cell phone to participate in or facilitate virtual training. They can, provided there is a clear connection without static or the chance of a dropped call. A telephone is a telephone, regardless of the connection type. VoIP telephones also can be used.

The bottom line is that the first two audio methods require some type of telephone connection. The third type, VoIP, simply uses the computer, its hardware components, and its Internet connection. My home office telephone uses VoIP for its connection. I do not have traditional telephone service to my house; instead, my phone service travels over my Internet connection. So, when I deliver a virtual training class that uses the first two options, I use my laptop to log in to the virtual classroom software and use my telephone to dial the conference call number. While they both use the Internet, they are separate connections to the virtual class.

Virtual trainers should know common commands used by the conference call provider, such as how to mute and unmute lines, and whether the audio conference supports audio subgroups or "breakout rooms."

Learn More About Technology

I've always felt fortunate that my training career began as a software trainer when personal computers first became mainstream in office environments. I learned and taught DOS programming, the first version of Microsoft Windows, early versions of today's common office programs, and basic networking. This experience allowed me to become very comfortable with technology.

Because I was teaching others how to use technology, I wanted to know as much as I could about it. So I read every software manual from cover to cover (this was when software programs came with printed instruction manuals). I clicked on every button, experimented with every feature, and learned as many shortcuts and tips as I could find.



Basic Rule 6

If there's one traditional software program that a virtual trainer should know well, it's PowerPoint.

Most virtual classroom software programs expect the trainer to share or upload a PowerPoint file and, therefore, it becomes the foundational basis for the training. PowerPoint slides can display text, graphics, and charts, and can help organize the class materials.

Trainers should know at a minimum the following features of PowerPoint:

- inserting new slides
- adding text, clip art, and other graphics (such as photos)
- formatting text and graphics
- changing slide order and deleting slides
- adding slide animations
- working with slide masters.

This is still my approach to learning new technology: read the documentation, try it out, and play around with it. It's also what I recommend for trainers who are learning new technology.

Perhaps you are like most trainers I encounter: You are self-taught in technology. You know how to get online, read email, type a letter, and fumble through a spreadsheet. You learn new technology when you have to, either by trial and error or when someone shows you a new trick. This method is common, and it works for most people. However, now that you are training in the virtual classroom, you should learn as much as you can about technology. It will serve to your advantage.

One Trainer's Journey: Learning About Technology

Kathy Shurte's Story

I am truly an “accidental” virtual trainer. Technology is not my forte, so I did not seek out opportunities to play (or frustrate myself) with the latest toys. The organizations I worked for tended to be very restrictive with technology, so I wasn't learning virtual skills at work. However, I totally understand how important technology is to the way we do business today, and I do want to learn.

Through a volunteer position with ATD, I gained experience working on virtual teams. We did most of our work over teleconference and, as time went on, there were opportunities to participate in webinars as both a participant and a presenter. It was a great confidence builder! We also had a tech team at our service, and I called on them when needed.

Although I was not an early adopter, when I was ready to stick my toe in the water, I did it surrounded by a strong support network. For my training sessions, I selected topics about which I was passionate, and that made it easy for me to focus on the message and not get caught up in the medium. I also reached out to the most tech-savvy people I knew and asked them for advice. Curiously, most of them were not trainers; they were just very technically astute people. And more curiously, they were telling me to do things that, as a trainer, I knew I should do: Engage your learners. Don't read from your slides. Ask questions, lots of questions. Pretty soon, my self-talk was saying, “See, you already know how to do this!” The learning, for me, was all about the technology.

Getting It Done

Remember, technology is simply a means to an end. It's not our goal. Instead, it helps us reach our goal. We want to know it so we can use it. We want to master it so that we can manage it. Use Worksheet 3-1 to assess what types of technology you want to learn more about.

To be a successful virtual trainer, you must become comfortable with technology—not for the sake of technology, but for the sake of your training. In [chapter 4](#), we'll cover the typical capabilities of virtual classroom software and how to present online.

Worksheet 3-1. Tech Check

Place a checkmark next to the technology skills you want to learn more about.

I Want to Learn	Technology Item
	Computer hardware and software
	Internet
	Software programs and apps
	Telephony

How will you learn about each one? List the resources you will use. (See the resources list in the back of this book for some ideas.)

-
-
-
-
-

4

Master Virtual Classroom Software Programs



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- how to select a virtual solution
- how to compare virtual classroom software programs
- virtual class logistics
- common features of virtual classroom software programs.

Master Virtual Classroom Software Programs

Masters of their craft know their tools: Carpenters know their hammers and saws, masons know their bricks and mortar, potters know their clay, and virtual trainers know their classroom software.

Virtual trainers must be experts in the tools they use—which means they should learn everything there is to know about their virtual software program. Just like classroom trainers study presentation skills and flipchart drawing techniques, virtual trainers should study the software program they will use when delivering.

Selecting a Virtual Solution

Selecting virtual classroom software to use can be a daunting task. It's a big decision to make: Which software platform will you use for training? The features and functions available to you in the virtual classroom depend largely on the software chosen; therefore, you must choose wisely. For example, if you know that using small group breakout rooms will be an essential component of your online training, then you want to look for a program that has breakout rooms.

In many organizations, the IT or IS department has control over which software programs everyone will use. If that's the case, you should establish a good relationship with the IT decision makers and discuss your training requirements with them. When the IT department purchases a solution, you want it to be one that fits the organization's training needs.



Think About This

Virtual classroom software programs bring people together online in real time. These programs allow for collaboration and document sharing.

Online virtual collaboration tools often have more than one version with different features for each, and someone outside the training function might not think about what is necessary for a virtual class. For instance, one popular virtual platform, Cisco WebEx, has three products: Meeting Center, Training Center, and Event Center. While all have a similar look and feel, each has its own features and capabilities. This is akin to a physical meeting space. Think about where types of training events are held in your office: conference rooms, training classrooms, and auditoriums. Virtual meeting programs have similar types of options.



Basic Rule 7

If you are scheduled to facilitate an online training class, and they tell you which virtual software platform you'll be using, be sure to ask, "Which version?"

So often I hear trainers say, "Our IT department purchased the meeting version of the virtual software, and I'm trying to convince them to upgrade to the training version." Nip this problem in the bud by working with the IT team to make a purchasing decision that's right for everyone.

Comparing Virtual Classroom Software Programs

There are many competing software programs on the market today that are used for virtual classrooms. These programs are called by various names; some are referred to as online collaboration platforms, others are known as synchronous learning systems, and still others are called web conferencing programs. Because this book focuses on virtual training, I'll refer to them as virtual classroom software programs.

[Table 4-1](#) lists a few of the most commonly used software programs. Please note that this is not an exhaustive list, and it may not include the right solution for your organization. You should thoroughly research your

own delivery needs, compare vendors and solutions, talk with your IT department about resource requirements, and make an informed decision. Most of these programs have trial versions for testing and allow you to participate in online sessions to familiarize yourself with the available features.

In addition to the software program vendors, several third-party vendors resell virtual classroom software solutions. They provide additional support services for the programs, such as event management and customer support. They also bundle conference calling systems and web conferencing (virtual classroom software) into one subscription package that individuals and organizations can purchase. When you use these bundled packages, the web and audio conferencing are integrated.

Table 4-1. A Sample of Virtual Classroom Software Programs

Name	Website
Adobe Connect	www.adobe.com/products/adobeconnect.html
AirClass by Lenovo	www.airclass.com
Cisco WebEx Training Center	www.webex.com/products/elearning-and-online-training.html
GoToTraining	www.gototraining.com
Blackboard Collaborate	www.blackboard.com/platforms/collaborate/overview.aspx
Saba Virtual Classroom	www.saba.com/us/lms/virtual-classroom
Jigsaw	www.jigsawme.com
Zoom	https://zoom.us

The decision to use a third-party vendor versus going straight to the software vendor will depend upon your organization's overall web conferencing needs. On the one hand, if you need both audio and web conferencing, third-party vendors provide integrated solutions. On the other hand, you may not need all the services offered through these bundles. It's important for you to research thoroughly and decide appropriately.

In addition, use the training or classroom version of a vendor's product for virtual training classes when possible. While it's possible to use a meeting or webinar product for virtual training, it's usually not the best alternative. A program made for virtual training will provide the robust, interactive tools that participants need to stay completely engaged in the learning experience.



Noted

“Spend time practicing leading the content and working with the technology.”

—Rebecca Ward, Former Training Performance Consultant, AchieveGlobal

Tips for Learning a Virtual Classroom Software Program

Keep the following pointers in mind as you learn a new program:

- Read the Help screens in the software program.
- Go through the online tutorials available on the vendor's website.
- Search for user tutorials on YouTube.
- Participate in user group discussion boards.
- Attend sessions that use the software program.
- Practice delivering sessions using the program. Set up multiple mock computers, or ask your friends, family, or co-workers to join as participants.
- Log in to a practice virtual event as a participant and click on every button and menu item to find out what each one does. Then do the same thing while logged in to the practice virtual event as the host and presenter. This way you will experience every button and command from all perspectives.



Think About This

Put some thought into the type of virtual classroom program you will use, and choose the best platform for your unique needs. Partner with your IT department to ensure the best tools are selected.

Virtual Class Logistics

For a synchronous online training class to happen, the event needs to be scheduled using the software program's administration tools. This administrative task establishes parameters such as:

- class date and time
- duration of the class
- presenter, trainer, or host login details
- participant login details
- audio or conference call features.

In addition, depending upon what virtual classroom software you are using, the administrative setup may also determine:

- whether a participant password will be required to log in
- how early participants can enter the event
- what entry or lobby screens the participants see upon login
- what privileges the participants will have in the session.

Most virtual classroom software programs are time driven, with a specific date and time for the event. However, for some programs, the administrative setup “generates” the meeting room, which can then be perpetually used from that point forward. In those programs, the administrator creates an online meeting room, and it can be accessed at any time. This is a useful feature because trainers can set up the room well in advance of the session. In time-driven event programs, the trainer simply logs in early to set up the session before its start time.



Basic Rule 8

The virtual class event setup can dictate which features will be available and who can attend. Be sure you are familiar with your virtual classroom software's administrative tools and settings.

Specific directions on how to schedule the event will vary from vendor to vendor and from program to program. Regardless of who is responsible in your organization for learning administration, you should learn how your software program's administration features work so that you can step in if needed. You'll also have an understanding of what can and cannot be changed for the event.

Part of event administration also includes communicating details to participants. The communication should include:

- prerequisites for the course
- assignments to complete prior to the session
- handouts to print prior to the session
- technical or computer system requirements
- computer technology checks that should be completed prior to the session
- connection details for the event.

We'll review more details about communicating with participants in [chapter 5](#).

A virtual class has more technical logistics than a face-to-face one, and special care should be taken to ensure all the details are established and communicated to everyone involved.



Think About This

Some virtual classroom software programs have a login passcode for the trainer and a separate one for the participants. (Depending on the software program, the trainer code may be called the host code, the presenter code, or the moderator code.) The trainer's passcode gives the trainer additional permissions and privileges in the software. Therefore, the trainer code should not be shared with participants. When sending connection details to participants, make sure the trainer code is not included.

A small glitch in the setup of a physical class might not be a big deal, but it could spell disaster for a virtual event. For example, a training class scheduled to be held in Room 107B may be accidentally communicated to participants as Room 107A; when the participants show up to the wrong room, they could easily be redirected to the correct location. And most participants would not think twice about having to walk a few extra steps to get to the right room. However, if virtual class participants are sent the

wrong event link to join the online session, you may not have an easy way to communicate the correct connection information to them in a timely manner. And participants who cannot connect to the virtual classroom may quickly give up and abandon joining the class. The incorrect link may have been a simple administrative error, yet it could be perceived as a technical glitch in the system. If this happens, your participants could miss the session, and for those who do arrive, it would be a rocky start to the virtual class.



Think About This

Take caution with your connection links and passcodes. I learned this lesson the hard way when someone logged in to my training session as the host while I was in the middle of the class. It immediately bumped me out of the host role and into a participant role. I lost technical control of the class. I had to send the person a chat message requesting that they log out or at least change my role back to the host. Fortunately, she did so quickly, and I regained technical control of the class.

Later, we found out that two classes had been scheduled at the same time, and another trainer had accidentally received my event host information for her class. She quickly realized the error, logged out, and found her correct class information.

Virtual Classroom Software Roles

Speaking of learning administration, a successful virtual training event needs someone to organize all its logistics. This person may or may not be the trainer. Just like a face-to-face classroom event, a learning coordinator might be assigned to manage the session details, or the trainer could do it all.

There are the four roles required for a successful virtual class:

- an administrator (sometimes called a coordinator)
- a host (sometimes called a producer or a moderator)
- a trainer (sometimes called a facilitator or a presenter)
- participants (sometimes called attendees).

Review [Table 4-2](#) for a description of each of these roles.

Table 4-2. Roles in the Virtual Classroom

Role	Description
Administrator (sometimes called coordinator)	• Establishes online event details prior to the event • Communicates logistics to the trainer and participants
Host (sometimes called producer or moderator)	• Greets participants upon entering the classroom • Manages the technical details of the event, such as monitoring the chat window for questions, creating breakout groups, and loading polls • Troubleshoots technical problems during the event
Trainer (sometimes called facilitator or presenter)	• Facilitates learning • Teaches new skills • Engages participants through discussion and activities
Participants (sometimes called attendees)	• Attends the event to learn new skills

There is often overlap between these roles. One person may wear multiple hats; it's possible for one trainer to act as administrator, host, and presenter. Or, there might be separate individuals available to take on each role. It is best to have at least two people involved in the administration during a live synchronous event: one person to act as host or producer, and another person to act as trainer or presenter.

The larger the class size, the more important it is to have multiple people responsible for the event. This shared arrangement allows the trainer to focus on the facilitation, learning, and participant engagement, while the producer focuses on the technical details. For example, if a virtual class has 12 participants, and one of them has a technical challenge, the producer can

assist that person while the trainer facilitates the discussion with the other 11. The producer and trainer should coordinate ahead of time to determine who will do what and how the handoffs between them will occur.

Common Features of a Virtual Classroom

Software Program

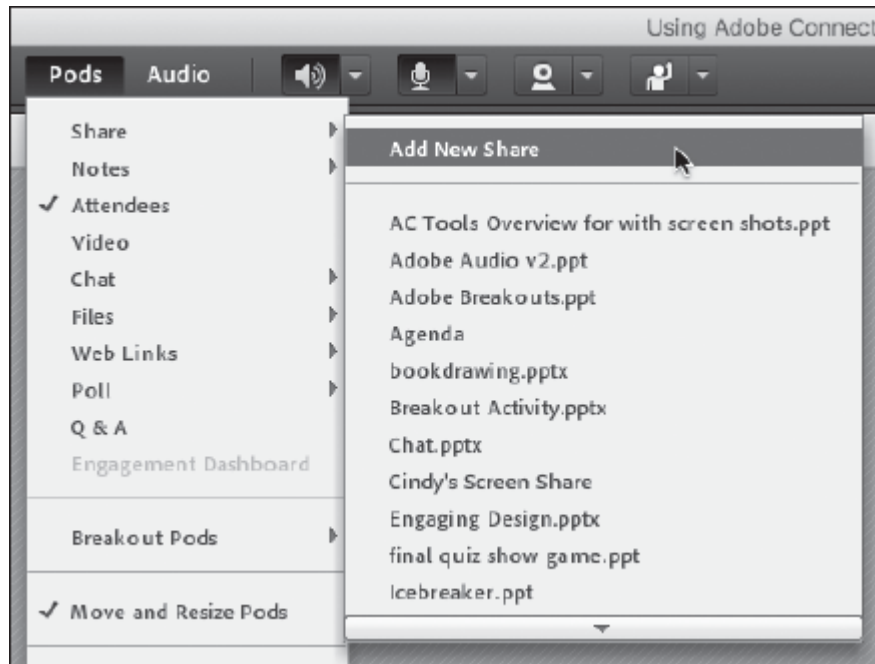
Let's review the common features available in most virtual classroom software programs. We'll briefly discuss each tool, its common uses for virtual training, and any unique characteristics to be mindful of when using it.

Once again, this is not an exhaustive list of all features—just the ones regularly used in virtual training. You should double check with your software program to discover which features it has, what is unique about the tool in that program, and if any software updates have changed the functionality since this book was written.

Sharing Documents

Sharing documents is one of the most commonly used features in a virtual class. The trainer uploads a file into a viewing window, and all participants can see it. When the trainer navigates through the document, moving from one page to another, the participants' screens follow along (see [Figure 4-1](#)).

Figure 4-1. Sharing Documents in Adobe Connect



Common Uses

Almost all virtual training classes use document sharing to display slides. In addition, other documents, such as training manuals or pages from the class handout, can be displayed.

Most programs can share Microsoft Office documents (Word, Excel, or PowerPoint), plus PDF files. Many programs also allow media files to be shared using this feature.

Unique Characteristics

Some programs have participant privilege settings that give the participants free control over viewing the shared documents. This means they could move to a different slide than the one everyone else is viewing. Other programs give you control over whether participants can print the shared document. Check to see what privileges your attendees have for viewing shared documents.

Most virtual classroom software programs have a “sync” or “synchronize” command that can be used by the presenter to synchronize all participant screens. In other words, if participants are viewing different parts of a shared document, clicking on the sync command will bring everyone together.

Check for file compatibility with the virtual classroom software: first, that the file type you wish to share can be uploaded, and second, that the version (such as Microsoft Office 2017 versus 2013) of the file you wish to upload is supported by the software.

Note that some virtual classroom software programs use the document-sharing feature to play audio or video files. In some programs, you simply open the media file as a shared document. Other programs require you to embed the media file into a PowerPoint slide using a proprietary add-in.

Chat

Chat enables you to communicate with participants through real-time typed messages, similar to an instant messenger software program (see [Figure 4-2](#)). Chat messages can be public so that everyone sees the note, or sent privately to one user.

Private chat allows a participant to communicate directly with the host and the presenter. For example, I was delivering a virtual class, and one of the participants sent me a private note explaining a personal reason why she wasn't able to complete an in-class assignment. She requested that I please not call on her to share her answers to it.

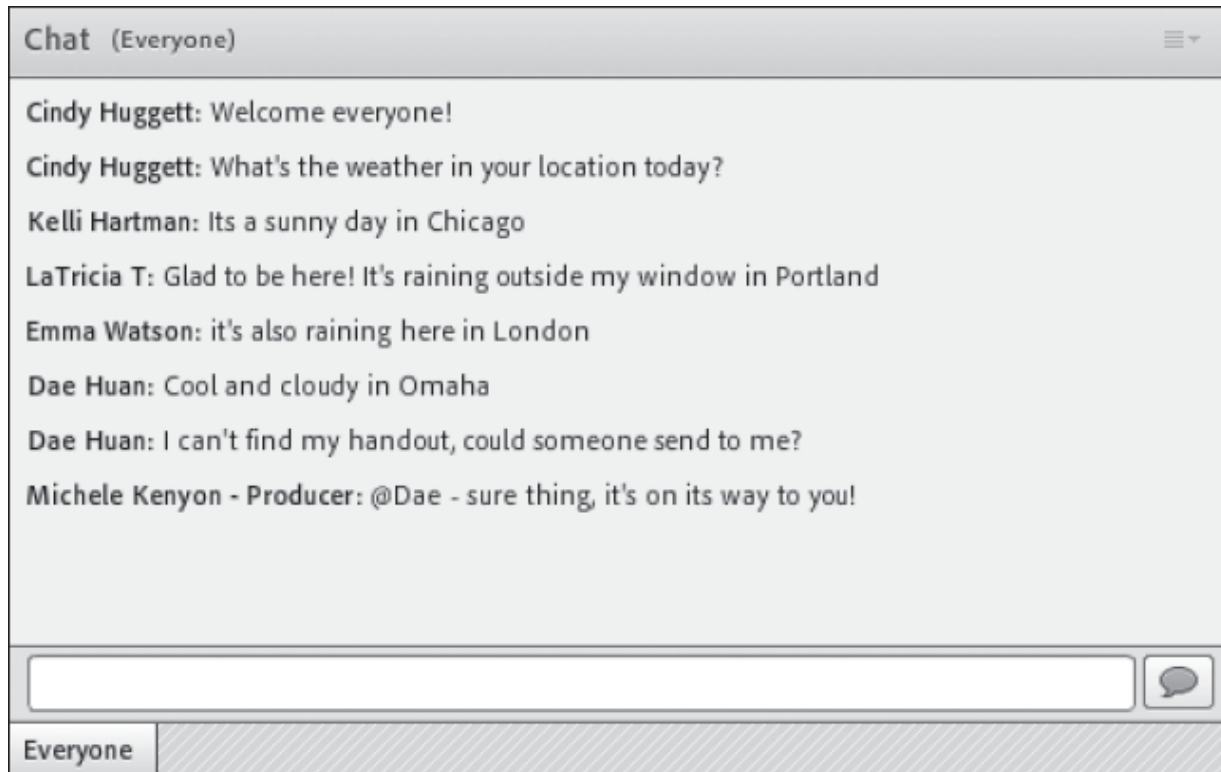


Think About This

Proper planning is crucial. If you are co-facilitating with another trainer or working with a producer, plan who will monitor chat and respond to questions.

Private chat also allows participants to chat with each other. For example, two participants in a training event could communicate by sending messages back and forth in the chat window. In some virtual classroom programs, this conversation would be completely private. Other programs allow the host to see all private conversations.

Figure 4-2. Sample Chat Pod in Adobe Connect



Common Uses

Chat enables you to engage participants during a training class in meaningful ways. The trainer can invite participants to send feedback, ask questions, and make comments during the program. The chat window can provide a running commentary throughout the session.

To increase participation during a discussion, a trainer could ask a question and direct participants to respond in the chat window. This method allows everyone to respond and get involved with the discussion.

The chat window can also be useful for the trainer to pass messages along to the participants during activities. For example, during a breakout session, the trainer can use the chat window to give timing reminders, such as “three minutes remaining” or “It’s time to begin Round 2.”

Private chat could also be used to create a “paired” discussion opportunity in class. Similar to a classroom session where a trainer says, “Turn to the person sitting next to you and discuss your response to this question,” a trainer in the virtual classroom could direct participants to have a private chat.



Think About This

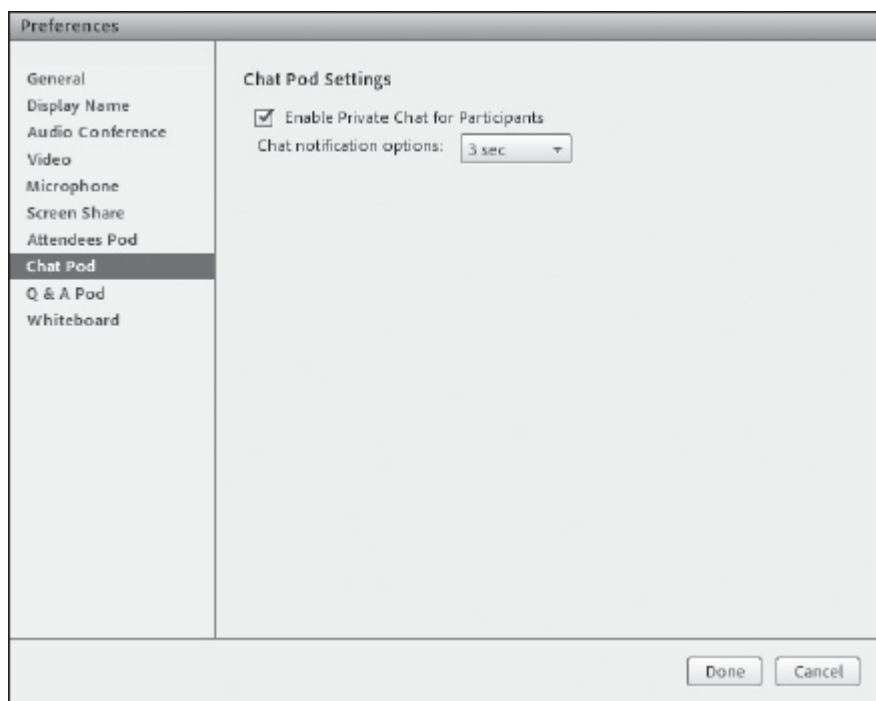
Use all your tools to communicate with participants and overcome any technical hang-ups. During one of my recent sessions, my telephone connection to the session unexpectedly dropped midsentence. I was still connected visually, just not verbally. So I typed a quick note in the chat area to let everyone know I was dialing right back in.

Now, of course, private chat between participants opens up the possibility of them passing notes back and forth, perhaps commenting about the training or their experience. While some trainers shy away from giving participants this type of control, I prefer to allow learners full access to the chat room and encourage them to communicate any way they wish.

Unique Characteristics

Rules about private chat vary from program to program. In most programs, the host can choose whether private chat is allowed, and if it is, whether participants can privately chat with each other (see [Figure 4-3](#)).

Figure 4-3. Participant Chat Privileges in Adobe Connect



If your participants include nonnative language speakers, extra time may be needed for chatting answers. Some participants do not type as fast as others, which may also affect the timing of chat responses.

In one of my virtual training sessions, we played a trivia game on a topic related to the content and awarded points to the first person to correctly answer the question. Participants were directed to answer questions in chat. Interestingly, the first name that appeared on my chat window was not the first name on others' chat windows. So when I announced the winner, everyone erupted in protest. We discussed it and decided it was due to Internet bandwidth, although it could have also been user error on my part. We joked about it and turned it into a lighthearted event and learning experience, but it was a good lesson learned. In future sessions, I changed the directions and process for awarding points.



Noted

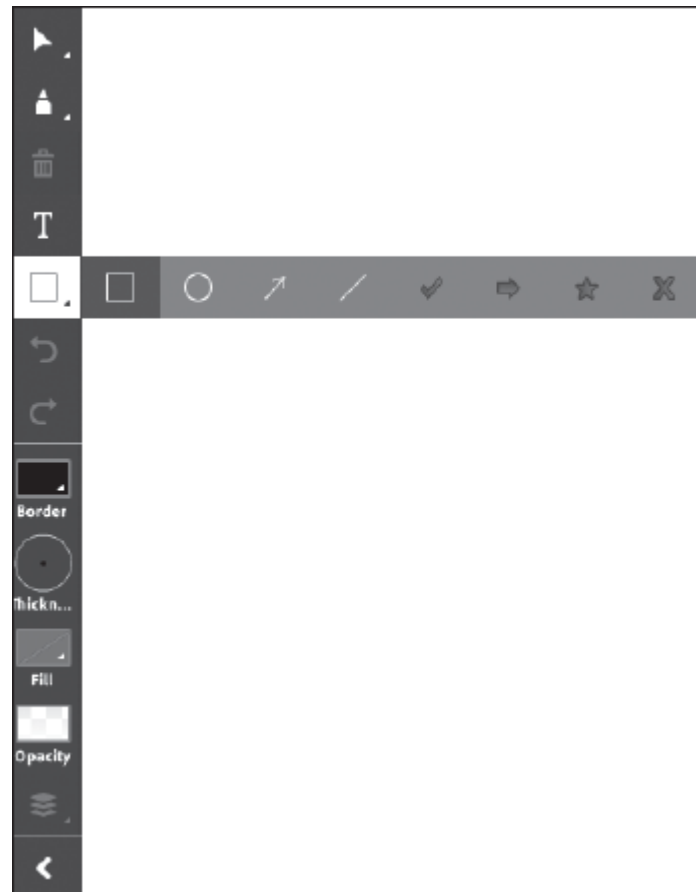
“I warn participants that if you’re going to talk about me or someone else in the class using private chat, make sure you’re sending the message to the correct person before you click send.”

—Wendy Gates Corbett, CPLP
President and Lead Visualist, Refresher Training

Annotate

The annotation tools allow for real-time “drawing” on top of shared documents or directly onto a whiteboard. Annotation adds visual flair to your screen (see [Figure 4-4](#)). It also focuses participant attention to specific areas of the screen.

Figure 4-4. Drawing Tools in Adobe Connect



The exact annotation tools available vary among programs. However, most allow you to:

- Draw lines and other shapes.
- Draw freehand with an electronic pencil or marker.
- Type text on the screen.
- Highlight words.

Common Uses

The annotation tools help keep the screen visually interesting when the trainer “highlights” key words while speaking. For example, if the trainer displays a slide with words, they would use the highlighter annotation tool to select words of importance.

In most virtual classroom software programs, participants can be invited to annotate the screen. When they are able to draw or mark on the screen, it helps engage them with the learning content. For example, during a group

brainstorm activity, the annotation's text tool can be used to add text to a slide or whiteboard (see [Figure 4-5](#)).

Unique Characteristics

Check the participants' privileges to ensure they have (or can have) annotation rights. Some programs allow participants to annotate the screen if the option is selected. Other programs only allow presenters to annotate the screen.



Think About This

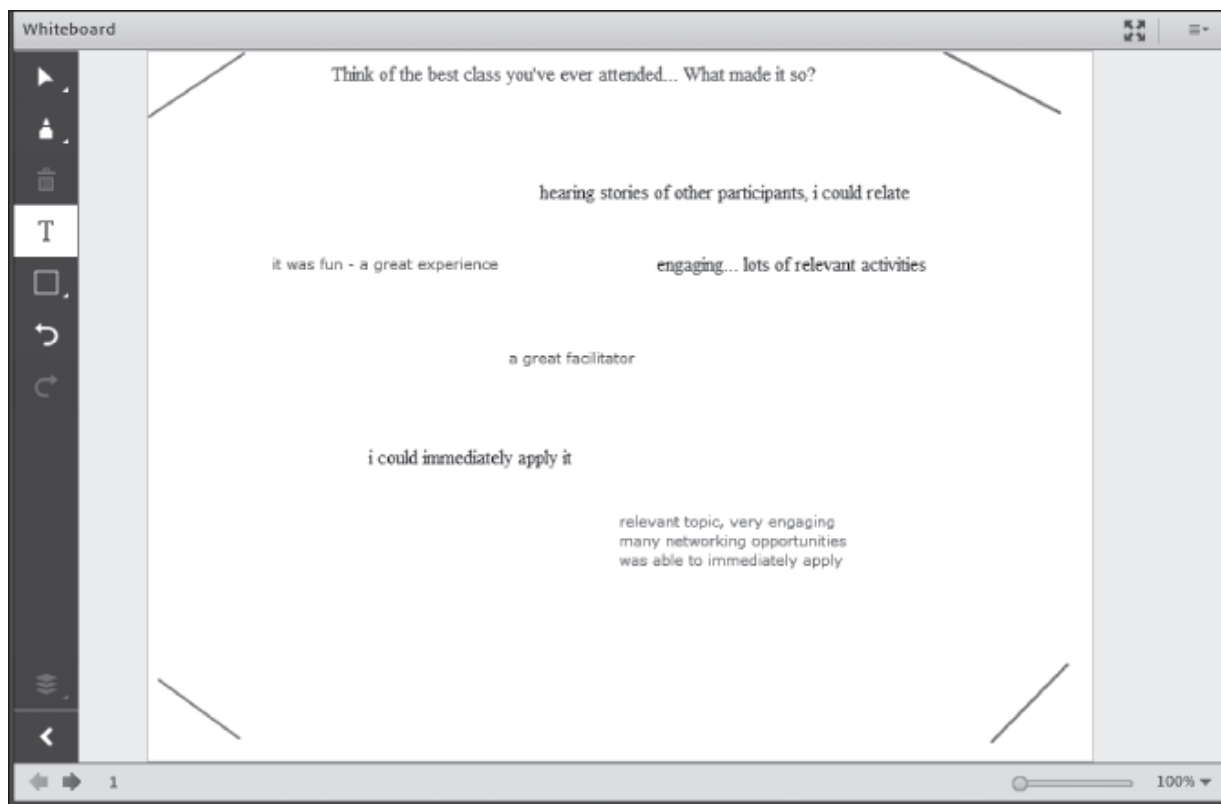
Great virtual trainers know all the tips and tricks of their preferred virtual classroom. Here's a quick tip that works in most software programs: To draw a perfectly straight line when using the line tool, hold down the shift key while you draw it.

Also learn how the eraser works. Find out who is able to erase what: Are you able to erase just your own annotations or all annotations? Find out the participants' privileges for erasing: Can they erase only their own annotations or all annotations? Are participants able to erase the presenter's annotations? If all annotations can be erased, be aware that this may affect one of your planned activities if someone accidentally erases all the marks on the screen.

Whiteboard

A virtual whiteboard is similar to a classroom whiteboard or flipchart. It's a blank screen that can be typed, written, or drawn on using the program's annotation tools.

Figure 4-5. Sample Whiteboard Annotation Activity in Adobe Connect



Common Uses

Whiteboards are used for brainstorming and other class activities that engage participants. Although the whiteboard screen starts as a blank page, the trainer can set it up ahead of time by adding drawings or other marks for an activity. For example, in one of my classes, we ask participants to conduct a SWOT analysis—strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats—using a whiteboard exercise. Prior to the class, I use my own annotation tools to draw two lines to make the grid, and type in the labels *strengths*, *weaknesses*, *opportunities*, and *threats*. At the appropriate time in class, I ask participants to type in suggestions on the screen.

Unique Characteristics

Check to see how many whiteboards can be open or shared at one time. If you plan to use more than one, see if you can rename the whiteboard for easy reference during class.

Check the participants' privileges to ensure they have (or can have) annotation rights for the whiteboard. Also check to see if there are any limitations to how many participants can annotate at one time. In addition, be sure to find out how the eraser tool works for both the presenter and participants.

Polling

Polls allow the trainer to ask survey questions in real time to participants. The questions can be multiple choice, multiple answer, or, in some programs, open ended.

Poll questions need to be initially created and then administered during the class. Creating a poll involves typing in the question and all possible responses. Administering the poll means sharing the poll at the correct time, opening it up for responses, closing the response window, and then sharing results with participants.

Common Uses

Polls can be used to survey participants in an unlimited number of ways. In [Figure 4-6](#), the trainer was delivering a class on communication skills and had just finished an activity for the participants to discover their preferred communication style. The trainer polled the class to find out their results.

Poll questions can also:

- Quiz participants' knowledge and understanding of a topic.
- Generate discussion using opinion questions.
- Solicit feedback from participants.

Unique Characteristics

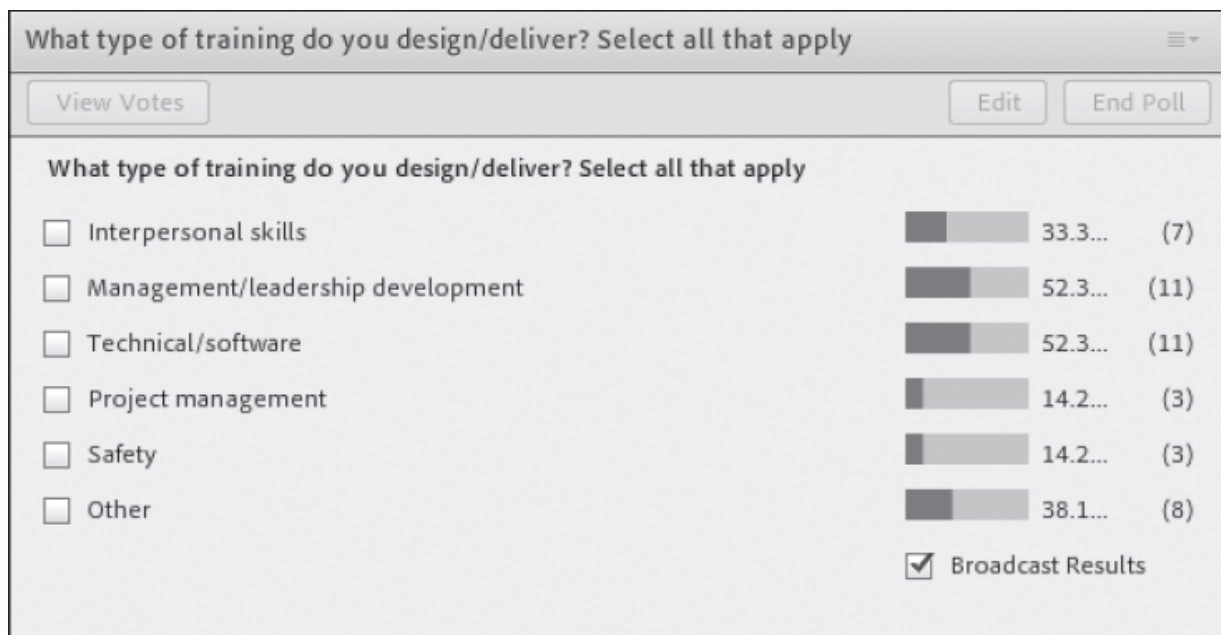
Some virtual classroom software programs allow for multiple questions in the same poll. Others limit each poll to one question. Therefore, plan the sequence of your poll questions accordingly.

Some virtual classroom software programs allow you to create polls ahead of time and store them as separate files that can be uploaded to the classroom when needed. In other programs, you may need to type in the poll questions and answers as part of your day-of-class setup.

Raise Hand or Change Status

Participants have the ability to communicate with the trainer by changing their status or raising their hand (see [Figure 4-7](#)). When someone clicks on this command, the trainer sees a small icon next to the participants' name indicating their status.

Figure 4-6. Sample Poll in Adobe Connect



Common Uses

This feature is often used for responding to closed-ended questions and quick yes/no polls. For example, a trainer might ask, "Who has seen this feature before? Please 'raise your hand.'"

A trainer could also inform participants that raising their hands is one way to ask a question during class. When someone clicks on the "raise your hand" option, the trainer will call on them to speak.

In the virtual classroom software programs that offer more options than just raising your hand, this feature can also be used for more advanced polling. Participants can choose to agree or disagree with a statement, or respond "yes" or "no." They can also use this feature to provide pacing feedback to the trainer, such as "speed up" or "slow down." And trainers can add an element of fun to virtual classes by encouraging use of applause and laughter statuses during group discussions.

Unique Characteristics

In some programs, only the host and presenter can see the status change or “vote” of the participants. Other programs allow everyone to see the hand raised or status change.

Figure 4-7. Status Indicators in Adobe Connect



Breakout Groups

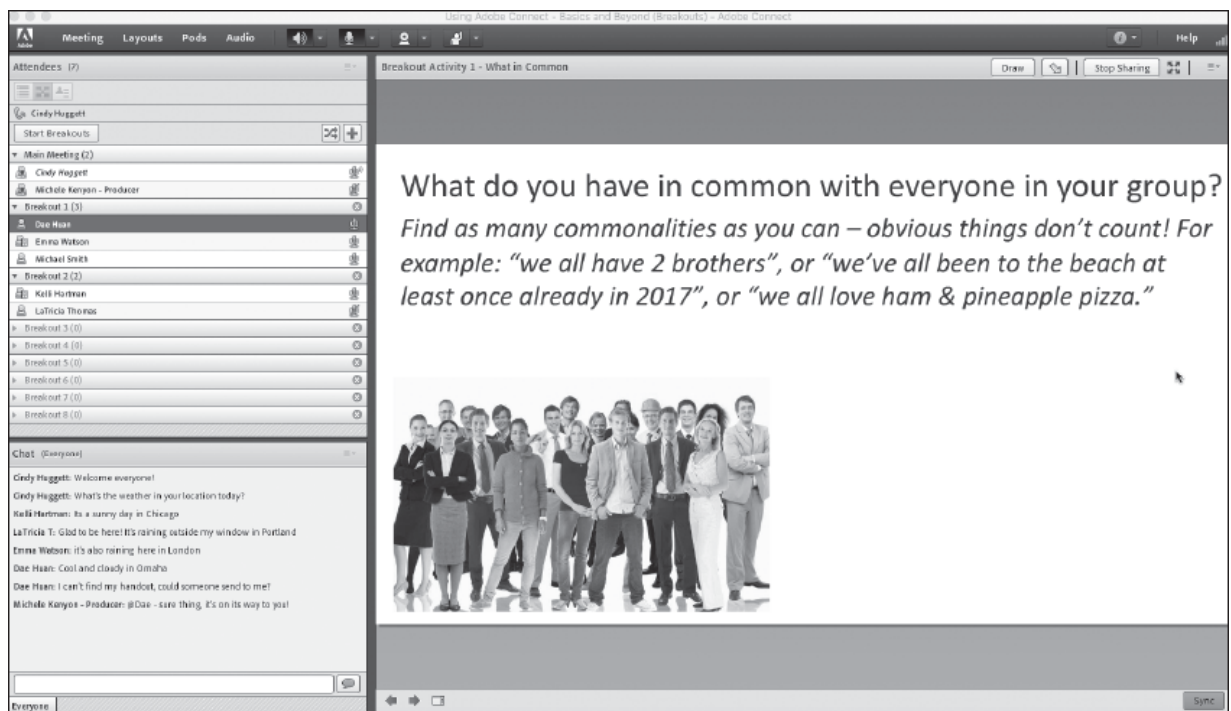
Breakout groups mimic small group activities in the face-to-face classroom (see [Figure 4-8](#)). If the trainer wants all participants to divide into smaller groups to complete a learning exercise, such as a skills practice or brainstorm activity, then the trainer would assign participants to a breakout group. For example, a class with 15 participants might split into three teams of five people each.

In the virtual classroom, it's the same thing: The trainer would divide the class into smaller groups and then activate the breakouts. Participants move into a virtual private meeting room where they hear only their private conversation. They can share documents and whiteboards among themselves and collaborate. The trainer has the ability to move in and out of the breakouts, just like they would walk around the room in a face-to-face session.

Common Uses

Breakout groups can be used to practice skills learned during the training event. For example, if the class learns techniques for how to start a coaching conversation with an employee, the individuals could practice those techniques in a small group setting. In a practice breakout, one participant could practice the new coaching skill, another participant could be on the receiving end of the practice, and a third participant could be the silent observer. The participants could then rotate roles, each having a chance to practice the new coaching skill.

Figure 4-8. Sample Breakout Room Activity in Adobe Connect



Another common use of breakouts is for small group brainstorming. Different groups could discuss different aspects of the same situation, or they could each discuss a different situation. You could even have the groups all discuss the same situation and then compare notes afterward.

In addition, any time you need to maximize participation, you might consider using breakout groups. These private collaboration sessions involve every participant because it's much tougher to hide in a small group. In other words, if you assign three participants to complete a group

task versus assigning 15 participants to complete it, participants in the smaller group are more likely to engage in the activity.

Unique Characteristics

The audio choice for the virtual event will dictate how the audio functions in the breakout. In other words, if you're using the virtual classroom software's VoIP integrated audio, then when you create the breakout groups, the audio will automatically update. Participants in a small group will only be able to hear each other, as if they were on a private line. However, if you use a separate conference calling line for the audio, then participants will need to manually move into their audio breakouts.

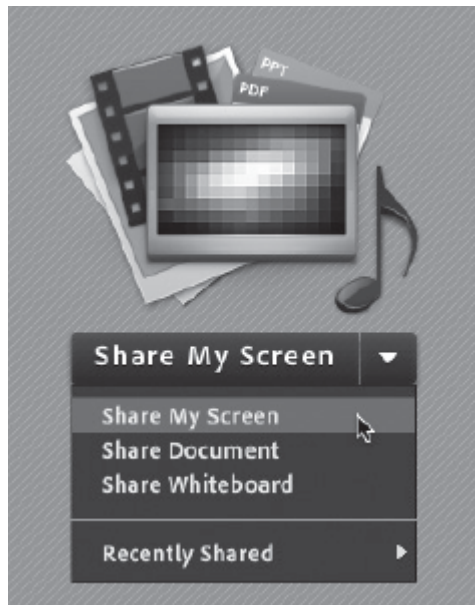
The number of breakout rooms available depends upon the virtual classroom software you're using. For example, one common platform currently has a limit of five breakout rooms at one time.

On the conference call provider I use most, I sign into the conference call as the moderator and press *21 to activate audio-only breakout groups. Then, when it is time for participants to use the audio breakouts, they press # and their group number on the telephone. At the end of the activity, they press ## on their telephone to rejoin the main line. As the moderator, I can press #0 to “force” everyone back to the main group.

Application Sharing

Application sharing allows trainers to open up their computer—specifically a certain software program, web browser, or desktop—to the participants (see [Figure 4-9](#)). Trainers select which application will be shared, and then participants will see it on their screen. When the trainer navigates through the program, participants follow along.

Figure 4-9. Screen Sharing in Adobe Connect



If the trainer shares her desktop, then the participants will view the trainer's computer, including all keyboard typing, mouse movements, and switching between programs. If the trainer shares a web browser, then the participants will see the trainer navigating the Internet. If the trainer shares a software program, then the participants will see just that one program.

The main difference between sharing your desktop and sharing just an application (either a software program or a web browser) is that when you choose to share your desktop, participants see everything. They will see your desktop's wallpaper, icons, and everything else you do on your computer. This feature can be useful if that's your goal. However, it is too revealing if you only want them to see one software program or just your web browser window.

A separate but related feature available in most virtual classroom software programs is a shared remote control. A participant can be given control of the mouse pointer so that they can navigate and edit in the shared application. This can be useful during software training when you want a participant to gain hands-on experience with the program. The participant can use the remote control to practice a new skill learned. However, most programs only allow one person to be in control, so large classes might not benefit from taking turns one at a time.

Common Uses

You could use application sharing when you need to display a file that is not supported by the virtual classroom program's document sharing. You could also use application sharing when you need to edit documents during class. For example, if you are demonstrating how to enter text into a file, then you would need to have the file open in editing mode, which is another way to think of application sharing. Perhaps the most common use of application sharing is when you are conducting software technical training in the virtual classroom. With application sharing, the software program becomes visible to all participants.

Unique Characteristics

There is often a lag time between the time the trainer selects the share application or share desktop command and when the participants see the trainer's screen. During this pause, let participants know that it might take a few moments so that they don't think something is wrong with their screen.

Some virtual classroom software programs distinguish between desktop sharing, application sharing, and web browser sharing, with separate tools for each. Other virtual classroom software programs combine these options into one command.

Getting It Done

It is critically important for you to know your software tools inside and out. A unique characteristic could be that the tool is only available under certain circumstances. For example, the annotation tools may not be visible to participants if they have not been granted privileges to use them. Or, the assign breakout command might only be available after you have clicked on a participant's name. Mastering your virtual classroom software means knowing every command and when it can be used.

Mastering the software also means knowing it from the presenter's perspective and from the participant's perspective. The participant's screen will not look exactly the same as yours. For example, the participants may see a raise hand button, while the presenter sees a make presenter button in its place. As the host or presenter, you will often need to teach participants how the virtual classroom software works, and therefore, you need to know it from their point of view.

In addition, if you have participants who join by mobile device and therefore will be using the platform's mobile app, it's important to know how the program differs. Find out if mobile users have access to all the tools, and, if not, which ones are available. Practice using the mobile app so that you can guide participants through the activities.

Finally, it's not enough to just read how tools work in an online help screen or user manual. You have to try them out yourself. There may be an undocumented quirk, or something about the feature that works in a way you didn't expect it to. Practice using the software so that you master it. Complete Worksheet 4-1 to determine which technology skills you want to learn more about.



Noted

"Become an expert on the software—and you can't be an expert just by using it once a month. I used online meeting software for all my remote meetings, not just training. This forced me to really know the tool inside and out. Great facilitators of in-person classes who do very few online facilitations just don't get comfortable enough with the software to transfer those great facilitation skills. You must know the tool. Attend all the training. Understand what every button does and when you would use it and when you would not. The biggest failure of online trainers is just not knowing the tool. It reflects badly on the course content and the experience."

—Michael Abrams, Director, Talent and Leadership Development, Ashley Furniture

Worksheet 4-1. Checklist for Learning Virtual Classroom Software

Use these questions to help you organize your notes while learning a new virtual classroom software program.

Name of virtual classroom software:

Which version?

Who is hosting the virtual classroom software? A vendor, a third party, or another option?

What sources of tech support for your virtual classroom software are available, such as telephone, web, classes, or dedicated support?

Use the following table to track your learning:

Feature	Unique Characteristics
Sharing documents	
Chat	
Annotation or drawing	
Whiteboard	
Polling	
Raise hand or change status	
Breakout groups	
Application sharing	
List other features here:	

Other notes about learning the software:

5

Prepare Your Workspace



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- how to prepare your virtual training classroom
- computer, Internet, and telephone connection considerations
- chronological steps to set up for a virtual class.

Prepare Your Workspace

What's the first step to building a house? The foundation? The cornerstone? The basement? No! The first step is planning—creating a blueprint for the final design. The successful completion of a finished house depends largely on how well it was planned.

The same holds true for virtual training. The success of your class will largely depend upon how well you have prepared. Setting up for success must be done in advance of classes you deliver—every class, every time.

In many ways, setting up for a successful virtual class is similar to setting up for a face-to-face class. You prepare your notes, double check the logistics, and find out about the participants. You arrive at the training location early to arrange the room appropriately and set up your equipment. You get your glass of water, put on a smile, and greet participants as they arrive.

It's the same with virtual training. You prepare your notes, double check the logistics, and find out about the participants. You also need to set up your equipment and arrive early to prepare the online classroom.

Preparing Your Virtual Classroom

Of course, because the delivery method of virtual training is different, your setup routine will naturally be different. You'll be setting up your computer and the virtual software instead of a physical classroom. You have different communication tools that need to be tested and ready to go. Your delivery workspace is usually your office, which needs to be prepared for training instead of your regular working routine.



Noted

“The learners want you to be successful.”
—Wendy Gates Corbett, CPLP, President and Lead Visualist,
Refresher Training

In both the face-to-face environment and the virtual one, the amount of time you spend preparing is probably equal to or more than the amount of time you spend in the class. You have to learn the content, get ready to deliver it, and ensure the class will meet the intended outcomes. An experienced virtual trainer would probably spend the same amount of preparation time as an experienced classroom trainer would take to prepare for a face-to-face class. However, you should heed Bob Pike’s classic advice from *Creative Training Techniques* (2003): “Proper preparation ... prevents poor performance.” This advice is even more important in virtual training delivery. There is less room for error because of the technology and the lack of visual connection with participants.

In addition to the event-specific preparation that classroom trainers do for each training class, there are also some general training preparation steps. For example, classroom trainers create a training supply kit and replenish it when needed. They keep their skills fresh by attending professional development programs. These types of general preparation steps are also necessary for virtual trainers.

Let’s begin with the general steps virtual trainers need to take to set up for success. These steps are not necessarily time sensitive or associated with a specific class. They are general things you should do to set up for any virtual training delivery.

Computer, Internet, and Telephone

Considerations

Your three main tools for virtual delivery are your computer, Internet connection, and telephone (unless you are using VoIP). Each needs to be carefully considered in your virtual training setup.

Computer

With the multitude of computer choices on the market, does it matter what kind you use for virtual training delivery? Yes and no. Whether it's a laptop, desktop, or ultra-portable device, as long as it meets the minimum technology requirements for your virtual classroom software, then it will be fine. You should also ensure the computer has all necessary software and accessories for your class. For example, if you plan to use audiovisual media during the session, be sure you have a sound card and speakers.

You may have personal preferences, such as a full-size keyboard or a regular mouse instead of your laptop's touchpad, so you should select the types of tools that are most comfortable for you.

If you use an ultra-portable laptop, be aware that its small size may prevent you from seeing the screen clearly. This limitation could affect the quality of your training delivery. For example, if you miss seeing someone's hand raised because of the tiny icon on your small screen, a participant's question might go unanswered.

Over the past few years, there's been a sharp increase in use of smartphones in place of full-size computers for browsing the Internet. The line is blurring between computers and smartphones in terms of functionality and power. While it is possible to use some smartphones to connect to a virtual training event, it is not yet an ideal solution for the host or trainer.

Even though most virtual classroom software programs can run on smartphones, they usually have limited capability. Some virtual classroom mobile apps don't support presenter privileges and therefore cannot be used to fully facilitate a virtual training event. There are workarounds, such as starting the meeting as the host and allowing someone else to present. Unfortunately, that would be like a trainer trying to conduct a face-to-face class from a remote location over a conference phone. While it's possible to do that in a pinch, it's not the way you would want to run a training class. So, while technically it may be possible to deliver virtual training using a smartphone, it should not be your first choice.

Computer Contingency Planning

When delivering a virtual class, you should have two computers on your desk. The first computer is your main terminal. Use it to log in as the host or presenter (depending upon your role and which software you are using).

Ensure that all the files you need, including your shared documents, are available to you on this computer.

The second computer is what you use to log in to the class as a participant. You don't actively use this computer during the class. Instead, you should glance at it periodically, like you would a sideview mirror when driving. This computer will show you what the participants are seeing at any given time, which is important because your presenter screen will not look the same as the participant screen.

Wendy Gates Corbett, president and lead visualist at Refresher Training, calls this second computer her "sidekick" because it sits next to her main computer on her desk. I also use two laptops when facilitating programs (see [Figure 5-1](#)).



Basic Rule 9

Have at least one backup plan for equipment technology. You never know when you might need to use it.

Another benefit to having a second computer is the insurance it provides. Should your main computer unexpectedly crash or have connection difficulties, the second computer could become your main one. Because it's right there on your desk, already powered up and ready to go, it would be a quick transition.

Speaking of insurance, part of your overall computer setup for virtual delivery should include contingency planning. You should consider ahead of time what you would do if your computer unexpectedly stopped working.

Figure 5-1. Cindy's Virtual Training Workspace

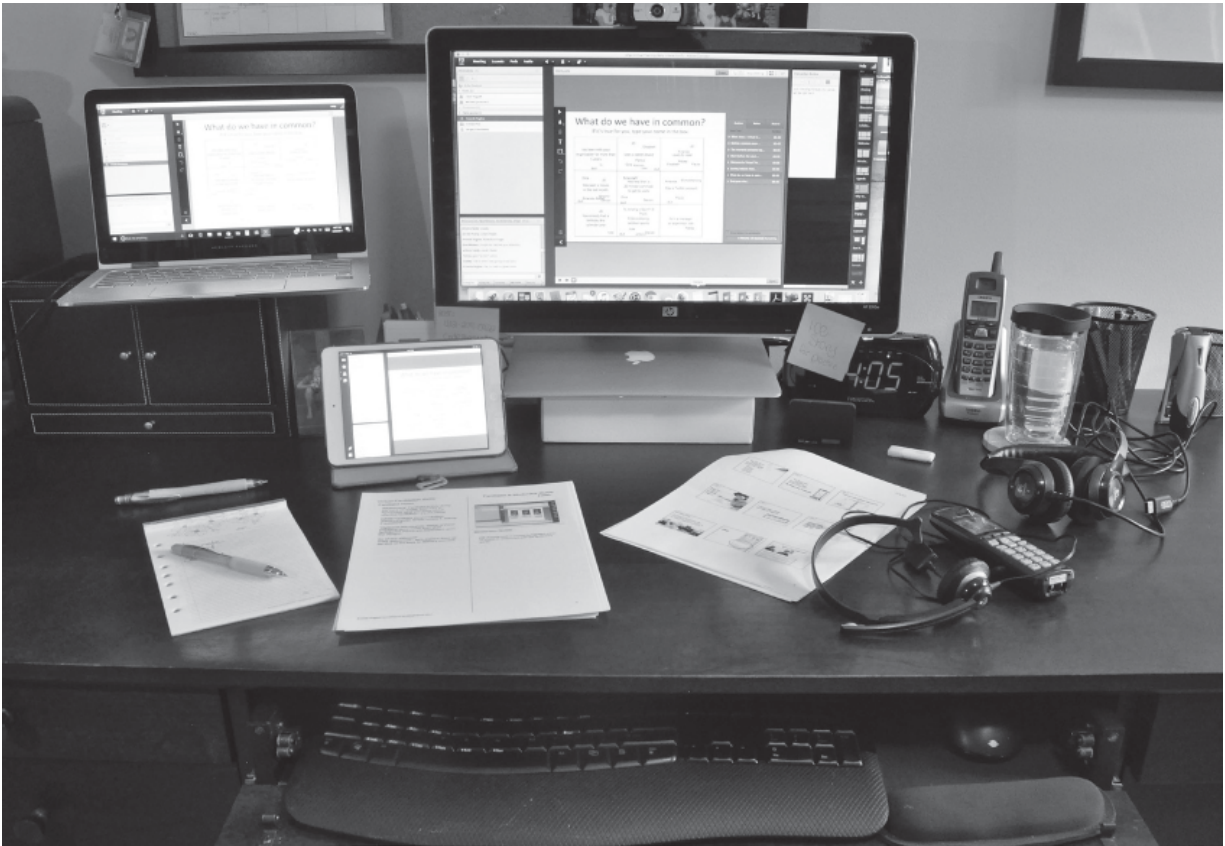


PHOTO CREDIT: EMMA

Having the second sidekick computer is one recommended backup option. If you have a third computer available, even better! You might easily have access to a third computer if you work in an office environment. If you work from home, you might be able to borrow one from your family or a neighbor, or even use a nearby public computer lab (if it's a quiet environment!). Regardless of the options immediately available to you, take some time to think about what alternatives you could use if needed.

However, your computer backup plans shouldn't stop there. If you need to quickly switch to another computer, make sure it's ready for you to use it right away. For example, if your virtual classroom software requires plug-ins, download them ahead of time just in case. Have a second copy of your training files already loaded onto the backup computer, or at least onto a portable USB drive. Your secondary computer choice should be 100 percent prepared, as if it were going to be your primary computer.

Internet Connection

The second necessity for successful virtual delivery is a reliable Internet connection. Without question, you should have high-speed connectivity. You do not want to have the slowest connection of the class. Your setup should not detract from the training class in any way, which could result from a slow Internet connection.

If you're working from an office, the Internet speed should not be a factor because most corporate offices have fast connections. If for any reason your work environment does not have a high-speed connection, find another location that has a strong, stable connection from which to deliver your training session.

The choice of wired or wireless Internet is not as important as the reliability of your connection. If you normally use wireless Internet but do not have a strong, steady signal, then change to a more dependable wired connection.

There are times that you may need to deliver a virtual training session from a remote location—somewhere other than your usual spot. For example, you may be traveling and need to facilitate training from your hotel room or airport lounge conference room. Once again, as long as you have a strong, steady, reliable Internet connection, your physical location should not matter. (Of course, if you are in a public location, ensure the background noise will not distract from your delivery.)

Internet Contingency Planning

When setting up for your virtual training sessions, create backup plans for connecting to the Internet. Just like having a spare computer is essential, knowing where else you could quickly find an Internet connection is also important. Ask yourself, “What would I do if I lost Internet connectivity just prior to or during a session?”

Once again, if you work in a corporate office environment, the reliability of your Internet connection will probably not be an issue. However, it is still a good idea to know if there is a neighboring office building or public Wi-Fi hotspot nearby. If you frequently deliver virtual training, consider having a backup Internet option, such as a broadband wireless card through a cellular service provider.

Another part of your preparation should be to create a backup plan for what to do if you don't have Internet at all. A few possibilities are to:

- Coordinate with your producer or co-facilitator to have them run the session.
- Use a smartphone to connect (if your virtual classroom software program supports it) and ask someone else to navigate the screen.
- Reschedule the session for another time.

None of these options is ideal, so remember to plan additional Internet possibilities. With the abundance of wireless and cellular Internet options with data plans available in most locations, this extra planning should be a standard part of your virtual delivery setup.

Telephone Connection

As we discussed in [chapter 3](#), unless you plan to use the virtual classroom software's VoIP capabilities, you will need a telephone for the audio connection.

Whether you work in a business environment or a home office, you will most likely have a telephone and handset at your desk. You probably also have a cell phone you could use. And, if you plan to deliver from a conference room in an office, you may have a conference room-style speakerphone.

With all these choices, which one should you use to deliver virtual training? Similar to your Internet choice, your actual telephone selection is not as important as the clarity of its sound. The connection should be strong, reliable, and crystal clear. That means if you normally use a cell phone but occasionally experience dropped calls or have a weak signal, use a landline.

Because you need to use your hands for typing on the keyboard and clicking with the mouse, you should have a hands-free telephone setup. However, do not use a speakerphone because of the potential for echo and background noise.

Use a cordless telephone when possible. It gives you the ability to get up and move around while facilitating. Joe Willmore, president and founder of Willmore Consulting Group, also recommends using a cordless telephone because if a participant asks a question, instead of writing it down and saying he'll get back to them, he can walk over to his bookshelf and look up the answer. Also, some trainers like to stand while talking so there's more

energy in their voice. A cordless telephone gives you the freedom and flexibility to do this.

For my hands-free connection, I use a cordless telephone with a wired headset connected to the handset. I can stand up and move around if needed. The wired headset has a headband, earphone, and extended microphone. It also has adjustable volume and a mute button. I prefer a wired headset because it minimizes any potential for electronic interference.

Telephone Contingency Planning

You should have contingency plans for not only your computer and Internet connection, but also your audio connection. Consider all your alternatives for audio connectivity. For example: If your telephone equipment stopped working, what nearby telephone could you easily access? Do you have another cordless handset? Do you have more than one telephone connection option, such as a landline and a cell phone?

Here are some tips to help you form a telephone backup plan:

- Make sure each primary and backup telephone you plan to use is fully charged prior to the event.
- Make sure all your cords are plugged in securely to all outlets, receptacles, and equipment. Also make sure the cords are not in the way and will not be potential hazards to trip over in case you stand up or move.
- If relying on a mobile device for audio, make sure you have the charging cord on hand. Also, plan to use a noise-cancelling headset designed for your mobile device, to have the best audio connection possible.

Setting Up for Success

Now that you have secured the basics for virtual delivery, let's look in chronological order at all the other steps involved with setting up for success.

Two Weeks Prior to Class

Approximately two weeks before your virtual training event, you should have all the logistics set and materials prepared.

First, regardless of who sets up the administrative details of your event, you should have all logistical information ready well in advance of the class. This information includes:

- course information, like the class name, instructor notes, and participant information
- the virtual classroom event website link and all passcodes
- conference call numbers and passcodes for the moderator or host and participants.

It is a misperception that virtual events can be organized closer to the delivery date because details can be communicated quickly through email. The reality is that all logistics should be planned and communicated well in advance. It *is* important to send email or other reminders prior to the session; however, these reminders should not take the place of initial communication.

If your organization uses scheduling software like Microsoft Outlook or Google Calendar, put logistical details in the calendar request. The event appointment should contain all website links, passcodes, and any prerequisite material that is needed for class. In my experience, participants who receive an official meeting request to hold the time on their calendar will also look to that electronic appointment reminder for the connection details. Having all the details in that location will minimize the need for participants to search for the information just prior to the class start time.

Second, around this time you should prepare all necessary class materials. The materials include the content, your facilitator guide, any virtual classroom activities that need advance preparation, and all participant materials.



Basic Rule 10

Use a strong, reliable Internet connection and a crystal-clear telephone line.

The first time you deliver a class, you need to both learn the material and prepare your training notes. You may have a formal facilitator guide to follow, or maybe just an informal text file with notes. The format of the facilitator guide varies depending upon its source. If you wear multiple hats, such as instructional designer and trainer, then you may even design your

own facilitator guide. See [chapter 11](#) for more details on designing a virtual class.

Even if this is the 50th time you have delivered the same class, you should prepare your training notes every time. The same class for you will be a new class for your learners. Each audience has unique needs, so you should not only remind yourself of the class material, but also tailor your content to the group. For example, the stories you share may need to be updated, or the questions you ask might need to be in a new context.

As you learn about the needs of your learners, you can also find out their lingo and incorporate it into your notes. Maybe they refer to themselves as associates instead of employees, or they have supervisors instead of managers. These details will help you better connect with your audience and enhance their learning experience.

All trainers have their own way of preparing the facilitator guide. Some write all over their guide with circles, underlines, stars, highlights, and other identifying marks. Others use sticky notes on the guide pages so they can change their notes for each class. There is no one right way to prepare your facilitator guide. What's important is that you can follow it during the class as you intended.

My personal preference for facilitator guide preparation is to print all materials (mine are usually in electronic format). I highlight all the key words in the guide, and write notes in big bold print so that I don't miss anything. I occasionally place small sticky notes strategically in the guide to hold stories or promptings. I use tape flags to mark sections of the guide and any important reference pages.

I also print all participant materials, and a six-slide-per-page handout version of my slides. On the handout, I write a brief description of what should be happening in the class just before that slide is displayed. For example, if we will use a whiteboard activity, I'll write *whiteboard*, or if we will use a specific poll question, I'll write *poll #3*. This handout document serves as my big-picture view of the class and becomes one of my backup plans should anything happen to my trainer notes.



Noted

“My co-facilitator had to work from home with a sick child and possibly step away to deal with a medical emergency. We worked out [that] if one of us wasn’t there, the other would immediately step in and cover, making it seamless for the participants.”

—Joe Willmore, President and Founder, Willmore Consulting Group

In addition, I use a manila file folder to hold my papers for each class. I write the connection information for the host and participants on the inside front cover. I also put a large ruled sticky note on the inside front cover with a checklist of everything I need to do to prepare the virtual classroom, such as polls to upload, attendee privileges to check, and whiteboards to share and rename. Inside the folder is a copy of the participant list, all emergency contact information, my facilitator notes, and the participant materials.

Third, if you are new or relatively new to virtual delivery, you should be practicing your facilitation skills using the virtual classroom software at least two weeks (or more) prior to the event. Don’t wait until the last minute to begin practicing. We’ll cover more information about practicing in [chapter 9](#).



Think About This

Check the calendar to see if any holidays fall close to your training event. If so, anticipate that some participants may be out on vacation around that time and send reminders well in advance.

A Week Prior to Class

Approximately one week before class, you should be working with your producer or co-facilitator (if you have one) to solidify all delivery details. Take time to figure out exactly when and how presenter handoffs will occur during the session. Determine who will take responsibility for which parts of the program, and who will “drive” the software tools. For example, if one person will use the annotation tools to highlight words on the slide while the other person is talking, agree on what words will be highlighted and when. Or, if a participant question appears in the chat window, decide ahead of time how and when the person with chat moderator responsibilities will interrupt the speaker.

Also, if you are working with a producer or co-facilitator, decide on a way for you to communicate outside the virtual classroom software. For example, will you be able to text one another during the class, or will you have a separate instant messenger program available? This backup communication option might come in handy during emergency situations before or during the class.

Finally, if you are using a virtual classroom software program that allows you to set up the “room” in advance, go ahead and prepare it at least three business days prior to the event. While three days may seem like excess time, it will give you extra cushion—just in case your time gets filled with an unexpected calamity, such as an illness.

The Day Before the Class

The day before your class, you should double check all critical training details. These include:

- reviewing the class roster or participant list for any last-minute changes or additions
- reviewing your training notes one last time
- reviewing your backup contingency plans
- charging all electronic equipment.

You should also double check the class time and time zones. Joe Willmore tells the story of how he had a virtual training event scheduled on his calendar in Eastern Standard Time. However, he was out of town that week, and happened to be in the Central Standard Time zone. The time on his calendar was one hour different than the event time. He realized his mistake a few minutes before the event was to begin. Fortunately, his producer was already online with the participants, and Joe was able to log in just in time for the event. His lesson learned? To always double and triple check the time and time zone for each event.

In addition, the day before the class, participants should receive one final reminder about the training event. To make it interesting, and not just another reminder, provide a brainteaser or interesting statistic related to the course content along with the reminder. This will help get your participants thinking about the topic and prepared to learn.

The Day of Class

Your day-of-training routine will vary depending upon what time of day the event is scheduled. With virtual training, it could be scheduled for any time of day depending upon where your participants are located. I've delivered virtual training at 5 a.m. and at 11 p.m. to accommodate international participants in different time zones. Therefore, "day of class" means the day of the event, a few hours prior to it.

First, set up your workspace for the training event. Clear your desk of everything except what you'll need to deliver virtually. Make sure your notes are organized and everything is where you want it to be. Have your class roster accessible on your desk, along with a pen or pencil to mark on it. I also find it helpful to have a notepad nearby in case I need to jot down a note during class. Also have all the connection details—the weblinks, conference call numbers, and passcodes—written down or printed out on paper on your desk. This way, if you lose Internet connectivity or your computer unexpectedly stops working, you have all the connection information immediately available.

Here's a tip from Wendy Gates Corbett: Always reboot your computer prior to your virtual training delivery. While it may not be technically necessary to do this, it helps close down any open files and gives you a fresh start.

You should be in a room by yourself for your training delivery. This is important to minimize any background noise or conversations. For example, you would not want to deliver virtually from a cubicle office environment. The potential for disruption, from loud conversations in the background to someone walking into your workspace, is just too great.



Think About This

Some trainers who work in an open space or cubicle environment find that it is difficult to locate an empty, enclosed room in their office location to deliver training. If this is a problem for you, get creative to explore alternative delivery spaces. You could consider:

- working from a home office on days when you deliver virtual training
- creating a designated virtual training delivery room in your office building
- borrowing someone else's office for training delivery.

Also, I don't recommend having any participants in the room with you—even if it's a large conference room. You should not try to present online and in person at the same time. Your focus will be divided between the

groups, and you will subconsciously favor one group over the other. It will be a very subtle difference, barely noticeable by most, but it will still have impact. For example, you might say something like, “As you can see here...” referring to something that only the in-person group can see. Or when you call on participants by name, you may use the names from the participant list disproportionately because you see them in writing on your screen. Therefore, when setting up your workspace, make it a private one.

Next, check the power levels of your electronic equipment. Even if you charged them up the day before or overnight, check again to ensure they have full battery power available.

You should also take care of your personal needs starting a few hours prior to the event. For example, find a middle ground between an empty and a full stomach. You don’t want to be distracted by hunger, but also not overly full and uncomfortable. Use the bathroom so that you don’t have to step away from the computer during your session, and limit your liquid intake to a level that works for you.

Also set a bottle of room temperature water near your workspace. If necessary, go ahead and crack open the bottle’s seal, but leave it covered to protect from any spills. If you prefer a glass, find one with a lid or use a plastic-wrap covering.



Noted

“Even if your computer could run on battery power during your delivery, use it plugged in. Why? In case you lose power, you’ll still have ‘juice’ to keep going.”

—Joe Willmore, President and Founder, Willmore Consulting Group

If you work in an office environment and plan to use a conference room for delivery, when reserving the room be sure to start your room reservation at least one hour before your session begins. For example, if your virtual training session begins at 10 a.m., then reserve the conference room starting at 9 a.m. This scheduling tactic will give you enough time to get into the room for set up without any scheduling conflicts.

If you work from home, make plans for your pets, children, or other family members who might disturb you during your session. You might close off an area of the house for pets to stay during your virtual deliveries, so that they don’t unexpectedly disrupt your class. While your dog may

normally be a quiet companion, the doorbell may ring and result in barking. A separate pet space will also prevent cats from jumping up onto your keyboard during the session.

Alert other people in your house to your training schedule and make a “Do Not Disturb” sign for the door as a reminder. If you’re on the road and delivering virtually from a hotel room, place the hotel’s “Do Not Disturb” sign on your door so that you will not be interrupted.



Noted

“My son made a sign for my home office door. It says, ‘Do Not Enter: Virtual Classroom in Session.’”

—Tracy Stallard, Independent Training Consultant

In my home office, I close the door before a virtual training class. I also keep a cat toy in my desk drawer. In the unlikely event that a family member unexpectedly opens the door and my cat wanders in, I can quickly reach for the toy and toss it out into the hallway, which distracts my cat and gives me a chance to close the door.

An Hour Before Class

One hour before class is “showtime” in my book. I log in to the virtual classroom approximately 45-60 minutes prior to a session. Although this may seem early, the extra time gives me a chance to check the technology connections and make sure everything is working as it should. If I’m using a time-specific virtual classroom software, then I’ll also use this time to set the classroom: sharing documents, loading poll questions, opening whiteboards, and checking participant privileges. My goal is to be ready for delivery at least 30 minutes before the session begins. If you are using the recommended sidekick computer, go ahead and log in to the virtual classroom on it as well.

If I’m working with a producer who will handle the technology setup, then I log in approximately 30-35 minutes prior to the class start time. I want to be online and settled before any participants arrive.



Noted

“I have a whiteboard over my desk with key thoughts and themes on it. It’s my ‘centering’ and my focal point. My key thoughts include ‘Breathe,’ ‘Be calm,’ ‘Talk at a normal pace,’ ‘You are the expert,’ ‘Have fun,’ and ‘They’re here to learn.’ I also post key themes of the class, and a few story ideas. That way, if something goes wrong and I need to fill time, I have an immediate story to tell. There are times I never look at it, and times I need it.”

—Jeff Smith, CEO, Voltage Leadership Consulting

15 Minutes Before Class

Connect to the audio, take a deep breath, be ready to greet participants, and have fun!

Getting It Done

The more prepared you are for your virtual delivery, the more relaxed you will be. You’ll have confidence in your equipment, in your knowledge of the content, in your comfort with the technology, and in your readiness to deliver. Do not overlook the importance of your preparation. Build in enough time to fully prepare for the training. Set yourself up for success.

Use the checklist in Worksheet 5-1 to ensure you are extra prepared for virtual delivery.

Worksheet 5-1. The Extra Prepared Virtual Trainer Checklist

Virtual Classroom Software

☐	I know the full extent of capabilities that the virtual classroom software has.
☐	When logged in as the host, I know what every button and every menu command does.
☐	When logged in as the presenter, I know what every button and every menu command does.
☐	When logged in as a participant, I know what every button and every menu command does.
☐	I am aware of all unique features of the virtual classroom software (for example, how many breakout groups can be used at one time).
☐	I know what file types are supported by the virtual classroom software's file-sharing feature.
☐	I have tested every feature and activity that we will be using in the virtual classroom during my training event.
	Subtotal

Internet

☐	I have a solid high-speed Internet connection in the location where I will be delivering virtual training.
☐	I have a backup Internet connection available in the location where I will be delivering virtual training.
☐	I have a second backup Internet connection available in the location where I will be delivering virtual training.
	Subtotal

Computer

☐	I have a reliable computer or laptop that I will use to deliver virtual training.
☐	I have a second reliable computer or laptop that I will use as a “sidekick” when delivering virtual training.
☐	I have another backup reliable computer, laptop, or tablet that I can use as a backup to my main or sidekick computer to deliver virtual training.
☐	All software, drivers, and plug-ins necessary to deliver virtual training are fully installed on all my primary and backup computers.
☐	All my devices and backup devices are powered on and ready to go prior to the start time of my virtual training event.
☐	All my devices and backup devices are fully charged and can run from battery power if needed.
	Subtotal

Telephony

☐	I have reliable telephone service that I will use when delivering virtual training.
☐	I have a backup telephone connection that can be used if needed (i.e., my main telephone is a landline and my backup telephone is a cell phone).
☐	I have a second backup telephone connection that can be used if needed (i.e., my main telephone is a landline, my backup telephone is a cell phone, and my second backup uses a different cell service provider).
☐	I have a compatible hands-free headset to use with my telephone.
☐	I have a backup compatible hands-free headset to use with my telephone.
☐	My telephone and all accessories I use have a clear sound connection (i.e., I can be clearly heard at all times when speaking).
☐	All backup telephones and accessories have a clear sound connection (i.e., I can be clearly heard at all times when speaking).
☐	My primary telephone handset is fully charged prior to the start of the virtual training event.
☐	All of my backup telephones are fully charged prior to the start of the virtual training event.
	Subtotal

Training Files

☐	I have a printed copy of every training file associated with the virtual training event (i.e., facilitator guide, participant workbook, saved poll questions, etc.).
☐	I have a second printed copy of every training file associated with the virtual training event.
☐	I have an electronic copy of every training file associated with the virtual training event that can be easily accessed from my computer.
☐	I have an electronic copy of every training file associated with the virtual training event that can be easily accessed on every backup computer, even if the Internet connection is down.
☐	I have an electronic copy of every training file associated with the virtual training event that can be easily accessed from any computer with an Internet connection (i.e., stored on an accessible website).
	Subtotal

Training Event

☐	I have all web links for my virtual training event, including host, presenter, and participant links if they are different.
☐	I have all event passcodes, including host, presenter, and participant codes if they are different.
☐	I have all teleconference details, including moderator and participant codes.
☐	I know all the teleconference commands for moderators (e.g., *21 to activate breakout groups).
☐	I know all the teleconference participant commands (e.g., *6 to mute and *7 to unmute an individual telephone line).
☐	I have all logistical details, including web links, passcodes, and teleconference information, printed out prior to the virtual training event.
	Subtotal

Facilitator Support

☐	I have a producer who will assist with all technical details of the virtual training event.
☐	I have a backup producer who could fill in for the producer if needed.
☐	I have another facilitator or trainer who could fill in for me at the last minute if needed.
☐	I have a second backup facilitator or trainer who could fill in for me at the last minute if needed.
☐	I have a technology specialist available to assist participants behind the scenes.
☐	I have made sure that a technical support person who is knowledgeable of the virtual classroom software and teleconference service is on-site or available at every location participants are located.
	Subtotal

And because this is an extra-prepared checklist, here's a bonus section.

Participants

☐	I know the participants' full names and job positions prior to the virtual training event.
☐	I know the length of time participants have been with their organization.
☐	I know the length of time participants have been in their current role.
☐	I know the biggest challenges the participants have related to the training topic.
☐	I know the questions that participants will have related to the training topic.
☐	I know whether participants have talked with their direct supervisor about the training topic.
☐	I know whether participants will be held accountable for what they learn.
☐	I have personally spoken to or exchanged messages with each participant about the training event.
☐	I have verified that participants have completed all prerequisites or pre-session assignments for the training topic.
	Subtotal
	Grand Total

Scoring Key

60	Fantastic! Enter your name on the Extra Prepared Facilitator All-Star List!
50–59	Excellent! Consider helping other trainers learn from your preparation efforts.
40–49	Congratulations! You are extra prepared to deliver virtual training.
30–39	You are prepared, but have room for improvement. Select a few areas where you can improve your preparation.
20–29	You are on the verge of preparation. Identify the next five items you can add to your virtual delivery preparation.
10–19	You have started to prepare and have opportunity to improve. Select 10 items from this checklist that are most important for you and make an effort to add those to your list.
0–9	Ask an experienced virtual facilitator for assistance in getting started.

Huggett (2017).

6

Get Really Good at Multitasking



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- the connection between speed and successful multitasking
- 10 tips for becoming a better multitasker.

Get Really Good at Multitasking

Many new virtual trainers are surprised at how much there is to do while facilitating an online class. There are so many sections of the screen that need attention, and so many moving parts to track at the same time. You may know this feeling if you have ever tried to host a dinner party. Your goal is to have dinner on the table at 7 p.m., yet it seems that every recipe needs last-minute attention and it's impossible to get everything on the table at the same time. This same situation often occurs during virtual classes, when you are trying to achieve a learning goal and multiple onscreen things need your attention at once.

In many ways, multitasking in the virtual classroom is like driving a car. When you drive, you need to keep your eyes focused straight ahead on the road. Yet, you use your peripheral vision to watch for unexpected changes. You frequently glance in your rearview mirror and check your side mirrors as well. You are also pressing down the gas pedal, steering the car, watching your speed, and listening to the radio. In addition, you may adjust the temperature, switch radio stations, or turn on your windshield wipers. And let's not forget that you are looking at street signs, stopping at signal lights, and paying attention to pedestrians and the other drivers around you. You may also be chatting with the passengers in your car. If something goes wrong, like a dashboard warning light coming on, you manage the situation, taking precautions to remedy it. And all the while, you're driving with a destination in mind and moving toward it. Getting there is dependent upon your car and your ability to drive it.

When you first learned how to drive, remembering to do all those things at once was a challenge. You had to practice and practice and practice some more. You probably had a learner's permit, took driving lessons, and needed an escort in the car with you. You may have been able to drive during daytime hours only at first, and then gradually added in nighttime driving once you gained more experience.

It will be the same in the virtual classroom. At first, it may seem like everything is coming at you at once, and there are so many steps to remember. You have to manage the technology and keep your eyes on the main screen, but also remember to check the chat window, the participant list, your facilitator notes, and your sidekick computer. You need to prepare for the next activity while keeping everyone's focus and attention on the current one. You have to watch the clock and remember to engage the participants.

Rest assured that like driving, multitasking in the virtual classroom will get easier over time. After learning the software, understanding the technology, practicing your delivery techniques, and perhaps even working with a more experienced virtual trainer, you will master the multitasking required to be effective. With practice, it will eventually feel like second nature.

The Connection Between Speed and Multitasking

Another way to think about multitasking is to consider the way your computer works. If you have multiple programs open on your computer desktop simultaneously—an Internet browser, your email program, a word-processing program, an instant messenger, and so on—it seems as if the computer handles all these things at once. In reality, the computer processor can only take one command at a time. It just seems to handle them all at once because of the speed at which the commands are processed. The faster the processor speed, the faster the computer works.

The human brain is often compared to a computer processor. Our brain processes commands, thoughts, tasks, and other complex information. Like the computer, we are seemingly able to process many things at once. Most important, it is the *speed* at which we're able to process information and complete tasks that is important to our success at multitasking. If you can speed up, then you will, to improve your ability to multitask.



Think About This

Some people seem to naturally be better at multitasking than others. It's as if they can balance more than one thing at a time, and they make it look easy. Meanwhile, other people can only concentrate on what's in front of them at the moment. If there's too much going on at once, they feel overloaded and overwhelmed.

Some people prefer a fast-paced environment. They constantly move from one thing to the next, often doing more than one thing at a time. Multitasking seems natural to them. However, many other people prefer a slower pace. They focus on one task, and then the next.

Neither method is better than the other. It's simply something to be aware of in yourself. Do you prefer a fast- or slow-paced environment? As you go about your work over the next few days, pay attention to your preferred style. Do you quickly move between tasks with multiple things going on at once, or do you prefer to focus on just one thing at a time? Knowing your preference will help you know ahead of time how you might react to multitasking in the virtual classroom.

It is possible to learn to speed up and therefore increase your multitasking skills. Of course, speed is one, but not the only, significant factor in successful multitasking. Let's look at all the ways you can learn to be a better multitasker.

How to Multitask

First, if you follow the other steps in this book, you will automatically be a better multitasker. When you are prepared, know the software, practice, and set yourself up for success, you will be able to concentrate on everything else that needs to be done while delivering your presentation.

On the other hand, if you are not quite comfortable with the technology, or you try to wing it with the material, you will simply add to your stress level and likely have more difficulty. You will suffer at the hand of all the things you need to do to be an effective virtual trainer.



Basic Rule 11

The more prepared you are, the better you will be able to multitask.

I recommend the following 10 tips to help you get really good at multitasking in the virtual classroom. Some of these tips will enable you to

quicken your processing speed; others will help you be a more effective multitasker:

1. Set up for success.
2. Be prepared with content.
3. Know your virtual classroom software program.
4. Have a producer or co-facilitator.
5. Be a proficient typist.
6. Build in pauses to regroup.
7. Practice multitasking.
8. Remember how you do it in the face-to-face classroom.
9. Resist the temptation to do too much.
10. Know what's OK to let slide.

Set Up for Success

One reason you are able to multitask successfully when driving is because you know where to consistently find everything on the console and dashboard. The same should be true when you deliver in the virtual classroom. You should be able to mentally picture every item in your workspace and be able to reach for it without much thought. You should also know where to find everything on your computer screen. The goal is to be able to do things without having to stop and concentrate on them.

To help you meet this goal, set up your workspace for maximum efficiency. Clean your desk so that it's neat and organized. Have your trainer notes and other papers in order, clipped together so they stay in place. If possible, use a swivel chair on wheels so you can move and turn easily. When everything is organized, you won't need to worry about where things are or how to reach them.

Set up your workspace the same way for every class. You may need to experiment a few times to see what specific setup works best for you. This consistent setup will start to feel comfortable and natural, which will help you multitask.



Think About This

Comfort, organization, and consistency are key in setting up your workspace. I'm left-handed, so for my own setup, I place my laptop on the right side of my desk toward the back. My telephone is tucked in beside the laptop. My trainer notes are on the left side of the laptop, with the handout perched on a stand. My sidekick computer is on the far-right side of my desk, turned sideways for easy viewing. I also have a small table next to my desk with backup notes, files, and accessories.

When your workspace is set up appropriately, with everything you need in reach, you will be able to automate your work flow. It will be a breeze to reach for what you need when you need it, which, in turn, will help you move faster and be more efficient. Speed in movement helps you multitask.

Be Prepared With Content

You should know your training material and content so well that you could facilitate in your sleep. Never try to wing it in the virtual classroom. If you do, your mind will have to work harder to figure out what you are going to do next.

I'm not advocating that you should have every word memorized or read directly from a script. Instead, you should know your content well so that it's not a stumbling block when facilitating. The more familiar you are with your content, the easier it will be for you to speak while focusing on other things.

Many years ago, in my first professional job as a computer software trainer, I was scheduled to teach a one-day advanced database programming class. I had prepared for the class and felt mostly comfortable with the content, except for one exercise near the end of class. I had a few unanswered questions about it, but was busy and did not take the time to research them before the day of class. I planned to use my lunch break to review that section of my notes and get clarity on the activity.

Class began and went well until lunchtime. When we broke for lunch, I discovered an unexpected mandatory meeting had been called, which meant I would not have any time during the lunch break to review my notes. I was in big trouble! I returned to the classroom for the afternoon, dreading that upcoming exercise. When we got to the activity, every ounce of my attention was on following the trainer guide and my notes. Had any questions arisen, or anything unexpected occurred, I would not have been able to easily handle them.

Fortunately, this situation turned out OK. We made it through the activity, and although I felt stressed out, I don't think my students noticed. It was a huge learning experience for me. I learned to never rely on class time for preparation time, and to spend as much time as needed to prepare ahead of class.

The situation also helped me realize the relationship between a trainer's comfort with the material and their ability to multitask in the classroom. When you know your content, you will be able to focus on the entire scope of class instead of needing to concentrate on your uncertainties.

Know Your Virtual Classroom Software

You should be so familiar with the virtual classroom software that you can click without thinking. You should also be able to click and talk at the same time. You should know where to find every menu command, every button, and every feature of the software.

If you have to stop and think about the program features, you will not be able to effectively multitask. If you're fumbling to open the correct poll, or struggling to remember which button starts the breakout groups, you will need to focus on those things in addition to everything else you're trying to juggle.

When asked to provide his advice on multitasking, Michael Abrams, director of talent and leadership development at Ashley Furniture, said, "The biggest failure of online trainers is just not knowing the tool." In fact, Mike's secret to multitasking when delivering is "to know your tool well enough so that you can do things without thinking about it too hard." For more information about the common features of virtual classroom software, review [chapter 4](#).

Have a Producer or Co-Facilitator

When you work with another person to facilitate a virtual class, the tasks can be divided up between you. If you have a producer, they can administer the technology and prepare the software tools while you focus only on delivering the content. Or, if you have a co-facilitator, you will be able to share responsibilities. Either way will free up some of your time in the classroom and allow you to more easily multitask.

It will be important to very clearly delineate roles and responsibilities so that you do not stumble over one another during delivery. There's a fine line between complementing one another and bumping into each other. Your interactions and transitions should appear seamless to the participants.

For example, if one person is responsible for monitoring the chat window for incoming participant questions, decide ahead of time if the speaker will be interrupted to respond immediately to the question, or if the speaker will take the initiative to periodically pause and ask what questions have come into the chat window. Either way is fine—you just want to work this out in advance. When you work together with a well-thought-out plan, you can focus on what matters most.

In one of my frequently taught virtual classes, I co-facilitate with a subject matter expert (SME). My role is to produce and facilitate activities, and the SME's role is to present the content. The SME stays focused on his expertise: imparting knowledge to the learners and responding to questions. Meanwhile, I am able to concentrate on the mechanics of the software tool and ensure that participants stay actively engaged. We practiced several times before our first delivery and are comfortable working together. We are both more effective multitaskers because of our shared duties.

Be a Proficient Typist

Typing skills are necessary in the virtual classroom, especially when you use the whiteboard, the text annotation tool, and chat. The better your typing skills, the better you will be able to use these tools and, in turn, lead a virtual class.

Also, if you can type without having to think too much, you will be a better multitasker because your mind will not have to focus on where to find each letter on the keyboard. Personally, I have trouble typing and speaking at the same time. Even though I can type quickly, I get tripped up if I'm typing one thing and saying another. So I've learned to either stay silent a moment while I type, or to say what I'm typing aloud.

Lengthy silence leads to disengaged participants, so speed is also important when you need to pause while typing something on the screen. When it makes sense to narrate what you are typing, such as when using the text annotation tool to type participant names for breakout groups on a slide, say their names aloud as you enter each one. This keeps them engaged while you are multitasking.

Remember, you need to be able to type quickly and accurately to type well. They are both important, because if you type quickly but with errors, you may need to spend time fixing your typing mistakes.

Build In Pauses to Regroup

Another way to handle the demands of multitasking while delivering virtually is to build pauses into the class design. This is obviously easier to do if you have a hand in creating the class; however, it can be done any time through proper advance preparation.

Before class, review your notes to find specific opportunities for what I call a “trainer pause.” These pauses are the times when you are still facilitating, but less actively engaged with the participants. Of course, there’s never a time when you should be completely disengaged during class. Instead, these pauses are pockets of time when the participants are engrossed in something and you are able to briefly step back from the class. For example, you might have a pause when:

- the groups are working on an activity
- your co-facilitator is leading
- everyone is watching a video
- participants are assigned individual reflection time.

As you’ll notice, these pauses are not long breaks. Instead, they are just a few moments here and there that give you an opportunity to turn to your next page of notes, take a sip of water, or mentally regroup. The short pauses give you time to recuperate and get centered, which will in turn help you catch up on whatever is needed. When you have trainer pauses during a class, you will be able to multitask more effectively.

For example, I deliver a virtual class that has a breakout group activity near the end of it. I place the participants into specific groups based upon their responses to a previous class discussion. I could create the group assignments on the fly right before the activity begins, but I prefer to think in advance about who will be in each group. At one point during class, prior to the breakout groups, we have a short time of silence (approximately three minutes) for an individual reflection activity. During this time, I quickly jot down the breakout group assignments. Of course, I am not completely disengaged from the class. I’m still keeping an eye on the time and on the chat window for incoming comments, and thinking about what I’m going to

say next. However, while the participants are focused on something else, I am able to catch my breath and take care of this task. When I create the breakout assignments during this trainer pause, I have one less thing to do when setting up the activity. During a trainer pause, make sure that you stay close to the class, periodically speaking or typing in the chat window. If there is complete silence and stillness for too long, the participants may worry whether they (or you) have been disconnected.

Wendy Gates Corbett lets participants know if she is going to mute her phone during an activity, but that she is still available if they have questions. Then, every 30-60 seconds, she lets them know either verbally or in chat that she's still there and able to respond to questions. This gives her a moment to pause, while still staying connected to the class.

Even though planning for trainer pauses will help you multitask, it's important to remember that you won't be able to always rely on these times for a pause. If participants have a question, or a technical issue arises, your trainer pause might be filled with activity instead. Or, if you use a webcam, then you'll need to maintain eye contact with the audience so that they know you are actively listening. While you may or may not be able to rely on having a trainer pause, it's good to plan and take advantage of the opportunity when possible.

Practice Multitasking

You've heard the phrase "practice makes perfect." Practicing does lead to improved performance; the more you multitask, the better at it you will be. One aspect of practicing is facilitating in the virtual classroom. As we'll discuss in [chapter 9](#), you should practice virtual delivery as much as you can.

You can also practice multitasking in other situations, such as your everyday work on the computer. If you are accustomed to having just one file or software application open, try opening several at a time and switching back and forth between them while you work, practicing instant messaging with multiple colleagues at the same time, or using your software in "split screen" mode (a command that allows you to see different parts of the same file on the screen at the same time). If you have dual monitors, use them in "extended" mode so that you can practice switching between programs.

When you practice multitasking on the computer in your day-to-day work, it may feel awkward at first, but it will help you get accustomed to having more than one screen open at the same time, which is typical in the virtual classroom.

Remember How You Do It in the Face-to-Face Classroom

If you're still concerned about getting used to multitasking, remember that trainers multitask in the regular face-to-face classroom as well.

Classroom trainers are like ducks on a pond—ducks look smooth as they glide along the water, but underneath the surface they are paddling like crazy just to move forward. Effective trainers make it look easy as they guide participants from one activity to another. Yet underneath they are working hard to keep the class moving.



Noted

“What I have learned over time is that the more I just relax and keep the attendee list front of mind, the better. I trust that my rehearsal time has prepared me for almost anything. Remember, it gets easier with practice.”

—Shane Strang, Supply College Deployment Manager, Mars Inc.

Trainers look at their notes, facilitate discussion, keep an eye on the time, think about what's coming next, pay attention to participants' expressions and body language, show visual aids, and so on. Experienced trainers do these things seamlessly; it's just part of what they do to lead a class.

Similarly, effective virtual trainers make it look easy as they guide participants, even though they are multitasking behind the scenes to move the class forward. Be encouraged by your classroom experience with multitasking, because you can bring those skills to the online environment.

Resist the Temptation to Do Too Much

Returning to our driving analogy, it's also possible while driving to add in extemporaneous activities, such as talking on a cell phone, reading a map, or fiddling with the radio dials. Of course, these activities are not recommended, yet many drivers do them anyway.

When delivering a virtual class, it might be tempting to add in extracurricular activities, such as keeping an eye on your email or running your favorite Internet application in the background, but just like in driving, these activities pull your focus away from where it should be and could be an accident waiting to happen. It takes discipline and self-control to keep your eyes on the road in both environments.

Before your training class begins, exit out of your email program and any other instant messaging or Internet software that may be running. Close anything on your computer—and remove everything from your workspace—that you will not be using in class. Give your class your undivided attention. There will be enough going on in the training class without adding more tasks or distractions to your virtual plate.

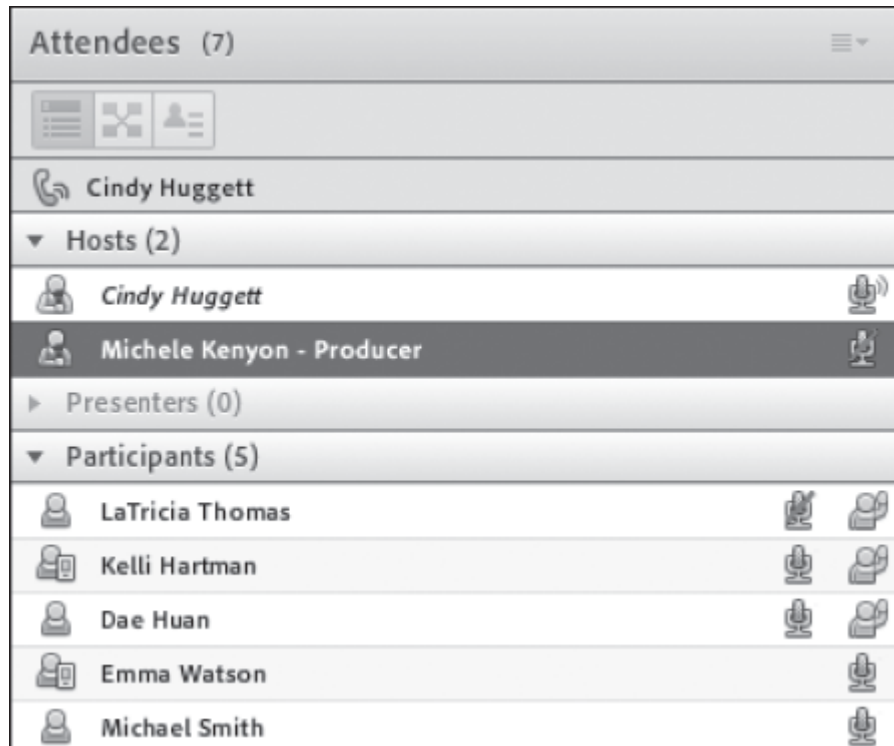
Know What's OK to Let Slide

Jim Wilcox, former regional training manager at AchieveGlobal, says his advice for new virtual trainers comes from his juggling skills. In the 1994 book *Juggling for the Complete Klutz*, by John Cassidy, the very first page directs the reader to take their juggling items, throw them up in the air, and let them drop without trying to catch them. The goal is to help the juggler get used to this feeling because that's what happens when you juggle—you drop things.

The same is true in the virtual classroom. Things drop through the cracks. The key is knowing what is OK to let slide, and what is not. For example, if you tell participants to raise their hands when they have a question or comment, then you don't want to miss seeing someone's raised hand (see [Figure 6-1](#)). If you do miss it, you could recover by saying, "I'm sorry, Kelli. I just noticed your hand was raised. What question do you have?"

On the other hand, if you ask all participants to respond to a question by typing in the chat window, and the responses come pouring in, you do not have to comment on each one. You can selectively pick and choose individual comments to point out during the debrief discussion. Then, at a later point in class, you can scroll through the chat window to see what you missed.

Figure 6-1. Hands Raised in Adobe Connect



Getting It Done

You may notice a common thread among most of these tips for multitasking: Almost all of them involve advance preparation and knowledge. The more prepared you are, the easier it will be for you to deal with whatever comes your way in the classroom. Worksheet 6-1 will help you assess how prepared you are to multitask while delivering virtual training.



Noted

“The first secret to multitasking while delivering is to know your tool well enough that you can do things without thinking about it too hard. The second secret is to use good facilitation techniques. If you need to focus on something else for a moment, do it when they are working on an activity. Ask a question and have someone answer it while you do whatever else you need to do. Don’t let them know you are multitasking unless you absolutely have to. If you have to tell them, don’t worry about it. They know you have many things to juggle.”

—Michael Abrams, Director, Talent and Leadership Development, Ashley Furniture

Worksheet 6-1. Multitasking Checklist

Use this worksheet to rate yourself on the 10 steps for multitasking success.

	Never	Rarely	Sometimes	Usually	Always
I set myself up for success before the virtual training event.	1	2	3	4	5
I am completely prepared to deliver my training content.	1	2	3	4	5
I fully know the virtual classroom software that I will be using.	1	2	3	4	5
I have a producer or co-facilitator who will assist me during the event.	1	2	3	4	5
I can type quickly and accurately.	1	2	3	4	5
I have identified trainer pauses.	1	2	3	4	5
I practiced multitasking.	1	2	3	4	5
I am comfortable with my virtual training delivery skills.	1	2	3	4	5
I have eliminated all distractions from my workspace to focus on the virtual training event.	1	2	3	4	5
I am comfortable with letting unimportant things slide without comment in the virtual classroom.	1	2	3	4	5

What skills are already your areas of strength?

What skills will you focus on first to help you be a better multitasker when delivering in the virtual classroom?

7

Harness Your Voice



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- how to overcome voice challenges
- how to harness your voice to work for you in the virtual training classroom
- the importance of choosing the right words.

Harness Your Voice

A trainer's voice can make or break the virtual training experience for a participant. Just as a musician's talent shines during a performance, a trainer's voice demonstrates their presentation skills. It reveals the trainer's personality and interest in the topic, and it can betray their nervousness.

A well-known Pittsburgh sports broadcaster named Myron Cope earned fame through his unique voice. He delivered one of his catchphrases, "This is Myron Cope on Sports," with emphasis on each syllable, and his distinct sound made him one of the most recognizable voices on sports radio. Some listeners loved it; others did not. Some people tuned in just to hear his funny catchphrases and unique cadence. Others avoided his broadcasts altogether.



Noted

"Pay strong attention to your voice."

—Jim Wilcox,
Former Regional Training Manager, AchieveGlobal

Many people equate virtual training delivery to broadcast radio. While there are parallels between the two, one thing is certain—trainers do not want to have a controversial voice in the training room. While everyone's voice is unique, you want to ensure that it doesn't get in the way of training. Participants shouldn't be distracted by your voice.

Your voice should be crisp, easy to understand, and neutral sounding, without annoying habits. It should allow the focus to stay on the learning.

Overcoming Voice Challenges

You might think you weren't born with a great speaking voice or you are vocally challenged. As for my voice, I have a slight lisp. I've had it my

whole life, and am slightly embarrassed by it. As a professional speaker and trainer, I recognize how important my voice is to my “product.” Yet I never apologize for my lisp. It’s part of my personality, my style, and who I am. No one has ever mentioned it after a class, and, in fact, I’m often complimented on my voice after a virtual delivery.

If your voice is truly a challenge, vocal training is available. You could hire a voice coach or take voice lessons. I took speech classes as a child, which gave me greater control over my lisp. At times, I still follow the vocal exercises my teacher taught me to warm up before a training event.

The bottom line is that your voice doesn’t have to be perfect. It just needs to not be distracting to participants.



Think About This

Trainers frequently ask if they should use a cell phone or regular telephone for virtual classes and whether to use a headset or mouthpiece. The answer depends upon the quality of connection you have with either one. I recommend using the device that gives you the clearest sound, as well as a high-quality wired headset so that your hands are free and there is no danger of wireless interference on the line. Also, do not try to use a speakerphone because you may sound “hollow” or have a distracting echo. Speakerphones also magnify *all* sounds, not just your voice.

In addition, some conference call providers allow you to adjust your volume as part of the participant controls. On the conference-calling system I use most frequently, I can press *5 on my telephone keypad to increase my volume or *8 to decrease it.

Watch Your Volume

When delivering in the virtual classroom, use your normal speaking voice. It’s not necessary to shout. If you do, you will strain your vocal cords. You will also create sound distortion over the phone.

In most cases, you will be speaking into a telephone handset or using a hands-free headset. Adjust your volume using the controls found on both the telephone and the headset (if you use one). If you are using a corded headset, make sure it’s connected properly, with all cords completely plugged in. If you use a wireless headset, make sure the wireless feature does not cause any interference or create static on the line. Place the headset microphone at a comfortable distance from your mouth. It should be just above your top lip, and a few inches away.



Think About This

Speaking of volume, it is OK to ask participants to speak louder if you cannot hear them. Phrase it in a neutral-sounding way so that they don't get embarrassed (such as, "Jane, I'm having trouble hearing you. Could you please speak up?" or "Jason, I think I heard you say [xyz]; is that correct? Can the volume on your phone be adjusted?").

Adjust Your Speaking Rate

Another common question is, "How quickly should you speak during virtual delivery?" You should speak fast enough so the participants don't get bored, yet slow enough that they can understand.

Our typical speaking rate varies based on many factors. Some people naturally speak fast; others speak at a slower rate. We may speak faster when we are nervous, and slower when we are tired or not excited about the material.

According to the Lynn K. Wells book *The Articulate Voice* (1999), the average suggested speaking rate is 140-175 words per minute in normal conversation. You can figure out your normal rate of speech by taping yourself, listening to the recording, and counting the number of words spoken in a minute.

I'm a fast talker, and have timed myself speaking about 175 words per minute, which is on the fast edge of normal. Therefore, in both the regular training room and the virtual classroom, I make a point to slow down and pause between phrases. If I think I'm talking too slow, then I'm probably speaking at just the right rate.

Wendy Gates Corbett, on the other hand, reminds herself to speed up when delivering in the online classroom. She says that in the face-to-face classroom she speaks slower, but her hand gestures help her participants stay engaged. However, in the virtual classroom, she knows she needs to speak faster, and thinks if she's talking too fast then she's probably speaking at just the right rate.

In addition to these guidelines, ask your participants to give you feedback on your rate of speech. You can do this live during class. Some virtual classroom software programs give participants the ability to provide real-time feedback by selecting buttons such as "speed up" or "slow down" (see

Figure 7-1). If your software has this capability, you should encourage its use. Otherwise, ask participants for direct feedback on your speaking rate.

Additional factors that affect your desired rate of speech are the audience and your content. Keep in mind that if you have an international audience or participants who do not speak your language, you will want to talk even slower for comprehension, around 120-130 words per minute.

If you're reading from a facilitator script, you will probably speak slower than normal because your mind has to process the words on the page and then say them. Therefore, I recommend that if you have a scripted guide, you only loosely follow it. You can do this by highlighting key words, which will help you say the script, but in your own speaking style and conversational tone. You can also do this by thinking about what you're saying while you're saying it.

Figure 7-1. Sample Feedback Options for Participants in Adobe Connect



Keep Participants Tuned In

It's also important to be mindful of the pitch and tone of your voice when you deliver. One of the worst things a trainer can do in the virtual classroom is speak in a monotone voice. Participants will have trouble listening to you and will not stay engaged. They will tune out. And once they tune out, it's difficult, if not impossible, to get them tuned in again!

Instead, use inflections to add interest to your voice. You can add emphasis to certain words, expressing excitement and emotion. You should sound energetic and animated about the content. How will your participants get excited about something if you don't sound enthusiastic about it? However, be careful not to lift your voice at the end of every sentence, as some presenters do, or it will sound like everything you say is a question.

Wendy Gates Corbett recommends recording one of your virtual training sessions so you can hear your voice. She did this several years ago, and said, "It was painful to hear myself—I sounded monotone and boring!" She now makes a point to change her tone, and use a wider range of pitch.

Keep your audience engaged with the sound of your voice. Avoid monotone speaking at all costs.

Minimize Your Airtime

The dictionary definition of *dialogue* is a conversation between two or more people. And if your virtual training class goal is to have a learner-centered experience, then the participants should be talking more than the trainer. This means that if you count all the spoken words during a class, the balance should tip toward the participants. This fact is true in both the face-to-face and virtual classrooms. The learners should be actively talking and participating in the class.

Even though you are the trainer, host, and facilitator, remember that the goal is to engage your participants. Give them opportunities to speak as much as possible. Let them talk much more than you do. As we'll learn in [chapter 8](#), asking questions, encouraging discussion, having volunteers read aloud, and so on are all ways to keep your own airtime to a minimum.

Control Breathing

Speaking of airtime, how much air do you have in your voice? If you expel too much air when speaking, you will sound breathy. You need to inhale

more often to keep up with your oxygen needs. Gasping for air is not attractive to your listeners. It will detract from the learning experience.



Basic Rule 12

Your voice is a key component of your virtual training delivery. Pay attention to your volume, rate, tone, and overall sound.

One technique for discovering how much breath you have in your voice is to place your finger across your lips while speaking in a normal conversational tone. Then do it while whispering. Notice the difference between the two experiences. You should feel some air on your finger while talking, but not nearly as much as when you whisper.

If you find yourself gasping for air while speaking, familiarize yourself with deep breathing techniques, which will help improve your lung capacity. Deep breathing will also help you stay calm and collected in a tense situation.

When I need to take a deep breath, I inhale as much as I can through my nose, hold it a moment, and then exhale through my mouth. Another deep breathing technique I use is to put my hand on my abdomen while breathing, which helps me breathe deep into my belly instead of taking shallow, chest-only breaths.

Take a few deep breaths before you begin class, and then again as needed during class.

Posture Affects Your Voice

Sit? Stand? Kneel? How do you position your body when delivering in the virtual classroom? Believe it or not, your posture affects the way your voice sounds.

In my first job as a corporate trainer, I was taught to always stand and never sit during class. I've since relaxed this rule, because sometimes a seated facilitator encourages more discussion, especially in smaller classes.

Similarly, when I first started virtual training, I always stayed seated and fixed to my chair during class. It just seemed like the natural thing to do. However, I've since adjusted this rule because sometimes a standing trainer has more energy in their voice. If I use the hands-free headset, place my

laptop on a stand, and arrange my notes in an easy-to-see location, I can facilitate a virtual class on my feet.

There are obviously times I do stay seated throughout the entire virtual class. But now I'm much more open to varying my posture than before. You might do the same—experiment with various options to find the best one for you.

When sitting, sit on the edge of your seat, and sit straight up with your head over your shoulders and your shoulders over your hips. Not only does sitting with proper posture make it easier to breathe properly, it will also help you sound more energetic and engaging. If you slouch in your chair, or lean back with your feet up on the desk, you might sound too relaxed and nonchalant. It may result in only a slight difference in your tone, yet your demeanor will translate across the phone line.

A final thought about posture: Smile while you speak. Your smile can be “heard” by your participants, and it adds energy to your voice.

Control the Nervous Voice

When I get nervous, you can hear it in my voice. That may be true for you as well. Your voice can betray you when you are nervous. Nerves can be heard when your voice shakes, when you speak too quickly, or when your voice squeaks in a higher pitch.

You can keep shakiness from your voice by using deep breathing techniques and ensuring you are prepared. And, as discussed previously, you can control your rate of speech. However, it's harder to control your voice range when it rises because of nerves. Jim Wilcox suggests maintaining your “morning voice” when you know that nerves may get the best of you that day.

Your morning voice is how you speak when you first wake up in the morning. For most of us, it's in a lower tone than our usual voice. You can work to keep your morning voice by keeping your vocal cords in that range right from the start of the day. For example, hum in that same low voice while you are in the shower. On your drive to work, listen to the radio and repeat the newscaster's words aloud or sing along to the music. All the while, remain in that lower register of your morning voice. Continue to hum softly until class time. Then, when class starts, if you get nervous and your voice rises, it will simply rise to your normal register instead of going too high. Your nerves will be masked!

Warming Up Your Voice

In general, warming up your voice is another important preparation technique for trainers. If you've ever tried to speak on a moment's notice and been caught with a "frog" in your throat, then you understand the importance of doing this. When your voice is already warmed up, it will not crack when you begin speaking.



Noted

"Make sure that a morning training class is not your first conversation of the day. Try warming up your voice by talking to someone ahead of time, either in person or on the telephone."

—Sharon Wingron, CPLP, Founder and President, Wings of Success LLC

Several of my training colleagues recommend using techniques from singers and professional broadcasters who warm up their voice by repeating phrases or singing scales ("do-re-mi"). Jim Wilcox's recommendation on how to keep your vocal cords warm is to hum in a low register, just below audible level, for a few minutes before speaking. He says it's just the act of getting air past your vocal cords that keeps them warm.



Noted

"Repeat the phrase *red leather, yellow leather* while doing scales. Start from low notes to high notes singing this over and over. Once you are at the top of your good-sounding scale, come back down. Then try to do it a bit quicker. This is a great way to warm up your face, lips, mouth, and throat."

—Michael Abrams, Director, Talent and Leadership Development, Ashley Furniture

Stay Hydrated

To help your throat stay hydrated when delivering virtual training, have room temperature water available to you throughout the session. I recommend room temperature because water that's too hot or too cold can affect your vocal cords.

In addition, water is a better choice than other beverages for several reasons. Carbonated sodas will cause unpleasant effects from their effervescence. Caffeine is a diuretic, which will make you need to visit the

bathroom. Milk and other dairy-based beverages will coat your vocal cords, which could make you sound congested.

If you have a glass of water, put a lid on it so it doesn't accidentally spill. If you use bottled water, crack open the top before the session so that you don't need to fumble with it during class. Also, don't use a straw, because that increases the air intake to your digestive system and could result in an unwanted belch during class.

Recently, I was facilitating a virtual class and accidentally knocked over my full water cup. As water spilled across the desk, I quickly picked up my laptop and set it on a nearby table. I scooped up my wet notes and put them on my chair. I reached for napkins to start sopping up the water, and kept on going. At my next opportunity, I ran to get a towel (wearing my telephone headset) to clean up the rest of the spilled water. My participants never knew what happened. But I learned my lesson: Always keep a covered lid on my water glass.

Choose the Right Words

While we're on the topic of voice, let's also talk about what you say—specifically, the words you choose. First, deliberately choose words that evoke emotion and add interest to the topic. For example, you could say, “Wow, this is cool” or “An exciting new way to do this is....” Of course, use phrases that are genuine to your personality and speaking style. Wendy Gates Corbett provides software training in the virtual classroom, and she uses phrases like, “I'm excited about this feature” or “My favorite topic is....” These add interest and convey her enthusiasm about the program.

Second, be careful about using phrases that not everyone will understand, such as idioms, colloquialisms, and slang. For example, if you're used to saying, “This is a piece of cake,” you can instead say, “This is easy.” Instead of saying, “The ball is in your court,” you could say, “That's your decision.” Be mindful of the phrases you use in your everyday language that might not translate well in the virtual classroom. Another virtual trainer I know once used the phrase, “Don't throw the baby out with the bathwater.” One of her international participants had to stop her and ask, “What do you mean?” The class ended up laughing about the experience; however, it's good to be careful of your word choices!

Third, avoid gobbledygook. Gobbledygook occurs when you use extra words to communicate or when you use larger words than needed. Just like

we're taught to avoid wordy phrases in written communications, we can avoid gobbledygook in our speech. For example, say "use" instead of "utilize" or "try" instead of "attempt." Keep your word choices simple.

Carefully choose your words so that you are clear, concise, and perfectly understood by your listeners.

Avoid Filler Words

Sometimes we say words without consciously realizing it. Words like *um*, *OK*, and *y'know* creep into our speech, and everyone but us hears them. Wendy Gates Corbett calls these words "verbal viruses" because they are easy to catch and hard to eliminate.

We all have filler words that we naturally gravitate toward using. Mine is the classic "um" between sentences. I also say "absolutely" more often than anyone should.

What's yours? If you don't know, ask someone who knows you well. They will probably be able to tell you immediately. You could also call yourself and leave a voicemail, reminding yourself to complete an upcoming task. Then during playback, you'll hear your filler word of choice.

The harder question is how to eliminate your filler word. The first step is to recognize you have one and identify it. The second step is to start listening for it when you talk. And the third step is to consciously stop saying it. You might pinch yourself every time you use it or keep a hash-mark tally count when you hear it. One preventive measure I've used is to write the filler word on a sticky note, and then place the note in an obvious spot.

You may have more than one filler word that you use. If so, repeat these steps for each one. Also, once you've stopped saying a filler word, the trick is to not replace it with another one. Instead, eliminate it altogether. Be OK with a silent pause; you don't have to fill that space.

Reduce Self-Talk

The other words you should eliminate are what I call your "trainer self-talk." Trainer self-talk happens when you think out loud—talking to yourself about what you're doing or mistakes you've made.

In the face-to-face classroom, trainer self-talk can be eliminated by simply not saying anything to draw attention to small mishaps. For example, if you thumb through a flipchart pad looking for the correct page, and while doing so say, “It’s taking me a while to find the right page,” that’s an example of trainer self-talk. Your participants probably would not have noticed that it took you a few extra moments to land on the right one, but because you told them, they are now thinking about the extra time. The alternative is to simply thumb through the chart without drawing attention to the few extra moments it takes you to find the correct spot.



Noted

“I plan how to use my voice. When I practice, I actually make notes like ‘slow down here’ or ‘emphasize this—speak louder.’ I have to use my voice as a major delivery tool.”

—Kathy Shurte, CPLP, CPM, D4 Organizational Development Manager, Florida Department of Transportation

It’s a similar situation in the virtual classroom. Let’s say you accidentally highlight the wrong word with the annotation tool. You could mention your mistake; you might say, “Oops, I didn’t mean to click on that” or, “My connection is slow today.” Or you could just use the annotation eraser tool to remove the highlight. If you do the latter, most participants won’t notice the minor error you just made.

There’s no need to call attention to your mistakes. Most of the time, especially if you quickly recover, your participants will not notice the error.

It’s a delicate balance between telling participants what you’re doing for them on their behalf versus pointing out mistakes, delays, or technical glitches. For instance, it would be appropriate to say out loud, “In a moment we will take a poll, which I am opening now to display on your screen,” or, if you need a moment of silence to create online breakout groups, you could say, “It will take me just a moment to assign you to your groups.” These statements are helpful and add value to the participant experience.

In the virtual classroom, there can be a very fine line between what you should and should not share aloud. Keep the hidden things hidden.

Getting It Done

Your voice communicates who you are as a virtual trainer. Make your voice work for you. Learn to control it. Exude energy and excitement through it. Convey your personality through what you say and how you say it. Use your voice to effectively deliver virtual training.

Worksheet 7-1 lists techniques to warm up your voice before delivering a virtual training event.

Worksheet 7-1. Vocal Warm-Up Exercises

Select one or more of these techniques to warm up your voice prior to delivering a virtual training event.

Quietly hum your favorite song.

Slowly say the alphabet vowels (a-e-i-o-u). Exaggerate your facial expressions while doing so. Repeat them in various vocal tones (low, medium, high) and in various volumes (soft, medium, loud).

Sing the musical scale (do, re, mi, fa, sol, la, ti, do) forward and backward several times in a row.

Open your mouth as wide as you can and say “ahhh” (as if you were in the dentist chair). Close your mouth, and then repeat.

Warm up your facial muscles by pursing your lips together (like a kiss) and then smile wide. Go back and forth between these mouth positions.

Warm up your neck muscles by gently looking side to side, and then up and down.

8

Engage Participants



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- how to effectively engage participants
- how to keep training relevant and bring it to life
- the importance of capturing participants' attention from the start
- to focus on the learners.

Engage Participants

In a 2004 *T+D* article, synchronous learning expert and author Jennifer Hofmann wrote, “Teaching online is like teaching after lunch.” In case you’re not familiar with the post-lunch phenomenon, classroom trainers jokingly refer to it as the “teflon hour” because “nothing sticks.” It’s a challenge at this time of day to keep participants’ attention and engage them in the class.

In the virtual classroom, the problem of engaging participants is even more pronounced. Many would say this is the fundamental challenge of virtual training—how to effectively engage participants and keep their attention throughout the class.

There are several reasons for this challenge. First, participants usually do not leave their personal workspace to attend synchronous online training. Instead they stay in their own environment, which means they see their “to-do” lists, their files, and their pile of unfinished work. In addition, they may have pop-up calendar reminders that interrupt the session, or that little yellow “unread email” icon in the corner of their screen. These things are hard to ignore as they silently beckon to the participant throughout the virtual class.

Second, some learners might be new to the virtual classroom and may not realize that you expect them to participate. Their previous experience may have been with webcasts or other noninteractive online sessions. These false expectations create more obstacles for a virtual trainer to overcome.

Third, this 60-minute virtual session could be the only block of time that day when participants’ telephones don’t ring or they are not interrupted. Therefore, they may see it as downtime and want to take advantage of the opportunity to catch up on other things. In these days of perpetual connectivity, even if participants shut down their email programs, they can still use their smartphone to read and respond to messages during the class. In fact, in some business cultures, they might even be expected to do so.

Fourth, participants may also think they *can* successfully multitask during your training class. Even if they stay engaged for most of the session, they assume it won't matter if they take a few moments to quickly respond to an incoming email message or to rearrange the items on their desk.

I actually find the multitasking challenge to be an interesting paradox. As a virtual trainer, you need to multitask and pay attention to many things at once. Multitasking is both expected and needed for the trainer to be successful. Yet we ask participants *not* to multitask, but to keep their sole attention on the virtual classroom.

Let's face it—it *is* difficult for participants to have a singular focus. It *is* difficult for many participants to break their habit of multitasking, especially when they stay in their own work environment to attend the training. And it *is* difficult for participants to ignore the temptation to do other things during the training session.

Therefore, to help participants stay focused on the virtual classroom, trainers need to keep them engaged throughout the entire event. The good news is that this can be done, and it can be done successfully. An effective virtual trainer with a well-designed course can maintain the attention of participants. Effective trainers encourage participants to multitask, but within the boundaries of the intended learning activities. They also keep the training pace brisk, give frequent opportunities to interact, and offer multiple options to engage.

Effectively Engaging Participants

Let's look at eight ways to effectively engage participants:



Noted

“Remember, it is still about involving your participants and staying focused on their learning. It is not about just getting through content.”

—Sharon Wingron, CPLP,
Founder and President, Wings of Success LLC

1. Make it matter.
2. Keep it relevant.

3. Capture their attention from the start.
4. Say participants' names frequently.
5. Create interactivity using technology.
6. Encourage networking.
7. Bring the training class to life.
8. Focus on the learners.

Make It Matter

To effectively engage participants in the virtual classroom, you need to “make it matter.” This means you appeal to participants’ internal motivations by showing them the WIIFM (“What’s in it for me?”). This also means you help the learners see the benefits of participating in the class. If the learning outcomes of your virtual training course are important to the participants, then they will be much more likely to engage in it. You, the trainer, can help them see how the training class matters to them.

To do this, begin with finding out the big picture of the training initiative. You may already know it if you were involved with the design of the program. If not, seek out someone familiar with the event and ask appropriate questions, such as:

- What is the overall purpose of this training class?
- What do the learners need to know as a result of attending?
- To what business or performance results will they be held accountable?
- What are the potential consequences if the participants don’t learn?

You should ask these questions ahead of time so you know what will motivate the participants. Knowing the overall purpose will help you put this specific topic into context. Knowing what the learners need to know as a result of attending will help you focus on that outcome. And knowing what business or performance results are needed will help you assist participants in achieving those expectations.

When you know the answers to these questions, it will help you clearly articulate the training class’s benefits to the learners. You’ll be able to show them the WIIFM from their perspective. You can emphasize this information throughout the session at appropriate times. When participants

realize the training class will benefit them, their internal motivation to learn increases, and they will stay more engaged in the class.

It's possible that you could discover there are no answers to these questions. In other words, it may be an unfortunate situation where the training class is not tied to business results or does not have performance-based learning objectives. It may simply be a "nice-to-know" topic or awareness-building session. Or, you may have been brought in just to facilitate the class, without any available insight into the before-or-after implementation. In this case, do everything you can to help participants see how this content matters to them. Ask them to share what *they* want to learn, and how this will benefit them.

Another way to "make it matter" is to encourage management involvement before and after the class. If the participants' direct supervisors talk with them beforehand about the importance of the training class, then they will be more likely to actively engage in the class. Do what you can to influence these conversations ahead of time. If you're able, send a note to the managers and let them know that their involvement is important. Call the managers and ask them to get involved. Offer to hold a virtual session just for them, to expose them to the training material (if they're not already involved with the training initiative). Or, at the very least, include them on pre-event communications.

When you "make it matter," the participants will be more inclined to stay tuned into the class. For example, in a sales training program I deliver, we begin class by asking participants to list specific challenges they experience during sales calls. Then throughout the class, I refer to the personal challenges listed and tie our lessons to them. These connections help participants see the benefits of each learning objective.

Here are three other ways to show WIIFM:

1. Emphasize benefits by reviewing each item on the class agenda with a comment related to how it will help them.
2. Ask the participants to share how they expect the training topic to benefit them.
3. Collect class alumni testimonials and share those comments with the class.

Keep It Relevant

Virtual trainers should keep the class focused on content that is interesting, relevant, and immediately applicable. The best-case scenario is that the training class design makes this easy. In the worst-case scenario, the trainer has to work harder to make this happen. When trainers keep the class relevant to the participants' real-world environment, the learners will be much more likely to stay engaged.

"How can trainers do this?" you might ask. "If the trainer follows the facilitator script, won't it automatically lead to the learning outcomes regardless of its relevancy to the participants?" Well, not exactly. Trainers add their own style when facilitating a class. They add stories and examples to enhance the content. They ask impromptu questions to generate discussion and to follow up on participant comments. These enhancements are a normal part of most training classes.

It's like ballroom dancing. A dance, such as the waltz or tango, is immediately recognizable because it follows a set of rules. However, each couple on the dance floor looks different, because of how they interpret the dance. You would know two people are dancing the waltz, but because of their personal style, they may look altogether different from the couple next to them.

It's the same with training. Two trainers could deliver a class using the exact same facilitator script; while you would recognize the class, each trainer's individual style would be obvious. When trainers inject their own style into the class, the discussions will be unique to that session. The stories told, the examples shared, and the emphasis on certain components will be distinctive to the trainer leading the class.

Therefore, when you deliver virtual training, keep your stories and examples relevant to the class. You could share how the current lesson relates to your six-year-old's funny comment last week, or you could share how it relates to a common business challenge. Both stories may illustrate the learning point; however, you should share the one that your participants will relate to most. In fact, you could compile several stories or examples to use in each class and then select the one most appropriate for your audience that day. These stories will add your unique style into the training class, while still maintaining the participants' interest.

For example, I recently co-facilitated a finance-related virtual training class. During the class, my co-facilitator shared examples of where to find companies' publicly available financial information. He knew that every

example was relevant to the participants because he listened to their introductions and comments about the companies they worked with. When it came time to share the examples, he could have used a set of preplanned generic company names. Instead, he deliberately used the companies that participants had named during the session. In some cases, he even referred to their websites. In fact, every time we run this class, he tailors the examples to the participants in attendance. It helps because when they hear the company names they work with every day, they pay closer attention.

In another virtual class I frequently facilitate, we discuss the challenges of coaching. To give participants an example of the type of challenges we'll be discussing, I share a short story about a coaching dilemma I encountered as a new supervisor. It's a story that is relevant to both the topic and the audience, and it helps illustrate the discussion point.



Think About This

You don't have to be the only storyteller. Everyone has a story. Encourage your participants to share their own examples. If a participant goes off-topic or shares what seems to be an irrelevant example, gently ask them to link it back to the training topic. For example, in a listening effectiveness course, you could say, "Oliver, thanks for sharing. That's an interesting example. What aspect of it could best help everyone remember how to listen effectively?"

Virtual trainers should do everything they can to keep their stories, examples, and discussions relevant to the participants. The more relevant the material, the easier it is for participants to stay engaged.



Noted

"My favorite tip is to tell stories. People relate to stories; they will engage and remember your presentation. It's very cool to be sharing a story and see things like, 'Wow! I didn't know that!' appear in the chat box."

—Kathy Shurte, CPLP, CPM, D4 Organizational Development Manager, Florida Department of Transportation

Capture Their Attention From the Start

Begin engaging your participants even before the official start of class. Participants are usually encouraged to log in to the virtual classroom early,

and many of them do. Unfortunately, in many virtual sessions, this time is just awkward silence while everyone gets connected. Sometimes a participant needs technical assistance, and this time is used to help them. Frequently, the producer or trainer simply greets the participants and lets them know, “We’ll begin at the top of the hour.”

To capture participants’ attention from the start, get them engaged from the moment they log in. Use this otherwise “dead” time to get the participants involved and excited about the class. When you capture participants’ attention right away, you will be like a conductor leading orchestra warm-ups, or like a coach leading athletes in calisthenics prior to a game.

To understand why it’s important to get participants involved from the start, imagine a virtual class from their perspective. Let’s say the class begins at 10 a.m. Joe Participant logs in to the virtual classroom at 9:50, and sees a screen that says, “Class will begin at 10 a.m.” So, Joe thinks, “I have 10 minutes ... great! I can get a few more things crossed off my to-do list!” And then he starts reading and responding to email. He is still logged in to the virtual classroom, but at 10 a.m., when class starts, he may be in the middle of responding to one last email and therefore not ready to begin.

If you have something for the participants to do once they log in to the virtual classroom, you will be more likely to keep their attention once the class starts. This initial activity also helps transition participants from work to the class. In some ways, it allows participants to ease into the class gradually instead of having a “hard” start time.

This pre-class activity should get them involved, yet it should not be a complete lesson of critical importance to the learning outcomes. The goal is not to begin class too soon; you don’t want to penalize the participants who do arrive on time but not early. Instead, this technique is more of a bonus for those who do arrive early.

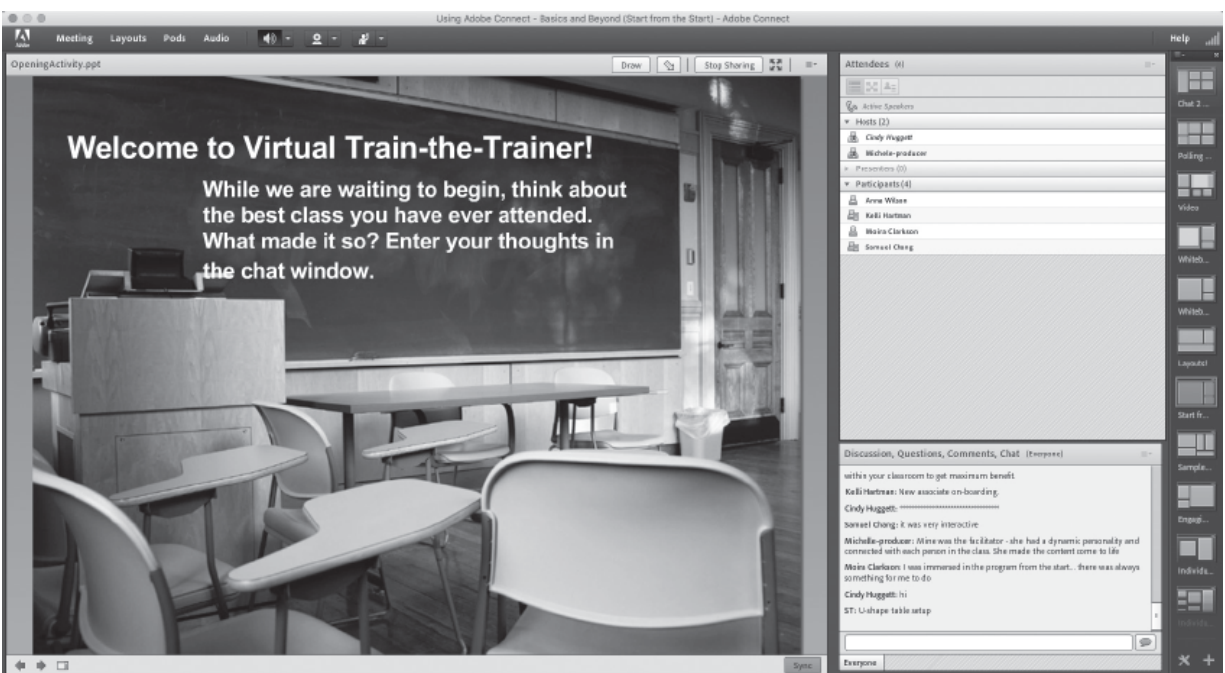
There are a number of things you can do during this time. For example, use the introductory screen to:

- Share a relevant quote and ask participants to comment on it in the chat window.
- Post part of an interesting statistic about the topic and ask participants to guess the correct number.
- Have a poll question open and ask participants to respond to it.

- Invite participants to share their expectations for the class, either verbally or in the chat window.
- Ask participants to comment on any pre-class assignments.

When you engage participants from the time they log in to the virtual classroom, they will be more likely to stay involved during class. It helps them know that this class will be interactive, and that they are expected to participate.

Figure 8-1. Sample Pre-Class Activity in Adobe Connect



In addition to this pre-class activity, reinforce the message of interactivity by giving participants something to do within the first five minutes of class. The last thing you want is 10-15 minutes of “introduction” time at the beginning of class. While this may be fine in a face-to-face class, it will not work in a virtual session. You need to engage the participants from the start, and keep the activity level high throughout.



Basic Rule 13

The general guideline for a synchronous virtual training class is to engage participants at least every four minutes.

Here are a few ways you can engage participants within the first few minutes of class:

- Have participants introduce themselves by annotating a map graphic to indicate their location.
- Invite participants to say hello to the group by typing their usual greeting in the chat window.
- Open a whiteboard and have participants type in a question about the class topic.



Think About This

If you have an international audience that crosses multiple time zones, you could have participants type in the time of day and weather in the chat window. We can all relate to time and weather, and these questions will help personalize the people behind the names.

Finally, in [chapter 2](#), we talked about establishing ground rules. One of the items that should be emphasized—both verbally and visually—is the expectation that this will be an interactive class. Tell them right at the beginning that everyone will be expected to participate. Let them know that:

- You will call on them by name during class.
- There will be activities for them to complete.
- Their fellow learners are counting on them to take an active role in the class.
- There will be assignments and opportunities to interact.

Then, follow through by capturing and keeping their attention throughout class.

Say Participants' Names Frequently

People like to hear their own names. When people hear their name spoken, their ears perk up and they listen. Therefore, you should say your participants' names often throughout the training class.

There are several ways to incorporate your participants' names into the class. First, when you ask questions or expect involvement, call on people by name to respond. For example, you could ask, “Sophie, what do you think about this process?” or “Emily, please tell us your experience in using

this tool.” Remember, these direct questions should not have a right or wrong answer, so you maintain a comfortable learning environment. The point is to encourage participation, not to embarrass or put someone on the spot.

Mike Abrams has an additional tip related to calling on people by name. He recommends warning participants that you will be calling on them by name, so they will be prepared. Your warning might be telling a participant exactly what you will be asking: “Bob, I’m going to ask you to answer question five after Maria answers question four.”

Another way to use participants’ names in the class is to incorporate their names in your examples. For instance, you could say, “Tomorrow, when Sarah goes to use this new skill, she would first follow these steps....” Or, say something like, “From past experience, at least two of you will have a question about this next week. Jack might wonder about *X*, and Bradley will probably want to know more about *Y*.” Using their names will help personalize the content and help participants stay engaged.

You can also incorporate participants’ names into the class by frequently referring to comments they have made. You may remember that a participant asked a question or made a statement, and you can mention it again at appropriate times during class. For example, you might say, “This next topic will give us even more insight into Emma’s earlier question,” or “Natalie told us about her experience with *X*, which also applies to this step in the process.”

If you want to use this technique but are not sure that you will remember participants’ comments and questions, use a blank page to make notes during discussions. Prior to my virtual classes, I print an extra copy of the roster with participants’ names and keep it on my desk next to my notes. During the introductions, I jot down any pertinent comments that participants make about themselves or the class content. I continue to take short notes on this page during class, and refer to it frequently.



Think About This

It’s not just about saying participants’ names, but also how you say them. When you incorporate participants’ names into your speech, use a conversational tone of voice so that it sounds genuine and not forced.

The more you can use participants' names during class, the more they will stay engaged.

Create Interactivity Using Technology

One of my favorite benefits of delivering synchronous online classes is all the technology available to use. Virtual classroom software programs are full of features that can make training interactive. We reviewed these tools in [chapter 4](#).

A well-designed virtual training class will use all the technology tools offered by the software platform. However, the trick to creating interactivity is to use these tools thoughtfully. Do not use them just because they are there. Use them because they will engage participants, keep their attention, and move everyone toward the learning outcomes.

Your program may be interactive if it uses the technology tools to engage participants. But, it's important that every activity have instructional value leading to the intended learning outcomes. If the class *only* has interactivity, it would be like a face-to-face class full of fun and games but no learning purpose. That type of training is like cotton candy—it looks good, but has no substance.

Wendy Gates Corbett recommends that trainers “change lanes” often while delivering virtually. This means that just like drivers change lanes while driving, a virtual trainer should frequently transition between methods during class. You can do this by using a good mixture of the technology tools to engage participants.

For example, if you have a series of questions to ask, consider having the participants respond verbally to one set of questions, and then in the chat window for the next set of questions. If you want the participants to brainstorm, have them use a whiteboard the first time, and then the chat window the second time.

You can also “change lanes” beyond the technology through your facilitation. For example, if you call on participants by name to respond, use various methods to do so. The first time you call on participants, you might ask them to use the “raise hand” button. The next time you call on participants, start with whoever is dialing in from the farthest time zone and then work your way around the globe. The next time, go in reverse alphabetical order.

I once had a virtual participant named Anissa who logged in to the classroom as “Nissa.” When she introduced herself as Anissa, I asked her which name she preferred to be called. She replied “Anissa,” but she explained that she deliberately signed in as “Nissa”; in a previous class, the trainer always called on her first to respond because her name was at the top of the list.

See [chapter 11](#) for ideas on how to use the tools to engage participants. There are several other books and resources that give activity ideas using a virtual classroom’s technology tools. See the resources section for more information.

Encourage Networking

In a face-to-face class, learners naturally interact with one another and the trainer. Even if they are shy to participate, they may speak to the person sitting next to them or interact with others during small group activities. However, learners in a virtual classroom often perceive the social element to be missing and are less likely to engage with others.

For many, the virtual classroom seems like an anonymous environment, so they may remain hidden during class. Because participants do not leave their personal workspaces to attend class, and do not see their fellow classmates, they may feel alone. The result of feeling alone and anonymous means attendees are less inclined to get involved. Virtual trainers need to work extra hard to build rapport among participants and to promote participation.

When trainers encourage networking, they get the participants involved with one another and therefore engaged in the class. Virtual trainers should strive to create a shared learning experience among participants. One subtle way to do this is to use inclusive language when speaking, such as, “We will cover *X* in today’s class,” or “Let’s all turn to page three of the handout.” Another discreet approach is to allow participants to see the attendee list. (Some virtual classroom programs have the ability to show or hide the list, so make sure it is visible to all.)

In addition, trainers should always take time to do some type of participant introduction activity. If the class size is small, participants could take turns verbally introducing themselves. If the class size is large, then participants could all type an introduction in the chat window or annotate

one on the screen. It's important for participants to see and hear the other learners for them to feel more comfortable engaging with the group.

My favorite way to engage participants through networking is to assign them to a team and have them work together on class activities. An obvious way to work in teams is to use the virtual classroom software's breakout group functionality. Less obvious but still effective ways include:

- Have a friendly team competition for points. Assign point values to questions, and the first person to answer a question wins points for their team.
- Create two-person teams and allow them to communicate with each other through private chat. Give team assignments and have each pair report back.

Take any opportunity you can to get participants networking with one another. It will not only add a social element to the learning environment, but also help you engage participants and keep their attention.

Bring the Training Class to Life

Trainers who communicate using more than words are more likely to engage participants throughout the class. For example, a trainer could simply tell everyone the four steps to a decision-making process. Or, a trainer could display a visual aid that matches the four steps, use the four steps in a recognizable example, and offer an acronym to aid memorization. A trainer could also tell a story about the four steps and use an analogy to help participants understand them. All these methods are examples of bringing the training class to life, and each one will help engage participants by offering an interesting and memorable example.

Wendy Gates Corbett frequently uses the following technique to engage participants. In one of her virtual classes, she posts a picture of a box with "fragile" stamped on it and asks, "How many of you have purchased a new computer?" She then goes on to discuss with participants the setup process for a new computer and relates it to an administrative setup process that they'll be learning in the class. Her visual depiction of a new computer puts the image in participants' minds and helps them put the training topic into context.

In another class, Wendy creates a word picture using serving dishes to explain how to distribute content in a learning management system. She

relates the distribution process to someone who needs to serve food, and who has a choice over what type of serving dishes (big plates, little plates, bowls, cups, and so on) to use based on the type of food they are serving. This simple yet powerful analogy brings the training content to life by using an everyday example that is easily relatable.

Wendy's techniques engage participants by giving them a visual hook—something to think about to help them learn the training content. The visual hook helps keep them involved in the class. You can (and should) use this technique. As part of your pre-class preparation process, plan ways you can bring the content to life. Think of analogies and word pictures you can use to help explain the concepts. Through your word pictures, try to engage participants' senses—sight, smell, sound, touch, and taste. The more you appeal to the learners, the more they will pay attention while you are speaking.

Focus on the Learners

The last tip to engage your participants may be the most important. Effective virtual trainers always remember that the focus is on the participants, and not on the trainer. It's not about us—it's about the participants and what they learn.

For example, a coach on a sports team usually has one goal: to help the team win a championship. The coach's decisions throughout the season reflect this goal. The coach keeps the focus on the players and helps the team play its best. It's the same in your virtual classes. Your goal is to help participants learn.

Many years ago, as a young training professional, I attended an ATD International Conference & Exposition session led by train-the-trainer expert Bob Pike. He talked about the difference between being a "sage on the stage" versus a "guide on the side." He said that a great trainer puts the participants at the center of the experience. The entire class is about the participants instead of the trainer. The trainer's role is simply to guide participants along to achieve intended learning outcomes.

I have found this advice to be true in the virtual classroom as well. When trainers focus on themselves, participants tune out. When trainers focus on the participants, they are more likely to stay engaged.

One way to demonstrate your participant-centric focus is to use inclusive language, like I said earlier. Another approach is to be OK with silence.

While participants are responding to a question, they need time to think about their answer. While they are writing on the whiteboard, they need time to compose their response and post it to the screen. While they are taking a poll, they need time to read the question and all answers, and then time to respond. The point is that trainers who are focused on themselves have a tendency to keep talking. But when a virtual trainer pauses to observe, they will encourage even more participant interaction because the space is allowed for it.

A third way virtual trainers can guide participants through learning is to ask a lot of questions. Questions elicit responses from participants, which in turn keeps them actively involved. We have already discussed effective questioning techniques in [chapter 2](#), including how to provoke discussion, be specific, and maintain a comfortable environment. When you apply those facilitation techniques, they will help keep participants engaged in the class.



Noted

“Ask questions and wait for multiple answers. Ask questions that elicit a story, not just a yes or no. Don’t be afraid of white space (the empty space where no one is talking). It’s OK to put pressure on your participants to fill the nervous gap of silence. When you think it’s time to continue because the silence has gone on long enough, count to five. You will be surprised who responds in those last few seconds who would not have shared before.”

—Michael Abrams, Director, Talent and Leadership Development, Ashley Furniture

Getting It Done

Keeping participants engaged may be the biggest challenge of virtual training, for many reasons. However, with a good class design and excellent facilitation skills, a virtual trainer can successfully engage participants during the entire session. Worksheet 8-1 will help you prepare before class to engage participants.

Worksheet 8-1. Engagement Worksheet

Use this worksheet to help you engage participants during class.

Name of training class:

Part 1: Purpose

What is the overall purpose of this class?

What do the learners need to know as a result of attending?

To what business or performance results will learners be held accountable?
What are the potential consequences if they don't learn?

Part 2: Class Preparation

Based on the answers to the previous questions, what can you specifically do or say to help learners see the benefits of participating in the class?

What relevant stories and examples will you share during class?

How can you capture their attention from the moment they log in? What activity or exercise can they do prior to class?

What word pictures or other visuals can you use to bring the training class to life?

9

Practice, Practice, Practice



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- the importance of practicing your virtual delivery
- how to use feedback
- how to use dress rehearsals
- activities that require extra practice.

Practice, Practice, Practice

What do world-class athletes and musicians have in common? They spend hours and hours each day practicing. Musicians do warm-up exercises, practice basic techniques, and play musical pieces over and over again. Prior to a public performance, they do a complete dress rehearsal to ensure their show components are all ready.

Athletes also practice regularly. They practice basic skills, run drills, and simulate game-day situations. Depending upon the sport, they may practice with the rest of their team, or they may practice on their own. They work with a coach who provides perspective and guidance on their performance. And they use their practice time to get physically and mentally prepared for the next exhibition.

Practice Makes Perfect

Virtual trainers need to do the same: practice, practice, practice. They should practice on their own and with others. They should practice their basic virtual delivery skills, simulate the online classroom environment, and run through “drills” to prepare for every scenario. They could also work with a “coach,” who will have a different perspective on their classroom performance.

Many years ago, when I was a training manager, the trainers on my team would be scheduled for a few days of prep time before each new class so that they could learn and practice the material. Each one had their own preparation style. One trainer would go into an empty classroom and practice facilitating a class from start to finish. She pretended to have an audience, and walked through every activity as if people were participating. At the time, I thought that type of thorough rehearsal was overkill; however, I now believe that it is exactly the right thing to do for virtual classes. You should have at least one complete dress rehearsal of the virtual training session, and preferably more.



Noted

“My advice for new virtual trainers? Practice as though you were actually doing it, and do it more than one time. Practice changing slides. Practice using the whiteboard. Practice opening polls. Play around with it, and get comfortable with it. Practice everything.”

—Tracy Stallard, Independent Training Consultant

All trainers, regardless of experience or skill level, should take time to practice delivering virtually. Even if you can think fast on your feet when facilitating, practicing is still critical to your success. You may be able to wing it in a face-to-face class with successful results. But spontaneously delivering a virtual class simply will not work. In the physical classroom, you could stumble over a few words when speaking, yet make up for it by your smile, gestures, and overall appearance. However, in the virtual classroom, when you stumble over your words, it sounds as if you are not prepared.

We already discussed preparation in [chapter 5](#); this chapter focuses specifically on how to practice your virtual delivery. We’ll look at ways to set up a practice environment, and how to complete a full dry run of your virtual event.

You can maximize your training effectiveness through quality practice. When you practice virtual delivery techniques, it improves your overall facilitation skills. When you practice using the virtual classroom software, it improves your ability to multitask and successfully deliver training in this environment. And when you practice using the content, it improves your knowledge of the topic and ability to check for learning transfer.



Noted

“An extemporaneous introduction in the face-to-face classroom may sound OK. Yet saying exactly the same words in the virtual classroom could sound sloppy and unprepared.”

—Joe Willmore, President and Founder, Willmore Consulting Group

Whether this is your first or 100th virtual delivery, practicing your techniques will improve your skills. Think of it this way: even Super Bowl champions, Stanley Cup winners, and World Series victors go back to basic

training camp at the beginning of each season. They practice the fundamentals to improve their performance. So should virtual trainers.

General Practice

If you are new to virtual delivery, begin with general practice sessions. Look for opportunities to lead virtual meetings or to give short online presentations. You could do this within your organization at internal meetings or offer to help with someone else's virtual class.

One way to practice delivering is to partner with colleagues who are proficient in the virtual classroom. Ask if you can co-facilitate a class with them. They may be willing to share the stage, or at least help you get started with some practice.

For example, one of my colleagues was asked to deliver a virtual class. She had no online training experience, so I worked with her to help her learn. We made arrangements to co-facilitate the first few classes together. In addition to our other preparation steps, we practiced the full session together three times before the first delivery. The practice opportunities helped her get comfortable with the online classroom and allowed us to rehearse our handoffs and division of responsibilities.

There are also plenty of places to practice if you want to start somewhere other than work. Look for local volunteer opportunities, especially with groups who meet virtually. As a training professional, get involved with your local ATD chapter. Many chapters hold virtual meetings, and if you volunteer for the program committee or a leadership role, you will most likely have an opportunity to practice your virtual delivery skills.

If you want to get started on your practice but do not have easy access to a virtual classroom software platform, take advantage of the free trial accounts available through most vendor websites. Create your own online events, and invite friends or co-workers to participate.

Jeff Smith, CEO of Voltage Leadership Consulting, was an early adopter of virtual technologies. However, he started small and practiced. His first sessions were not with clients. Instead, he started using the technology in a “low-stress” environment—internal department meetings. He and his team began playing around and experimenting with the tools. They gave presentations, used the software tools, and practiced. This helped them learn

and get comfortable with virtual delivery. The more they practiced, the better they became.

When you practice, focus on getting comfortable with the technology and delivering to an audience you cannot see. This is your opportunity to try things out and play with the software. You can practice multitasking—looking at your delivery notes while keeping an eye on the chat window and other screen elements. Practice as often as you can and more than you think you need.

If you are an experienced virtual trainer, use this practice time to take your game to the next level. Focus on the small nuances that can have a big impact on your delivery. For example, are you using inclusive language (“let’s all look at this model”) instead of trainer-centric language (“I want you to look at this model”)? Or, have you eliminated filler words from your delivery? Although I don’t recommend recording live training events, this is one time a recorded session could be useful. When practicing for delivery, record the session and then play it back to critique yourself and identify areas for improvement.



Think About This

Pay special attention to one technique at a time when practicing your virtual delivery. For example, one time you might focus on your rate of speech, and the next time pay extra attention to your word choices. While it’s important to have the complete delivery package, during your practices you can strive for improvement in one area at a time.

Getting Feedback

When you first learn how to deliver virtually, invite people you know and trust to be your participants in general practice sessions. Ask them to honestly evaluate your delivery, and be open to their comments. Solicit feedback on the following elements of your delivery:

- voice (is it clear? easy to hear? good tone and pitch?)
- word choices (any filler words? unnecessary trainer self-talk?)
- rate of speech (too fast? too slow? just right?)
- activity instructions (clear, concise, and complete?).

When gathering feedback on your practice, ask participants to share one thing you did well and one suggestion for improvement. Or, ask each person to focus on one of the listed items and provide specific positive and constructive feedback on just that area. What's important when receiving feedback is to listen without getting defensive and to be open to ideas for change.

Dress Rehearsals

Broadway shows and other live performances hold dress rehearsals, and so should your virtual training events.

The first time you deliver each class, plan to walk through it in full as if you were delivering it. That means if it is a 90-minute session, you would have at least a 90-minute rehearsal. If you have a producer or any co-facilitators, they should also participate just as they would during the live training event.



Basic Rule 14

Schedule dress rehearsals far enough in advance of the training class so there is time to make necessary changes to the class and, if needed, time for additional practice.

Plan to run at least two full dress rehearsals prior to delivering a virtual class for the first time. The first dress rehearsal will help you test the technology and flow of activities. The second dress rehearsal will reinforce your preparation and allow you to check any changes that were made after the first rehearsal.

Dress Rehearsal Environment

You will want to set up your dress rehearsal practice environment exactly as you will when you deliver the class. This means you will:

- Prepare your trainer notes and all class files.
- Set up your personal workspace with your primary computer and a sidekick.
- Set up the virtual classroom as if you were expecting your participants to arrive.

- Set up the same telephony options that you plan to use during your event.
- Invite mock participants to attend the session.

During a dress rehearsal, it's important to always use the exact virtual classroom software that you will be using for your class. Recently, I worked with a trainer who was delivering in the virtual classroom for the first time. My role for the event was to be the producer, and she would be the main facilitator. We initially practiced using the virtual training software, which in our case was hosted by a third-party vendor. We also used the third party's conference-calling system for our audio connection. We then practiced using the client's version of the same virtual training software and their conference-calling system, which were both hosted by a different third-party vendor. In our dress rehearsals, we noticed a few small differences between the systems, such as the telephone moderator commands and the default participant privileges. While these differences may seem insignificant, they could have had a big impact during the virtual event if we were not aware of them.

Dress Rehearsal Participants

Ideally, the participants you invite to the dress rehearsal will not know the content or be familiar with the course design. This will more realistically mimic the class.

It's also good to have the instructional designer and other trainers participate in the dress rehearsal. They can give you feedback from their perspective on the flow and timing of activities, as well as tips for improving your virtual delivery skills. They'll also be able to keep an eye on the participant involvement and whether the overall class outcomes were met as intended.

If for any reason (availability, confidentiality of the content, and so on) you have trouble finding available practice participants, don't let a lack of people prevent you from holding a dress rehearsal. You could invite friends or family who know nothing about the virtual classroom to log in and act as participants. Or, at the very least, you could set up multiple computers in your own work environment and pretend to have participants—just like my classroom trainer did years ago.

If possible, have your dress rehearsal participants use the same types of computers that the real participants will be using. This includes various

operating systems, browsers, and screen resolutions. It may also include different Internet connection speeds. This variety will help you authentically replicate the class environment.

When conducting a second or third dress rehearsal, invite new participants to attend. There is an advantage to having the same participants attend each rehearsal—they can give you feedback on what improved from the first session. However, to fully practice in a realistic training environment, you should have participants who are not familiar with the material attend each time. A compromise would be to have a mixture of “old” and “new” participants in each rehearsal, which could give you the benefit of both scenarios.



Think About This

It's important to test out a variety of connection options to the virtual classroom software during a dress rehearsal. You might discover that your visual aids do not show well on a particular monitor resolution, or that the video playback in one location is problematic. Discovering these unexpected abnormalities prior to the training event will give you time to troubleshoot and correct the issues.

Things to Look for During a Dress Rehearsal

When you facilitate a dress rehearsal for a new virtual training class, there are several things to look for during the delivery:

- **Activity choice:** Is this the best activity for the learning outcome?
Does it engage participants?
- **Activity flow:** How well do the activities flow from one to the next?
Are they in the best order?
- **Activity transitions:** Are the transitions between activities smooth and seamless?
- **Instructions:** Do the participants know exactly what they should be doing at all times? Are any additional directions needed?
- **Visual aids:** Do the visual aids (such as PowerPoint slides, whiteboards, and handouts) match the course content?
- **Timing:** How does actual timing compare with the expected timing?
What activities need more time? Less time?

- **Speaker transitions:** If more than one person is delivering (co-facilitators and/or a producer), are the transitions between speakers smooth and seamless?

If your dress rehearsal reveals significant design flaws or major changes to be made, be open to them. This is one reason the dress rehearsal should be scheduled far enough in advance of the first delivery—so that changes can be made.

In the case of a virtual class that has been delivered many times and tested by other trainers, your focus should be less on the activity design and more on your delivery of it. The previous questions are still valid; you simply consider them in a different context. For example, if during your dress rehearsal the timing of an activity was way off the intended length, consider how your delivery can be adjusted to make the allotted time work. If participants were not clear on the instructions for an activity, review the word choices you used when giving those directions. Or, if the visual aids did not match up, was it because you forgot to change from one slide to the next?



Think About This

If you are using virtual classroom software that has a perpetually available room, be sure you completely reset all activities to their original state after the dress rehearsal. This includes:

- moving the shared documents back to page one
- clearing the chat history
- rewinding any video clips to the beginning
- removing all poll responses
- erasing the whiteboard.

Tips to Remember for Timing

Just like in a face-to-face class, your timing may not go as planned. The discussion could go off on a tangent, or you could have someone who talks too much. You may also have more participants than you expect, which makes some activities take longer.

Therefore, during your practice, determine content areas that could be shortened without detracting from the learning objectives of the class. For example, if you would normally ask for four volunteers to share a personal

example, you could ask for only two volunteers to share. Or there might be a “nice to know” activity that the participants could do on their own after class.

The opposite holds true, of course. In the rare instance where you find yourself with more time than needed, you could give your participants the gift of this extra time and release them from class early, or you could consider which activities could be expanded. These additions should enhance the learning experience and not just “fill time” for the sake of making class last longer.

Activities That Require Extra or Special Practice

In some cases, an activity looks good on paper but falls flat in the online environment, or the technology does not work as you expected. In addition, it’s important to know what you, as the trainer, should experience during the activities, as well as what the participants should experience. Pay special attention to the following activity types and software features during your practice sessions.

Polls

Determine at what point a poll question needs to be opened. If you are co-facilitating or working with a producer, figure out which one of you will open the poll to solicit participant answers, and when and if the poll results will be shared.

In one of my virtual classes, my co-facilitator and I discovered an awkward moment when loading a poll question. The handoff was not smooth, and seemed clunky to everyone in the class. Therefore, we practiced working out the exact timing of our poll question setup. Now, when he lands on a certain slide, I briefly take presenter control and open the next poll question behind the scenes. I then turn presenter control back over to him before he needs it. Later in the class, when the poll question is needed, it’s already loaded and just needs to be opened for participant responses. The participants are unaware of our handoff, and the awkward moment no longer occurs.

Whiteboards

Practice annotating and typing on the screen, and then erasing. Look to see if everything shows up exactly as expected, for you and for the participants.

In one virtual classroom software I use, I discovered that one of the annotation tools shows up slightly to the right of where I click, instead of in the center. I also discovered that the default highlighter color did not show well on my slide background. I was able to make adjustments prior to the class to accommodate for these tools.

Breakout Groups

Determine how you will assign participants to a breakout group, and exactly when you will release them to their groups. Notice if there will be any lag time between the activity directions and the start of the breakout group. Also determine if any before-class breakout room preparation needs to be done by the trainer, and, if so, how and when you will do it. In addition, plan what you will do during the breakout group activity—will you go in and out of the rooms or stay in the main room? If you visit the rooms, will you be a silent observer or speak to the group? Will you communicate with the groups during the activity or let them work on their own?

When I practice assigning breakout groups, I like to plan who will go into what groups. I consciously assign partners and teams to promote networking across departments and locations. I also test out the frequency of communicating with the groups during an activity. I don't want them to be interrupted by my intrusions, yet I also don't want them to be lost without direction. During practice, I try to determine the appropriate amount of facilitator involvement in each breakout group activity.

Shared Web Browser

Practice transitioning to the website you wish to view during class. This transition should be as seamless as possible to the participants. For example, have your webpage preloaded or saved as a quick link so you can jump right to it without stopping on your browser's default homepage. Also, if you plan to type in any fields or dialog boxes that remember your previous entries, clear out your browsing history and Google searches—otherwise participants might see your past websites and searches. Make it as “clean” as possible for the participants.

I once watched a trainer share his web browser, and start typing in a search window. His browser settings caused past searches to appear on a drop-down list as he typed, which is usually a helpful shortcut for Internet searching. While there was nothing unusual about his past Internet searches, he paused for a moment when the autocomplete list appeared. It's always a good idea to clear your history prior to a virtual delivery, just in case.

Here's an example of what all this practicing and rehearsing looks like in real life: One of my clients had the same virtual training class scheduled eight times over a five-month timeframe. Prior to our first delivery, my co-facilitators and I held four dress rehearsals. Then, immediately after each class, we met to debrief the experience and make all necessary adjustments to our materials. I also reset my facilitator notes and the virtual classroom materials. Then, a few days before the next event, we would each individually review and prepare for the upcoming class.

Getting It Done

The more you deliver in the virtual classroom, the more practice you will get and the better your training will be. If you are an occasional virtual trainer, make a deliberate choice to schedule practice time in your calendar before every event. The conscious decision to continually practice your delivery will reduce your anxiety and improve your classes. Even if you practice frequently, remember that this does not take the place of your class setup (see [chapter 5](#)). Instead, this practice is in addition to it.

Also remember that regardless of how often you deliver the same virtual class, it's a good idea to consider each session as a practice dress rehearsal. Solicit feedback after each class, making notes about what can be improved about your delivery. Feedback is a gift when you are open to it. Use your practice time to improve your training. Use Worksheets 9-1 and 9-2 to track your practice sessions.

Worksheet 9-1. Practice Checklist

Use this worksheet during a dress rehearsal for a virtual training class.

Topic	Questions to Ask	Changes to Make for Next Time
Activity choice	Is this the best activity for the learning outcome?	
Activity flow	How well do the activities flow from one to the next?	
Activity transitions	Are the transitions between activities smooth and seamless?	
Instructions	Do the participants know exactly what they should be doing at all times? Are any additional directions needed?	
Visual aids	Do the visual aids (e.g., slides, whiteboards, and handouts) match the course content?	
Timing	How does the actual timing compare with the expected timing? What activities need more time? Less time?	
Speaker transitions	If more than one person is delivering (e.g., co-facilitators and a producer), are the transitions between speakers smooth and seamless?	

Worksheet 9-2. Practice Schedule

Use this worksheet to track your practice sessions.

Name of training class:

Facilitator name:

Co-facilitator name (if applicable):

Producer name (if applicable):

Date	Time	Participants	Feedback Received	Action Items

10

Know What to Do When Everything Goes Wrong



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- to prepare to prevent problems
- to stay calm
- to manage the situation.

Know What to Do When Everything Goes Wrong

Virtual training classes often have challenging moments. From technology problems to connection issues to unexpected glitches, all these conditions are common in synchronous online events. Many trainers fear this aspect of virtual training; they are concerned about how to handle the problems and what to do when things go wrong.

Yet it's not much different from the problem-solving skills trainers use in the face-to-face classroom. In the classroom, trainers deal with challenges all the time—broken projectors, missing materials, video players that don't work, distracting noise, and other unexpected commotions. When these things happen, skilled classroom trainers simply manage the situation and move on with class.

It's the same in the virtual classroom. Things can and will go wrong. You will encounter everything from participants who cannot connect to a software feature not working as planned to unexpected disruptions to the class. All these and more are typical occurrences during a synchronous online event. When they happen, skilled virtual trainers simply manage the problem and move on with class.

There are three rules to follow to keep your problems and their impact to a minimum:

1. Prepare to prevent problems.
2. Stay calm.
3. Manage the situation.

Let's explore each one in detail.



Noted

“Expect something to go wrong.”

—Jim Wilcox, Former Regional Training Manager, AchieveGlobal

Prepare to Prevent Problems

The number one thing you can do when things go wrong is to be prepared. Your preparation before a virtual training class begins can literally make or break the event when something unexpected happens. Your preparation makes it easier to deal with technical glitches and problems. Your preparation also helps you handle participant issues. The more prepared you are, the easier it will be to respond when things don't go as planned.

For example, if your class includes a video, then your preparation could include uploading the video script to the virtual classroom software's file-sharing tool. Then if the video playback experiences unforeseen problems, participants will have easy access to the script and you can ask for volunteers to act out the dialogue. Or, if your computer crashes unexpectedly but you have prepared a backup computer, then you could quickly switch to it while continuing class. Or, if you prepare extra slides with activity instructions, participants who may not have printed the handout will still be able to engage. Each of these situations could be a disaster that affects the virtual class, yet your advance preparation prevents disruption.

In another example, trainer Jeff Smith was delivering a virtual session when his co-facilitator had to make an early exit due to a fire in her building. Jeff had to deliver the rest of the class on his own. He was able to do this because he had prepared both sections of class—just in case. When the “just in case” became the case, he was able to stay calm and continue the class, without negatively affecting the participants.



Noted

“Everything depends on how well you prepare.”

—Tracy Stallard, Independent Training Consultant

In essence, the main purpose of this book is to prepare you to effectively deliver virtual training classes. If you have completed all the recommended actions up to this point, then responding to problems during a virtual class should not be a big deal. By following the steps, you will have:

- learned about technology
- mastered the virtual classroom software program
- prepared your workspace
- improved your ability to multitask
- harnessed your voice
- practiced over and over again.

The probability of something going wrong in the first place will diminish if you have fully followed these steps. When something unexpected *does* happen, you will be able to rely on your knowledge of the technology, the virtual classroom software, and contingency plans you have prepared. You'll keep your voice calm, and you'll be able to multitask by keeping the class going while dealing with the situation.

For a few examples of how your preparation can help you respond to a problem in the virtual classroom, see [Table 10-1](#).

Table 10-1. Preparing for Problems

Situation	Possible Cause	How to Prevent the Situation	A Possible in-the-Moment Response
A participant has trouble logging in to the virtual classroom event	User error if the participant does not have the correct web link or types in the wrong password	• Ensure participants have the correct connection information prior to the class • Have both the host/trainer link and password and the participant link and password in an easily accessible spot	• Email the correct link and password to the participant • Verbally tell the participant the link and password information
A virtual classroom software feature does not work as planned (e.g., a poll question does not load)	User error if the producer or trainer clicks on the wrong button	• Master the virtual classroom software program, knowing all the buttons and features • Practice all the software features ahead of time	• Pause, then click on the correct button • Switch to a contingency plan, such as typing the poll question on the whiteboard
Participants are not able to annotate on the screen or whiteboard	User error if the producer or trainer did not enable this participant functionality	• Practice all the software features ahead of time • Follow all pre-class setup procedures, including checking required participant privileges	• Navigate to the participant privileges screen and enable these privileges

There are times when you will be fully prepared yet things will still go wrong, such as a server outage or unanticipated disaster. Despite your best efforts, these unexpected occurrences could create problems for your virtual training class.

For instance, another trainer and I recently delivered a series of virtual training events for an organization. We had practiced and prepared, and separately delivered several successful sessions. Then one day, for some seemingly unexplained reason, my training colleague began a class and nothing seemed to work. Several participants had trouble logging in to the session. Others were able to log in but were not able to see the shared document. Still others were not able to see the video clip during the class. The trainer did everything she could to prepare, yet these problems still occurred. Later, we found out that the participants' IT department had made

some organization-wide technology updates on everyone's computer, and had not thought about how this would affect our training. We were not aware of the updates. This lack of communication, coupled with the technology changes, created a difficult situation for the virtual event. The trainer had to deal with these unexpected challenges. Luckily, she was able to do so, in part because she stayed calm, which leads us to the next technique for handling a challenging situation.

Stay Calm

When things go wrong, the key is to stay calm. Take a deep breath. Pause, so that you can think clearly enough to react appropriately. Assess the situation and decide what to do next.

It's the mark of a professional in any field to remain cool and collected under stress. Effective virtual trainers do so as well. They maintain their composure and stay calm when things go wrong.

For example, if a software feature is not working the way you expected it to, and you have a contingency plan for the activity, you could simply go to the alternative activity without mentioning it to the participants (such as, "Let's respond to this next question using the chat window"). Or, if you had already told them to expect a poll and you have to change to a contingency plan, just do it without giving too much extra detail (such as, "Instead, let's switch and respond to this next question in the chat window").



Noted

"The more you call attention to a technical glitch, the more people will focus on it. Instead, recognize it, manage it, deal with it, and move on."

—Tracy Stallard, Independent Training Consultant

Don't be overly concerned with how participants will react when they know there is a problem. Most will work with you when things go wrong. In the face-to-face classroom, when a flipchart marker runs dry or the projector bulb blows, the participants realize these things happen and do not get upset. The classroom trainer's appropriate response to these situations is to stay calm, get another marker, or keep going without the projector until the next break. It's the same in the virtual classroom. When unexpected

technical difficulties occur online, most participants are very understanding, especially when the trainer stays calm in the situation.



Think About This

Be aware of what you say out loud when things go wrong. Be mindful of your trainer “self-talk,” which may appear when something unexpected happens. Your initial response may be to comment on the problem, which may or may not be appropriate for the situation.

Manage the Situation

When things go wrong in the virtual classroom, you should take steps to manage the situation and keep the class going. It’s best if you can maintain the flow of the class and keep the situation seamless to the participants. Ideally, they won’t even know that there is a problem. If the problem is obvious to one or more participants, then it’s just a slight challenge that gets worked through without too much disruption to the learning.

For example, Jeff Smith was in the middle of leading a virtual session when something unexpected happened to his telephone connection. As a result, the participants could only hear every other word he said. Once he realized there was a problem, he simply typed a chat message to let everyone know what he was about to do, and then he hung up and dialed back in. His connection was fixed, and the class continued along as planned.

In a similar example, Jim Wilcox was co-facilitating a virtual training class. His co-facilitator was in a separate but adjoining conference room. In the middle of the session, it was Jim’s turn to speak, and for some unexplained reason, his telephone remained on mute. He had pressed the right buttons, but his phone remained silent. He was speaking, but no one heard him—except the co-facilitator in the adjoining room, who could hear his voice through the wall. She took over for him and facilitated his portion of the class. Eventually, he realized that no one could hear him, so he simply hung up the telephone and dialed in again. Meanwhile, it was seamless to participants, and the class continued on schedule.

Not long after one of my recent virtual classes began, the online meeting and associated conference call unexpectedly ended, and I was not able to reconnect. I opened my email program, sent a quick message to the

participants in the class, and asked them to stay tuned for directions. I then created another online event using the virtual classroom software, sent the participants a new connection link and telephone conference code, and restarted the training. It took a few minutes for me to reload the presentation materials and poll questions. We lost about 10 minutes of time, but the participants were understanding and ready to continue learning.



Basic Rule 15

When something unexpected occurs, take a deep breath and stay calm.

What's the common thread between these stories? In all cases, something unexpected happened. And in all cases, the class continued mostly as planned. The trainers stayed calm, they took steps to remedy the situation, and they managed the problem.

This is exactly what you should do when an unexpected problem occurs during your virtual training class—manage the problem and keep the class moving forward.

Managing Technical Problems

When technical problems occur, hopefully you have a producer who can step in and troubleshoot the problem while you continue the class. This is one of the main reasons a producer is recommended. One of the producer's primary roles is to handle the technical components of the virtual classroom, which includes problem solving.

If you don't have a producer, you could ask a technical contact or a fellow trainer to join the virtual class for the first 10 minutes. Because most connection problems occur during the first few minutes of class when everyone is logging on, ask this person to be your "as-needed, short-term, back-up troubleshooter." Unless major problems arise, this person is free to log out and drop off the line after the first 10 minutes of class.

There are times when it's not possible to have a producer, co-facilitator, or any additional help. In those cases, your multitasking skills are truly tested. As a general rule of thumb, if you can quickly work with an individual participant having trouble, then go ahead and do so. For example, if you can get them back on track in under a minute's time, then

help them. However, if it will take you longer than a minute to help them out, consider what other options are available.

In a recent virtual class of mine where I was alone, without a producer, a participant temporarily lost his Internet connection and could not find the meeting link to reconnect. He needed the specific meeting number and passcode for our session. I knew I could quickly tell him the information he needed, even faster than I could get it to him in an email. So, I paused the class to verbally give him the information. It took just a moment, and everyone was understanding while he received the troubleshooting assistance needed. Had he needed more involved technical assistance, I would have offered one or two short suggestions, and then either asked him to press #0 (the operator-assistance code for my conference-calling provider) or asked him to reschedule the class for another time. If he were in a building where another participant was connected, then I would have considered asking him to go pull up a chair next to that person and share a connection.

For a list of common technical problem and troubleshooting tips, see [Table 10-2](#).

Table 10-2. Common Technical Problems and Troubleshooting Tips

Problem	Troubleshooting Tips
Participants can't log in	• Check the web link and passcode they are using • Have them close their browser and reopen it before trying again
Participants do not see your screen or shared documents	• Use the virtual classroom software's "synchronize" command to sync everyone's display • Have them exit and re-enter the virtual classroom event
Participants have trouble seeing or hearing a video clip	• Require participants to test the virtual classroom software features prior to the class • Have them check to ensure the volume is turned up • Have a printed copy of the video script available
The trainer has trouble sharing a document	• Check the file type compatibility with the virtual classroom program • Instead of sharing the document, share the application (or share your desktop with the application open on it)

Aside from connection challenges, most technical glitches are specific to the software you are using. For example, as we reviewed in [chapter 4](#), one platform may have participant privileges that control what the participants can and cannot do in each event. Another platform may have unique rules over how the eraser works on a whiteboard. As you learn and practice the software tools, make note of how these features work so you can become an expert in troubleshooting them.



Noted

“If worse comes to worst, you can always reschedule the session. Strange things have happened and will happen. Keep a level head, make a joke, and move on.”

—Jeff Smith, CEO, Voltage Leadership Consulting

Getting It Done

The moral of the story is to expect the unexpected. Things can and will go wrong when you are facilitating in the virtual classroom. While it's hard to predict what specifically will go wrong, you can rest assured that at least one challenging situation will probably happen during class. This fact is true for even the most prepared trainer. Therefore, remember the three steps to handle it: Prepare thoroughly, stay calm, and manage the situation. By doing these, you will keep the class moving toward the learning outcomes. Use Worksheet 10-1 to keep track of problems that arise during your training classes.

Worksheet 10-1. Troubleshooting Log

Use this log to keep track of problems that arise during your training classes. Frequently refer to this list as a learning tool.

Name of training class:

Name of virtual software classroom program:

[illegible]

11

Design Interactive Programs



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn to:

- define program outcomes
- set the stage for interaction
- get creative when selecting activities
- close with a call to action.

Design Interactive Programs

While this book has primarily focused on techniques for facilitating virtual classes, it's important not to ignore the importance of interactive design. Design and delivery go together as inseparable components of effective virtual training. You can't—and shouldn't—have one without the other. Unfortunately, poor design is one reason that virtual programs have a reputation as being boring.

Effective virtual classes engage participants, create a comfortable space for learning, and provide opportunities to apply new skills. They do this through well-thought-out, intentionally planned designs. That means it's more than just clicking through slides while someone talks. It's about creating a high-quality learning experience.

Whether you are converting a traditional class to the virtual classroom, or starting from scratch with a new program, the process is almost the same. Infuse relevant interactivity into the program to engage participants in the learning experience.

This chapter outlines six techniques that will help you design an effective and interactive virtual class:

1. Define the session type.
2. Review the learning objectives.
3. Set the stage for interaction.
4. Select activities for maximum involvement.
5. Close with a call to action.
6. Create materials for facilitators, producers, and participants.

Define the Session Type

When you begin to design a virtual class, it's tempting to just open a blank slide presentation, add images, and start writing. Or to take a slide deck that you've used in an in-person class and believe you already have a design.

Imagine if you were to build a house by starting to dig the foundation before creating a blueprint, or by using a blueprint that doesn't fit the terrain of the land. Neither method brings success. Starting to create slides (or repurpose existing ones) before you have a blueprint prepared will not lead to success either.

The true first step in designing an interactive class is to determine what you are designing for. What's your overarching goal for the session? What are you trying to accomplish? What topic are you trying to convey? What information should be shared, or what skill needs to be learned?

Also ask questions about your participants. What do they already know about the topic? What experiences do they have that you can draw upon? What questions are they likely to ask? What concerns will they express?

And given the answers to all these questions, what's the best way to achieve your goals? Do you need a main presenter who will provide one-way communication to a large audience? Will it be a facilitated meeting with every participant taking an active role in speaking? Will it be a panel discussion with interactive questions and answers from a large audience? Will it be a small-group training class that requires participants to have hands-on skill practice?

Each of these examples represents a different type of session, and therefore will naturally have a different type of design. Once you determine your goal, and the type of session you will have, you can design appropriately.

It's a common mistake to mix the session types in thought and design. In other words, you might think you are designing a training class when it's just a presentation with one-way communication. Instead, design a session that builds on your established framework and desired outcome—an interactive training class.

If your goal is to have a one-way presentation instead of an engaging training class, then you can still add some interactivity to your session by using the techniques found in this chapter. Your participants will be more likely to pay attention if you use them.



Noted

If your program doesn't have learning objectives, or it has poorly written ones that don't clearly state measurable job requirements, then pause here to write (or rewrite) them. It will be worth the time and effort.

Review the Learning Objectives

What are the stated learning objectives for the program? The objectives will drive many design decisions because they explicitly state what learners need to be able to know or do back on the job after participating in the program. By paying close attention to the learning objectives, you can determine your virtual program structure and flow. Therefore, once you have determined the session type, you should review the learning objectives.

List the program's learning objectives and ask: Will you be able to accomplish them all in one short virtual event? Or will you need a series of virtual events? Since most virtual events are only 60-90 minutes in length, more than a few learning objectives usually means more than one event.

What's the time sensitivity to each objective in relation to the job task? Should the participants learn it and then practice it on the job before moving on to the next learning point? If so, then creating a series of short virtual events with practice assignments in between might be a perfect solution. For example, if the learning program's goal is to teach service reps how to use a customer database, then show them the program in logical steps and let them practice and play with it between each step. Likewise, if a learning program's goal is for machinists to learn how to operate and maintain a piece of equipment, then teach it to them in logical segments and allow them time to examine their own shop floor equipment in between each segment. In both cases, the learning program would be chunked into smaller parts, with hands-on-practice and application time in between. Learning rarely happens in a one-and-done event. Learning occurs over time, in designs that allow for practice and spaced repetition.



Think About This

If you need to turn a traditional class into a virtual one, follow these three basic guidelines for success:

1. **Begin with the learning objectives.** Go back to the training class's original design documents and review the performance outcomes. What should learners know or do as a result of participating in the class? Establish these as the groundwork for your virtual training.
2. **Determine the overall format that could achieve this outcome.** Consider creating a blended solution with a mixture of methods. Ask yourself: What activities could you ask the learners to do on their own, and what should be done together virtually?
3. **Select activities for maximum participant involvement.** Use activity ideas from the classroom content, and make full use of the virtual classroom software tools available to engage participants in learning.

You may want to consider a blended program—a collection of learning activities in the same training curriculum. For example, it can be a series of self-paced assignments interspersed between live facilitator-led online events. Are there some things that participants could (and should) learn on their own? Or would a combination of self-paced and facilitator-led activities be the right fit? For example, could participants watch a video and then get together in a synchronous facilitated session to discuss it? Or could participants meet with a facilitator to kick off the program series, then read some reference material, then work in small groups on a case study, and then meet to present and receive feedback on their solutions? These are all examples of “blended” programs. Virtual classes are often part of a larger, blended curriculum.



Noted

“Your face-to-face training sessions absolutely can’t be used as-is for the virtual classroom. They need deconstructing and rebuilding: a flipchart turns into a whiteboard; a one-on-one conversation becomes a private chat message; group work becomes breakout rooms. Your slides need to be better, your questions need to be rewritten. Invest time here for brilliant delivery later.”

—Jo Cook, Live Online Learning and Virtual Classroom Expert, LightbulbMoment.info

Set the Stage for Interaction

An interactive virtual class should be engaging from the moment that your participants register for it. That means that the expectation should be set from the very beginning that it's going to be an active learning experience. Use the following moments to create a great opening:

- the registration email message a participant receives upon enrolling for the class
- every reminder message that is sent
- upon logging in to the virtual session
- at the start of class.

Registration Message

Start creating interactivity from the first message participants receive about the class. For example, the messaging received upon class enrollment could invite them to do one or more of the following:

- Engage with other participants on a discussion board.
- Print a handout with a relevant pre-class exercise that will be referred to during class.
- Respond to a topic-related question or two, bringing their answers with them to class.
- Send questions they have about the topic to the facilitator.

When sending this pre-class request, keep in mind your participants and their likelihood of completing the assignment. They will be more apt to complete it if any of the following conditions are true (Huggett 2014):

- It's a topically relevant activity that's simple to complete.
- It's a class that has active support from the learners' managers, who have encouraged them to participate.
- It's a class topic that participants are highly motivated to learn about.
- It's a series of classes, and the upcoming session is not the first event in the series.

Even if none of these situations is true for your learners, you can still set the stage for interaction and encourage completion by keeping the assignment "short and sweet"—relevant to the course content and quick and easy for learners to do.

Reminder Messages

The encouragement to interact should continue with any reminders that you send. These reminders should include not only class logistical information, but also information that lets participants know the session will be interactive.

For example, you could explicitly state that they should prepare to be hands-on during the session and that you'll expect them to respond often. Remind them to close out of their email and other messaging programs at the start of the session so they can give the class their full attention. Consider sending them a “Do Not Disturb—Training in Session” sign that they could hang on their office door. By communicating these expectations prior to the session, participants will not be blindsided when they are asked to actively engage when the session begins.

If possible, at least one reminder message should be sent directly from the facilitator instead of an automated system. This personal touch will begin to build rapport between the facilitator and participants. In addition, the individual message may have a greater likelihood of being opened and read.

Upon Login

The next opportunity to create an interactive environment is the moment a participant logs in to the platform. As mentioned in [chapter 8](#), it's important to capture attention from the start. That means the program design includes a “soft opening” activity to get the participants hands-on with the virtual classroom platform right away.

Welcoming activities set the stage for interaction because they can reference the pre-class assignment, preview the training topic, or help participants learn how to use the interactive platform tools. Most important, they help participants realize that this program expects them to get involved.

Start of Class

At the official start time of your virtual training class, get everyone involved by beginning with an interactive exercise. If you need to welcome participants or do some other housekeeping task that requires the facilitator to talk, be sure these participant-passive moments last no more than a

minute or two. Participants need to interact with the tools and with one another within the first three minutes, or you will have lost the opportunity to set the stage for an interactive experience.



Basic Rule 16

Encourage participants to join a session five to 10 minutes early, so they can be ready to begin at the actual start time. You could even set your calendar appointment requests to begin five to 10 minutes prior to the actual class start time.

For example, immediately ask everyone to introduce themselves in chat. You could also post a short-answer poll question that requires typing, or use the onscreen drawing tools to have everyone complete an exercise. Additionally, you could put everyone into a breakout room with an assignment to complete as a small group.

The main point of these ideas is that every single participant should be clicking or typing in this first activity, to reinforce the notion that everyone will be asked to participate throughout.

Select Activities for Maximum Involvement

Once you have set the stage for interaction, it's important to keep the momentum going. You've established that participants are expected to join in and take part in their learning. You've gotten them involved from the start, so it's important to maintain that level of energy.



Noted

If you have too much content to allow for interactivity every four minutes, then you might have a presentation instead of a training program. You might need to redesign your program to be more learner centered than facilitator led.

Remember, it's not about interaction for the sake of interaction. It's about engaging participants in their own learning.

You should aim to design a virtual class that engages participants about every three minutes. This frequency keeps participants focused on what

they need to learn. It also helps keep them from getting bored or distracted by what's going on around them in their physical environments.

One of the biggest advantages to using a virtual classroom is the variety of tools available to get participants involved in their learning. When designing, use the platform tools to engage participants, and use your creativity to design unique interactions.

Use the Platform Tools

First, consider the abundance of platform tools that can be used for each activity: chat, polls, status indicators, drawing, whiteboards, file share, web browsing, video, notes, breakouts, and more! These common tools available in virtual classroom programs allow so many alternative ways for learners to interact. For example, if you use paper or electronic handouts, have participants “raise their hand” when finished with a worksheet exercise. When asking questions, direct participants to respond in chat. When surveying the group, create challenging poll questions to check for knowledge or to get participants thinking. Refer to [chapter 4](#) for descriptions of the common tools available.

Use Your Creativity

Second, get creative when designing activities for the live online classroom. Your use of the technology tools is limited only by your imagination.

For example, if you want each person to respond to a challenging question, you could have everyone take turns in an interesting way. You could type someone's name in chat, have them respond, and then ask them to select the next person by typing the next name in chat, and so on, until everyone has been chosen. Or put unique photos onscreen, have each person select a photo with their pointer, and then reveal a question underneath each photo.

Another example of creativity is to have fun with polls. Instead of just asking review questions in a poll, create a team competition. Divide the group into teams, and invite them to quickly create a team name (they can use chat or talk verbally). Ensure that each person knows their team assignment by having the producer type each team's assignments onscreen.

Or use private chat to assign pairs. Let each person know who their partner is, and allow them to use private chat to connect with each other on

a discussion question. This activity gives every participant an opportunity to be involved in a group conversation.

[Table 11-1](#) includes more examples of creative activities.

Table 11-1. A Sampling of Engaging Activities Using Common Virtual Classroom Tools

Share documents	• Have key topic points listed on a slide. Ask participants to use the annotation tools to highlight or mark what stands out to them. Then have the facilitator use the highlighted words as the basis for discussion. • Write an incorrect fact on a slide. Have participants chat about what's incorrect, and then have them state the correct fact. • Post a topic-related puzzle or game board on a slide (such as a crossword puzzle or hangman). Have participants use the annotation tools to play the game.
Whiteboard	• Use the whiteboard to brainstorm solutions to a problem posed by the facilitator. Invite all participants to type onscreen. • Ask participants to type on the whiteboard using the annotation tools to summarize lessons learned during class. • Prepare the whiteboard with a grid and assign each participant to a specific area. Ask them to share examples of the content by drawing a relevant symbol in their assigned area.
Polling	• Ask participants to share their opinion on a topic by voting for or against it. Use the results as a discussion starter. • Use the polling or survey tool to quiz participants on any pre-class activities. Create a friendly competition by having participants track how many questions they answered correctly. • Check for knowledge transfer by periodically quizzing participants on the content and having the facilitator respond to the results.
Chat	• Have sentence starters on a slide like, "I'm surprised by..." or "I now understand...." Ask participants to

	complete the sentence by typing in a public chat window. • Ask participants to discuss a topic with an assigned partner using private chat.
Interactive discussions	• Give the participants a Buzzword Bingo game board as part of the handout package. Invite participants to play along during the class, listening for keywords related to the training topic. Invite participants to call out “bingo” as appropriate. • Ask participants to provide feedback during a mini lecture by using the virtual classroom’s raise hand or change status feature. • Have a printed handout with fill-in-the-blank spaces. Ask participants to complete the handout during the discussion.
Multimedia	• “What’s the next line?”—play short audio clips of a conversation and ask participants to tell you what the next line should be. (For example, if the class topic is how to provide feedback, the conversation would be a feedback dialogue.) • When showing a video, provide a video observation form in the handout so that participants can take notes while watching.

Adapted from Gates Corbett and Huggett (2009).

Also, use your creativity to add variety to the training class. Instead of having participants take one poll after another or respond in chat every time there’s a question, switch it up as often as possible. Keep it moving, and keep it interesting.



Noted

Remember, the point of these interactive exercises is to further the learning and achieve the objectives. It's not just about making a program “fun” or “active,” or using the platform tools just because they are there. Instead, it's about helping participants learn a new skill or change their behavior back on the job.

Close With a Call to Action

The bookend to an interactive opening is a call to action near the program's completion. Assuming the program has learning objectives that have job-related results, the virtual class should help participants apply what they have learned. A powerful close can help accomplish this goal.

One way to close an interactive program is to help participants directly apply the content to a real-world job situation. For example, if participants just learned how to have performance-related feedback discussions with their employees, then have them plan their next conversation. Or if participants learned how to negotiate agreements with customers, then have them create their own job aid to remember the negotiation tips.

Another way to close an interactive program is to have participants create an immediate action plan. What will they do right away? What will they do next week? Next month? By taking time during the program to plan their next steps, they will be more likely to achieve them. Participants can do this individually or in pair groups to increase accountability. For even more accountability, participants could be asked to report their action items back to their managers, or to report back to the facilitator.

Create Materials for Facilitators, Producers, and Participants

When you design an interactive virtual training class, it's important not to overlook the required documentation. Facilitators, producers, and participants need to have materials that set them up for success. These resources include:

- facilitator and producer guides
- platform activity components, such as slides, polls, and whiteboards

- participant materials, such as a workbook or job aids.

Facilitator and Producer Guides

Facilitator and producer guides contain an overview of the content in context of the learning objectives, explicit instructions for activities, and setup information for the program.

The guides can be fully scripted, with instructions for each speaker to “say” statements, “ask” questions, and “do” activities. Or the guide can be basic highlights or bulleted lists with general instructions for managing activities.

The guide’s instructions should include enough information for each activity to run as planned by the designer, along with timing notes and other considerations. The facilitator and producer should have enough information in their guides to make the program run smoothly. See [Figure 11-1](#) for an example.

Platform Activity Components

Most virtual class activities will need corresponding visuals and other online components to make them work. For example, a discussion activity should have a slide with discussion questions. A quiz activity needs poll questions. And an interactive whiteboard activity needs preplanned visual items created and placed on the board. In addition, videos or other multimedia might need to be created and saved in compatible file formats. In most cases, these items can (and should!) be created in advance of the virtual class.

Some platforms allow for these components to be designed and stored ahead of time. Other platforms require setup in real time, at the start of the class. Either way, the activity components need to be accounted for in the program design.

Participant Resources

Participants will benefit from having reference material related to the content. This material can be handouts and job aids that are sent to participants ahead of time, or distributed in class through file sharing within the platform.

Figure 11-1. Sample Page From a Virtual Facilitator-Producer Guide

Welcome and Introductions 10 Minutes

WELCOME participants to the program.

INTRODUCE yourself to the group.

Include the following information:

- your name
- your location
- your major responsibilities and trainer experience
- your role as facilitator of this program.

SHOW slide, “Introductions.”

HAVE participants introduce themselves using the chat window, sharing the information requested on the slide.

Comment on introductions as appropriate. Encourage participants to chat with one another, to begin building a comfortable learning environment.

SAY:

It looks like we have an eager group who is ready to learn! We will continue using the chat window, as well as the status indicators and verbal dialogue, throughout today’s session.

If needed, review how to use the status indicators (raise hand, agree, disagree, and so on) and how to send public and private chat messages.

TRANSITION:

Let’s take a moment to preview our time together.

Introductions

- Your name
- Your organization
- Your role
- Your location
- Something you hope to gain during this session



Producer Notes:

- Introduce yourself in the chat window.
- Let participants know you’re available to assist with technical issues, and how to reach you.
- Assist with feature overview as needed.

The participant resources should not be just a copy of the facilitator’s notes or slides. The slides will have activity instructions and other items

that simply won't be useful for participants' post-class reference. The best slides often make the worst handouts.

A better option is to create a useful participant handout that can be a job aid back in the workplace. Provide resources, tips, techniques, content, and information that they will actually use on the job.

Getting It Done

The design of virtual training classes directly affects participant engagement and learning transfer back on the job. Using relevant activities to capture and maintain participant attention, and to engage them in learning, will equip participants to transfer what they've learned to the workplace.

12

Present With Polish



What's Inside This Chapter

In this chapter, you'll learn:

- how to make a great first impression
- presenting with poise and confidence
- how to be authentic and stay true to your unique style.

Present With Polish

Stepping into a virtual classroom is like an actor stepping onstage for a Broadway play. The props are set, the performers are ready, and the audience waits expectantly for the curtain to open.

Before this moment, there has been tons of planning and preparation. A professional actor would never step onstage without learning their lines or rehearsing.

This is true for a virtual trainer, too.

Although the audience in a virtual classroom won't be as passive as an audience at a play, the analogy still holds true: Like an actor in a play, a virtual trainer goes through intense preparation to be ready. He can never expect to wing it.

In a virtual class, the star of the show is the virtual trainer. Even when emphasis is placed on facilitation instead of presentation, the trainer's role on the virtual stage shouldn't be forgotten or overlooked. Their online presentation skills are an essential part of the event.

What separates a good actor from a great one is their ability to connect with their audience through an authentic performance. Great actors draw in the audience, creating interest in the story line. They captivate their audiences with a smooth delivery.

Likewise, what separates a good virtual trainer from a great one are the intangible qualities of an effective presenter: one who authentically connects with their audience and creates a smooth performance.

So what does it take to be a great presenter online? It involves much of the same techniques as presenting face-to-face, but with extra professional polish. Specifically, there are seven things that the best virtual presenters do:

1. Set the stage.
2. Start on time.
3. Sound confident.

4. Script parts of their delivery.
5. Seamlessly transition.
6. Share their webcam.
7. Show their style.

Many of the items in this list have been explored earlier in the book, but in a more piecemeal format. It's now time to combine them into a polished outcome. In other words, you've got the ingredients; now it's time to pull them together to make the recipe.

Set the Stage

Setting the stage is all about advance preparation. It's about creating a welcoming learning environment for the participants, and ensuring you are ready for the event. Good virtual trainers set up in advance, but the most polished virtual trainers go one step beyond to set the stage for success.



Noted

"Most virtual presenters choose to be engaging or choose to be the expert. Great virtual presenters do both simultaneously."

—Sardek Love, President and Founder, Infinity Consulting and Training Solutions

Imagine you walk into a fancy restaurant while they are still setting the tables. You probably feel like you've come too early and you should come back later. It's the same in the virtual classroom. If your participants show up while you are still loading slides or testing audio, then they will likely feel as if they are intruding. Therefore, the most polished virtual trainers plan for participants' arrival by rolling out the virtual red carpet. They have everything set and ready to go well in advance of the start time. Even if participants come early, the classroom is ready to welcome them.

The first part of making this happen is arriving early with plenty of time to spare. As previously mentioned, virtual trainers should be logged in to the online classroom at least 30 minutes in advance. You may need extra time if you are using a platform that needs to be designed from scratch for each event, or if you have to physically change workspace locations, such as going to a conference room down the hall from your office.

The second part of making this happen is being intentional about the screen appearance when participants join. If you can simplify the login process as much as possible, and gently usher them through all necessary steps, it will help your participants feel more at ease. For example, if you have any control over the classroom's URL, then keep it short and simple. Or, if you can keep the classroom password-free, that eliminates an extra hurdle. Or, if you can use an already authenticated login process, then choose that option.

Also, the joining experience can often be simplified with a lobby-like entry. If the platform has a lobby feature, then use it to greet participants before they enter the virtual classroom. If it doesn't, then place a warm, welcoming message onscreen. Polished virtual trainers are mindful about the participants' first impressions. They use every tool at their disposal to ensure a seamless entry.

Finally, the third part of setting the stage is to verbally greet each participant as they join. Say their name to acknowledge their presence and welcome them to the room. Begin building rapport as early as possible, and demonstrate that you have been waiting for them to arrive.

Start on Time

Starting on time might seem obvious—of course a program should start at the advertised time. However, that's easier said than done. Because participants join through technology, they often don't factor in the extra time needed for connecting to the virtual classroom. Or, they simply might not recognize the importance of showing up on time.

It's a natural inclination for virtual trainers to wait for participants to join before starting the event. It seems like the polite thing to do. However, the best virtual trainers make sure their program begins on time, because it shows respect for your audience. If a program says it's scheduled to start at 10 a.m., then it should start at 10 a.m. It actually should begin earlier—as previously discussed—with a soft opening called the “start before the start.” But at minimum, the program should be under way at the advertised start time.

An on-time start demonstrates respect for those who did make the effort to join early and are ready to begin. It also demonstrates the virtual trainer's preparedness for the program. No one will falsely assume that preparations

are still under way, or think you're still scrambling behind the scenes to get things ready.

However, keep in mind that cultural considerations can influence the definition of an “on-time” start. Some cultures have a more laissez-faire attitude toward time, which means it seems completely normal for participants to arrive 15-20 minutes (or more!) after the scheduled start time. An organization's office culture might be that same way—either everyone runs from meeting to meeting without any margin in between, or it's just expected that everyone will be late.

Despite the potential cultural norm of lateness, it's important for the virtual trainer to begin on time. Even in cultures with a relaxed attitude toward time, there are still time-bound events, such as train schedules and public performances. Virtual classes fall in that category of things that should start on time.

If tardiness is part of the office culture, one way to nip this problem in the bud is to simply start on time, even if everyone is not yet connected. Participants will quickly get the message that virtual classes are different from everyday meetings.

To prepare for an on-time start, the virtual trainer needs to communicate with participants in advance to implore the importance of joining the online classroom early. They should also partner with a producer who can work with late-arriving participants to get them connected. Finally, the technique of using a soft opening—where the participants are engaged in a relevant activity—will help ensure the program is under way at the official start time.

Sound Confident

[Chapter 7](#), “Harness Your Voice,” placed emphasis on how you sound in the virtual classroom. It provided tips on the proper rate of speech, how to eliminate filler words, and breathing techniques for a solid-sounding voice. The best virtual speakers and presenters do all those things.

Outstanding professional speakers and virtual trainers take it one step further and sound confident. Whether they feel confident in the technology or in the content, they still sound it. There's a reassuring quality to their voice. This vocal self-assurance helps participants feel comfortable in the online environment. A confident virtual trainer puts participants at ease.

A confident voice has energy and enthusiasm, yet doesn't sound "sing-song-y." It doesn't rise in pitch at the end of sentences. It makes statements instead of asking questions or sounding doubtful. It emphasizes words and is expressive, yet it doesn't sound hollow.

This confident voice originates in a feeling of assuredness. It's expressed when the voice comes from deep in the belly instead of high in the nose. Employing deep-breathing techniques results in a cool, calm, collected sound. A confident voice also speaks clearly, without rambling or filler words such as *um*, *ah*, and *OK*.

Confidence creates a warm, welcoming voice. It's sincere and authentic. A virtual trainer can sound both enthusiastic and sincere by smiling. Yes, actually smiling—even though the participants may not see it. A smile goes a long way in creating a confident-sounding voice and therefore a comfortable learning environment. The virtual trainer sets this tone by the expression on their face.



Noted

"Plan, prepare, practice, and repeat! The more you have written down to follow, worked out for yourself, and the more you've done it, the more confident you'll be. Using different platforms, computers, tablets, audiences, experimenting with ways to do things, problems you resolve, supporting others—it all builds your knowledge and experience, and that's where confidence comes from."

—Jo Cook, Live Online Learning and Virtual Classroom Expert, LightbulbMoment.info

Script Parts of the Delivery

As you already know, this book focuses on virtual training classes instead of scripted presentations. There's a difference between one-way presentations and interactive virtual classes. Therefore, using a scripted facilitator guide that's intended to be read like a teleprompter is probably not the situation you're in. Even if you have a scripted guide, you're probably only expected to paraphrase the key points, without reading it word-for-word.

However, whether or not you use detailed facilitator guides, the best virtual trainers script out at least parts of each virtual class they deliver. They have taken lessons from actors and newscasters, who have mastered

the art of following a script without sounding like they are reading from one. They express their own style and emotion while saying preplanned words. They can insert their authentic selves into the text and therefore don't sound robotic. Instead, they sound articulate.

Scripting creates a polished presentation because it helps a virtual trainer sound professional. The best virtual trainers, at minimum, think through their opening comments, including the precise words they'll say at the class start time. Polished virtual trainers also plan out exactly how they will greet participants, including icebreaker questions they'll ask. Additionally, they script the questions they will ask throughout a session to facilitate discussion and enable learning. When teaching content, they rehearse their presentation in advance and know their lines backward and forward.

I rarely—if ever—script out my entire virtual class or virtual presentation. However, I do follow my own advice and write out certain parts of the program. I always use a scripted opening for the first moment or two of class. In addition, there are key sentences and preplanned phrases that I intend to say at certain points. And if I have a short story to share, I'll rehearse it in advance to ensure it's as succinct as it can be while still sharing the important, relevant details. For everything else, I use an outline form of bullet point lists. And I have practiced the program over and over, so that it's scripted in my mind instead of on paper.

Seamlessly Transition

If you've ever watched a play, then you've likely seen the stage transitions between scenes. Furniture and props are moved, actors change positions, and the dialogue flows in a way that signals a change. Some of these transitions are smoother than others. The best ones are well executed changeovers that happen in plain view but are barely noticeable. You can often tell the quality of a play by the quality of its transitions. Much thought, practice, and preparation goes into them.

Likewise, transitions are pivotal moments in a virtual training class. These transitions include moving from one topic to another, from one activity to another, or even from one screen to another. Each one should be smooth. A good transition is one that the participants need but don't notice. There's no awkward pause or disruption of program flow. Instead, the

change just easily occurs. And, it's the virtual trainer's responsibility to ensure seamless transitions.

First, participants should feel as if the program flows naturally from one topic to the next. The program design provides the class structure, but it's the virtual trainer who brings it to life in the classroom. Using appropriate words and phrases, the trainer helps the class shift from one thought to the next.

For example, a skilled virtual trainer might say, "Now that we've discussed your biggest challenge, let's learn the best solution to overcome it." Or in another spot, the trainer might say, "This is the second of the three typical customer reactions." These types of phrases help present an organized, logical flow.



Basic Rule 17

Use transitions as a way to keep your audience engaged in the content. By making connections to what they have already learned, and piquing interest in what's to come, you can directly affect their attentiveness.

These transition statements might seem to be a fundamental skill, but don't underestimate their impact. The virtual trainer's voice sets the verbal tone of the program. Their deliberate word choices during the transitions make the difference between a good program and a great one.

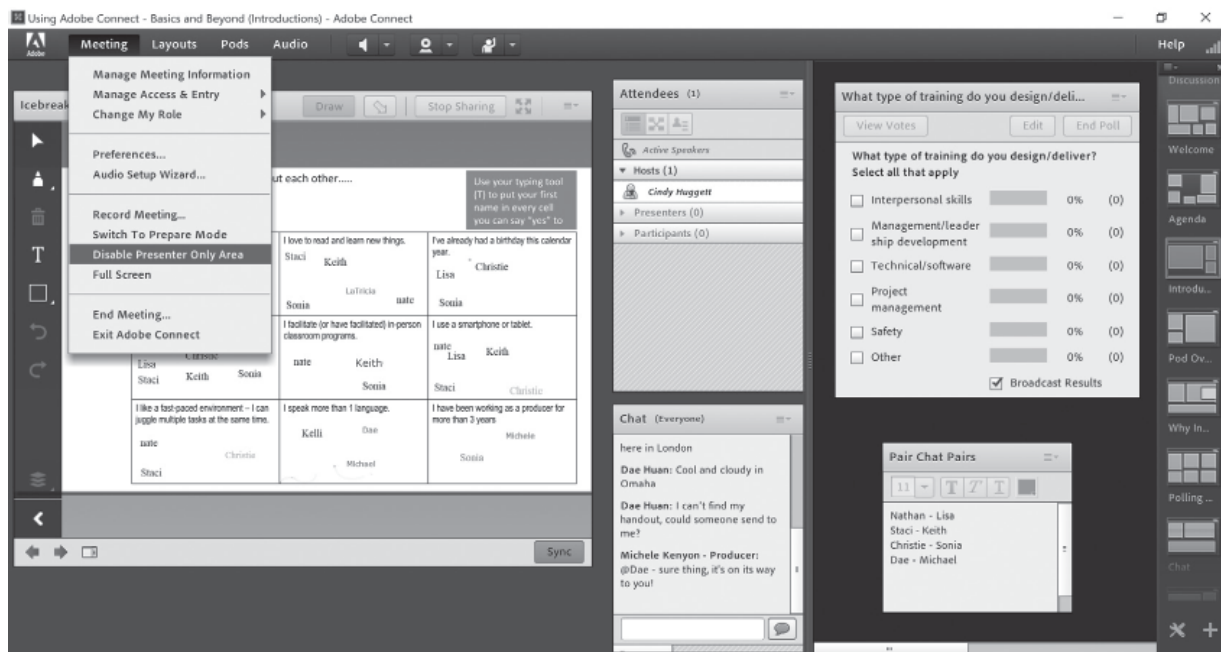
Technology also creates transition opportunities in the virtual classroom. When a trainer moves from one activity to the next, or from one visual to the next, it's a transition. Some platforms allow for easier transitions than others; it may just be one click to change the entire screen. But in other cases, the virtual trainer may have to open files or resize windows to move to the next activity.

The best virtual trainers skillfully navigate these onscreen changes. They make files open smoothly and resize windows with ease. They move windows without awkward moments or extended pauses. Participants notice the changes but don't pay attention to them, because seamless transitions don't distract from the program flow.

There are several ways to ensure smooth technology transitions. First, the virtual trainer should know the software platform well, so that they know exactly where to click. Second, they should practice the transitions until

they are easy. Third, they should partner with a producer or co-facilitator who can prepare the transitions in advance. Finally, if your platform has a “staging area,” or the ability to have multiple files open but hidden from view, then use it, so that the files are readily available (see [Figure 12-1](#) for an example). Your virtual classes will be more polished and professional if these transition tips are applied.

Figure 12-1. Adobe Connect With Presenter-Only Area Visible



Share Your Webcam

Streaming video adds an extra visual dimension to the virtual class. As long as your bandwidth supports the use of webcams, it's a nice addition to the program. When webcams are used, I prefer that everyone turn on their webcam—presenter and participants alike. But because we are focused on the professional presenter role in this chapter, let's explore how to show yourself with polish when on camera.

First and most important, set up the camera shot. Put the camera at eye level. For most of us, this means elevating your laptop onto a higher surface so that you aren't looking down at the webcam. Not adjusting the camera angle is the most frequent mistake made by virtual trainers, yet it's one of the simplest fixes. Your eyes should look straight into the lens.

On my desk, I have two computers. The first uses a large external monitor with a webcam on top. It's already at eye level, so no adjustments are needed. However, my second laptop moves around with me, and when I use it at my desk it needs to be elevated. I have a basic plastic display riser, and place my laptop on it so the camera's at eye level. When I travel and need to use my laptop's webcam in other places, I will always find something—like a stack of books or a small box—to lift the camera higher.

In addition, setting up the camera shot includes testing the webcam's position on your desk to determine how much of your body you want to show. The most common is to use a close-up view that shows only your head. But you may prefer a slightly farther away view with part of your upper body visible, or even further away, with your entire torso on screen.

Second, set the background you want viewers to see. For a professional look, have a neutral, nondescript environment that doesn't distract. Check to see what's in view of the camera and remove anything that doesn't match what you want to display. If you work in an open office environment, you'll also want to pay attention to things that could unexpectedly pop up in your background, such as co-workers walking past. It's fine for this to happen; you just want to be aware of it.

Third, place a light source in front of you. Just like when taking a still photograph, your face should look into the light for the best clarity. If you have a natural light source, such as a window, then use it. Or, place a lamp so that the light shines in your face. This lighting position will ensure no strange shadows appear on your face.

Next, test your camera connectivity in advance. Some cameras have a "preview" mode, which is nice, but it's not the only advance testing you should do. During your practice time, spend a few minutes testing your webcam's features. Learn how it works, and what preferences can be set. During the practice, get feedback from your colleagues on any changes to make.

Finally, get comfortable being on camera. Practice looking at the lens while participants are talking, so that they know you are actively listening. Put your notes in a place so you don't have to look down to see them. (Use an elevated clipboard or notes attached to your monitor). If you are self-conscious about your on-camera appearance, then simply flash your best smile. Or do whatever makes you feel comfortable—wear your favorite (solid-color) top, brush your hair, or put on makeup. Practice using the

camera until it feels natural. Your onscreen attitude will make a difference in your onscreen appearance.

Show Your Style

This book has shared many tips, techniques, and guidelines for virtual training success. They are all meant to be followed. But effective virtual training is not meant to be a cookie cutter experience.

Think of it this way: When a famous actor leaves a Broadway play and the understudy takes over, that person says exactly the same lines. But the understudy brings their own style to the character. The storyline is still the same and the audience will recognize the lines, but it's a new show.

It's the same in the virtual classroom. Each virtual trainer—even if they deliver the same exact class and follow every one of the guidelines—will have their own take on the program. Each successful program will follow a format, but each one will be distinct.

The best virtual trainers are authentic. They show their style. Unlike the actor on stage, they are not playing a part or trying to make the audience believe they are someone else.

You are who you are. Embrace your style and the strengths you bring to the virtual classroom. Follow the tried-and-true tips recommended by the experts, but do it your way. Let your personality shine through. Be authentically you in your delivery.

Getting It Done

The more prepared you are, the more confidence you'll bring to the virtual classroom. Even if you aren't feeling that confident, acting as if you've done this hundreds of times (while smiling) will convey competence to your attendees. When they sense your self-assurance, they in turn will have more confidence in the classroom.

Also, using these tips will help you present in a professional yet approachable way, which leads to a better overall learning experience. Focusing on the small but important details can take your virtual classes from good to great, allowing participants to learn new skills and apply them back on the job.

Glossary of Virtual Training Terms

Term	Description
Annotation	Drawing on top of shared documents or a whiteboard. The exact annotation tools available vary from program to program. However, most allow you to: • Draw lines and other shapes. • Draw freehand with an electronic pencil or marker. • Type text on the screen. • Highlight words or objects.
Application Sharing	Allows viewing of the presenter's desktop or other selected application. Typically used when a presenter needs to demonstrate use of a software program or show a document that's not able to be loaded into the virtual classroom due to file type limitations.
Asynchronous	Refers to learning activities that take place on the learners' own time; "self-paced" or "self-directed" learning that occurs at a time and place chosen by participants.
Audio	The ability to hear sound during a virtual class. Audio connections could be over a telephone through a conference line, or computer or device through Voice over Internet Protocol (VoIP).

Blended Learning	A training curriculum that combines multiple components and uses a variety of delivery methods. A blended learning solution might include a mix of virtual classes, coaching, and participation in a discussion board. Or, it could be a series of virtual classes with required self-paced assignments in between. It is a “blend” of various activities sequenced together to achieve a learning outcome.
Breakouts	Dividing attendees into smaller subgroups for a discussion or an activity. Participants are temporarily moved into a separate online space where they only hear participants who have been assigned to the same group. The group can share documents and whiteboards among themselves and collaborate. These documents and whiteboards can then be displayed in the main classroom room for report-outs and debrief discussion among the larger group.
Chat	The virtual classroom feature used to type text messages on screen. Usually chat is public and visible to everyone connected to the virtual class. Most platforms also allow for private chat, which gives the ability to send private messages to individual participants or confidentially to the presenter.
Co-Facilitator	A second person who shares facilitation responsibilities during a virtual class.
E-Learning	Short for <i>electronic learning</i> , referring to learning using a computer. Some people use the hyphenated spelling <i>e-learning</i> , while others run it together as <i>eLearning</i> . Both versions are widely accepted.
Face-to-Face	Refers to an in-person classroom experience, where participants and the trainer meet in the

	same room. Also called <i>in-person classes</i> , or <i>ILT (instructor-led training) classes</i> .
Facilitator	A word often used interchangeably with <i>trainer</i> . Facilitators typically focus more on discussion and dialogue instead of one-way presentation.
Facilitator Guide	A document that includes detailed instructions for the virtual trainer and producer to deliver the virtual class.
File Transfer	The virtual classroom feature that allows for file distribution to participants. Used when a trainer wants to send a document, such as a handout or job aid, electronically through the platform during a virtual class.
Host	One of the leaders in the virtual classroom. The host is sometimes called the producer or moderator. Some platforms designate a named “host” role as the session leader.
Hybrid Learning	Typically refers to a virtual class with a combination of participant connections. Some participants are in the same room as the trainer, while other participants are individually connected from other remote locations. Note that some training professionals use the phrase <i>hybrid learning</i> to refer to blended learning.
Integrated Telephony	A teleconference that is connected into the virtual classroom. When the teleconference is integrated, typical audio commands, such as mute/unmute, are available using the virtual classroom controls.
Learning Management System (LMS)	A database software program that manages training programs. It tracks participant attendance and completion of training programs. Most learning management systems can also store training materials for participant access.

Learning Objective	A statement that defines what participants should know or do as a result of participating in a virtual training class.
Moderator	Another name for <i>host</i> or <i>producer</i> in a virtual class.
Participants	Attendees in a virtual training class. Sometimes referred to as learners. Participant names are usually visible to all in a virtual classroom, although some platforms allow them to be hidden from view.
Platform	A virtual classroom software program. The features and functions available to you in the virtual classroom depend upon the software chosen. See <i>virtual classroom</i> .
Polling	The virtual classroom feature that asks questions of participants. Polls allow the trainer to ask survey questions in real time to participants. The questions can be multiple choice, multiple answer, or, in some programs, short answer.
Producer	One of the session leaders in a virtual classroom. Producers typically take responsibility for running the technology, so that the facilitator can focus on delivering the content. Producers should be experts in the virtual classroom software so they can troubleshoot any technical challenges. Producers assist participants with connecting to the virtual class and using the tools. Sometimes called a <i>host</i> or <i>moderator</i> .
Raise Hand	A participant input tool in a virtual classroom. When someone clicks on the “raise hand” button, the presenter sees a small icon next to the participants’ name indicating the “raised hand” status.
Sharing	The virtual classroom feature that allows file or

	document sharing. When a document is shared, it's visible onscreen to everyone connected to the virtual classroom. Sometimes called <i>share document</i> or <i>share file</i> .
Software Platform	See <i>platform</i> .
Start-Before-the-Start Activity	An attention-grabbing activity available onscreen when a participant first joins the virtual classroom. The activity is designed to get participants involved right away, and—if needed—teaches them how to use the platform tools.
Status Indicators	A participant input tool in a virtual classroom. Trainers can ask participants to change their status, which means they click on a button to indicate their response. The participants' chosen status is represented by small icon next to their name. Status choices typically include "raise hand," "agree," "disagree," "smile/laughter," "applause," "speed up," "slow down," and "step away."
Synchronous	Refers to a time-based learning event. In a synchronous online training class, the participants and trainer meet at a set day and time.
Telephony	A broad term referring to overall audio connection and telephone equipment used for verbal communication during a virtual class. See <i>audio</i> .
Videoconferencing	A live meeting where participants are separated by distance, yet can see and hear one another on a video screen. Videoconferencing is distinguished from virtual training because it usually has a group of people gathered around a screen, while virtual training has only one person per online connection.

VILI	An acronym for <i>virtual instructor-led training</i> .
Virtual Classroom	The online meeting “room” for a virtual training class. Virtual training uses a software program specifically designed for real-time collaboration on the web. This software application is called a virtual classroom, and is sometimes referred to as a <i>platform</i> .
Virtual Trainer	The main session leader in a virtual classroom, who is a skilled professional with a good command of the subject matter. This person enables participant learning and application back on the job. Sometimes called the <i>virtual facilitator</i> or <i>virtual presenter</i> .
Virtual Training	A highly interactive online synchronous facilitator-led class that has defined learning objectives, with participants who are connected individually from geographically dispersed locations, using a web-based virtual classroom platform.
VoIP	An acronym for <i>Voice over Internet Protocol</i> . It’s a communication method that allows for hearing audio through computer speakers and speaking into the computer’s microphone. See <i>audio</i> or <i>telephony</i> .
Webcast	A one-way presentation held online with a presenter and participants. In a webcast, there is typically little interaction between the presenter and participants, except for possible question and answer opportunities during the program. A webcast usually has a very large audience.
Webinar	A live online program that may or may not be interactive. <i>Webinar</i> is a loosely defined word that still has several meanings. Some consider it to be a highly interactive live online event, while others consider it to be the same as a passive

	webcast.
Whiteboard	A common feature found in most virtual classroom platforms. It allows the trainer and participants to draw on the screen using annotation tools.

References

- Association for Talent Development. 2017. *State of the Industry*. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.
- Association for Talent Development and Institute for Corporate Productivity. 2016. *Virtual Classrooms Now: Using Technology to Reach Today's Workforces*. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.
- Biech, E. 2005. *Training for Dummies*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.
- Cassidy, J., and B.C. Rimbeaux. 1994. *Juggling for the Complete Klutz*. Palo Alto, CA: Klutz Press.
- Clark, R.C., and A. Kwinn. 2007. *The New Virtual Classroom: Evidence-Based Guidelines for Synchronous e-Learning*. San Francisco: Pfeiffer.
- Cross, J. 2015. "The Rise of Informal Learning." eLearning Industry, October 20. <https://elearningindustry.com/rise-of-informal-learning>.
- Gates Corbett, W., and C. Huggett. 2009. "Designing for the Virtual Classroom." *Infoline*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- Hofmann, J. 2004. "Teaching Online Is Like Teaching After Lunch." *T+D* 58(1): 19-21.
- Huggett, C. 2014. *The Virtual Training Guidebook: How to Design, Deliver, and Implement Live Online Learning*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- . 2017. *Virtual Training Tools and Templates: An Action Guide to Live Online Learning*. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.
- Huggett, C., and W. Gates Corbett. 2008. "Simple, Effective, Online Training." *Infoline*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.

Pike, R. 2003. *Creative Training Techniques Handbook*. 3rd ed. Amherst, MA: HRD Press.

Wells, L.K. 1999. *The Articulate Voice*. 3rd ed. Needham Heights, MA: Allyn & Bacon.

Additional Resources

This book outlines the steps to virtual training success. By following these tips and techniques, you will become more effective at delivering online training. However, your quest doesn't—and shouldn't—stop there. Due to the rapid pace of change with technology, I encourage you to continue learning about virtual classroom software programs and their evolving features. The following resources will assist you in your journey.

Publications

Biech, E. 2014. *ASTD Handbook: The Definitive Reference for Training & Development*. 2nd ed. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.

———. 2016. *The Art and Science of Training*. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.

Carnes, B. 2013. *Making eLearning Stick: Techniques for Easy and Effective Transfer of Technology-Supported Training*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.

Christopher, D. 2011. "Facilitating in the Global Virtual Classroom." *Infoline*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.

———. 2014. *The Successful Virtual Classroom: How to Design and Facilitate Interactive and Engaging Live Online Learning*. New York: AMACOM.

Clay, C. 2012. *Great Webinars: How to Create Interactive Learning That Is Captivating, Informative, and Fun*. San Francisco: Pfeiffer.

- Colvin Clark, R., and A. Kwinn. 2007. *The New Virtual Classroom: Evidence-Based Guidelines for Synchronous e-Learning*. San Francisco: Pfeiffer.
- Colvin Clark, R., and R.E. Mayer. 2016. *E-Learning and the Science of Instruction: Proven Guidelines for Consumers and Designers of Multimedia Learning*. 4th ed. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.
- Courville, R. 2009. *The Virtual Presenter's Handbook*.
www.eventbuilder.rocks/the-virtual-presenters-handbook.
- Dirksen, J. 2015. *Design for How People Learn*. 2nd ed. Berkeley, CA: New Riders.
- Elkeles, T., J.J. Phillips, and P.P. Phillips. 2014. *Measuring the Success of Learning Through Technology: A Guide for Measuring Impact and Calculating ROI on E-Learning, Blended Learning, and Mobile Learning*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- Gates Corbett, W., and C. Huggett. 2009 "Designing for the Virtual Classroom." *Infoline*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- Halls, J. 2014. "Memory and Cognition in Learning." *Infoline*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- Hodell, C. 2015. *ISD From the Ground Up: A No-Nonsense Approach to Instructional Design*. 4th edition. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.
- Hofmann, J. 2004. *Live and Online!: Tips, Techniques, and Ready-to-Use Activities for the Virtual Classroom*. San Francisco: Pfeiffer.
- . 2004. *The Synchronous Trainer's Survival Guide: Facilitating Successful Live and Online Courses, Meetings, and Events*. San Francisco: Pfeiffer.
- Hofmann, J., and N. Miner. 2009. *Tailored Learning: Designing the Blend That Fits*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- Huggett, C. 2014. *The Virtual Training Guidebook: How to Design, Deliver, and Implement Live Online Learning*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- . 2017. *Virtual Training Tools and Templates: An Action Guide to Live Online Learning*. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.

- Huggett, C., and W. Gates Corbett. 2009. "Simple, Effective, Online Training." *Infoline*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- Koegel, T.J. 2010. *The Exceptional Presenter Goes Virtual*. Austin, TX: Greenleaf Press.
- LaBorie, K., and T. Stone. 2015. *Interact and Engage!: 50+ Activities for Virtual Training, Meetings, and Webinars*. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.
- Murdoch, M., and T. Muller. 2013. *The Webinar Manifesto: Never Design, Deliver, or Sell Lousy Webinars Again*. New York: RosettaBooks.
- Phillips, P.P., ed. 2010. *ASTD Handbook of Measuring and Evaluating Training*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.
- Pike, R.W. 2015. *Master Trainer Handbook: Tips, Tactics, and How-Tos for Delivering Effective Instructor-Led, Participant-Centered Training*. 4th ed. Amherst, MA: HRD Press.
- Pike Pluth, B. 2010. *Webinars With WOW Factor: Tips, Tricks and Interactive Activities for Virtual Training*. Minneapolis: Pluth Consulting.
- . 2016. *Creative Training: A Train-the-Trainer Field Guide*. Minneapolis: Creative Training Productions.
- Reynolds, G. *Presentation Zen: Simple Ideas on Presentation Design and Delivery*. 2nd ed. Berkeley, CA: New Riders.
- Scannell, M., M. Abrams, and M. Mulvihill. 2011. *The Big Book of Virtual Team Building Games: Quick, Effective Activities to Build Communication, Trust, and Collaboration From Anywhere!* New York: McGraw-Hill.
- Shank, P. 2011. *The Online Learning Idea Book: Proven Ways to Enhance Technology-Based and Blended Learning*. Vol. 2. San Francisco: Pfeiffer.
- Smith, D. 2016. "6 Steps to Moving Your Training Online." *TD at Work*. Alexandria, VA: ATD Press.
- Turmel, W. 2011. *10 Steps to Successful Virtual Presentations*. Alexandria, VA: ASTD Press.

A Selected List of Virtual Classroom Software Vendors

Here are a few examples of common virtual classroom software platforms.
Please note that this is not an exhaustive list.

Adobe Connect: www.adobe.com/products/adobeconnect

AirClass by Lenovo: www.airclass.com

Blackboard Collaborate:
www.blackboard.com/platforms/collaborate/overview.aspx

Cisco WebEx Training Center: www.webex.com/products/elearning-and-online-training.html

GoToTraining: www.gototraining.com

Jigsaw: <http://jigsawme.com>

Saba Classroom: www.saba.com/us/lms/virtual-classroom

Zoom: <https://zoom.us>

Trademark Attributions

Adobe, Flash, and Adobe Connect are either registered trademarks or trademarks of Adobe Systems Incorporated in the United States and/or other countries.

Cisco WebEx Meeting Center, Event Center, and Training Center are trademarks of Cisco Systems Inc. and/or one or more of its subsidiaries, and may be registered in the United States Patent and Trademark Office and in other countries.

Microsoft and Microsoft Office are either registered trademarks or trademarks of Microsoft Corporation in the United States and/or other countries.

About the Author

Cindy Huggett, CPLP, is an independent consultant, professional speaker, instructional designer, classroom facilitator, and author who specializes in workplace training and development. With more than 25 years of experience, Cindy has successfully designed curriculums, facilitated classes, and led training rollouts in almost every industry and every size organization.



She partners with her clients to help them transition from the face-to-face to the virtual classroom, and works with them to design online and blended learning solutions.

Cindy is the author of three books on virtual training: *Virtual Training Tools and Templates: An Action Guide to Live Online Learning* (2017); *The*

Virtual Training Guidebook: How to Design, Deliver, and Implement Live Online Learning (2013), and *Virtual Training Basics*, 1st edition (2010). She is the co-author of two *Infoline* issues, “Simple, Effective Online Learning” (2008) and “Designing for the Virtual Classroom” (2009). She’s also contributed to several compilations, including the *ASTD Handbook: The Definitive Reference for Training & Development* and *101 Ways to Make Learning Active Beyond the Classroom*, and written several articles for *T+D* magazine.

Cindy holds a master’s degree in public and international affairs from the University of Pittsburgh, and a bachelor’s degree from James Madison University. Cindy is also a past member of the ATD National board of directors and was one of the first to earn the Certified Professional in Learning and Performance (CPLP) designation.

Cindy lives in Raleigh, North Carolina, with her husband, Bobby, and four-year-old son, Jonathan. You can find Cindy sharing training tips on twitter as @cindyhugg, or on her website, www.cindyhuggett.com.

It's a digital world; is your training up to speed?

E-learning has been around since the late 90s, but it continually evolves. Sometimes it may seem impossible to keep up—but your learners need courses they can take anywhere, organizations need to save money and time on travel, and everyone needs your material to be as current as possible.

Refresh and build your virtual training skills with this new edition of *Virtual Training Basics* by Cindy Huggett. You don't have to be a tech wizard to follow her proven techniques. *Virtual Training Basics* will get you started with the fundamentals of virtual training, and then take you through preparation and delivery, with updated material and two new chapters on designing and presenting interactive courses that will keep learners engaged.

A Complete How-to Guide to Help You:

- Use tips from a variety of seasoned trainers.
- Gain insight into the differences (and similarities) between in-person and virtual training.
- Understand the fundamentals of virtual training design.

Part of ATD's Training Basics series, *Virtual Training Basics* will help you build and refine your virtual training skills.

Praise for This Book

"*Virtual Training Basics* is essential reading for trainers taking their skills into the virtual classroom. Drawing on her extensive experience as a pioneer in virtual learning, Cindy has loaded this book with practical resources and checklists to help the virtual trainer hit the ground running."

—Jonathan Halls

Learning Specialist and Author, *Rapid Media Development for Trainers*

"Knowing the basics of virtual training is essential to its success, but learning them is not simple. The first edition of Cindy's *Virtual Training Basics* was a game changer, making learning to train and present online easily accessible to everyone! I'm thrilled we now have an updated version of this handy resource for our virtual training strategies."

—Kassy LaBorie

Author, *Interact and Engage!*

"I guarantee that if you read this book, you'll find dozens of innovative and actionable ideas to show you how to get started in virtual training. This updated edition is a comprehensive, authoritative, and well-organized guide, and a must-read for training professionals who want to deliver virtual classes."

—Darlene Christopher

Author, *The Successful Virtual Classroom*

Senior Knowledge and Learning Officer at the World Bank

atd
PRESS
www.td.org/books